

U.S. Metro Economic Health Report

50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas

Percentile-Based Composite Scoring · 8 Metrics · BLS & FRED Data
85% Employment / 15% Housing · August 2026

TOP PERFORMERS

#1	A+	Salt Lake City	77.3
#2	A+	Raleigh	76.6
#3	A+	Cincinnati	73.7
#4	A+	Hartford	69.7
#5	A+	Charlotte	68.6
#6	A+	Kansas City	68.4
#7	A	St. Louis	63.5

MARKETS UNDER PRESSURE

#50	D	Louisville	20.8
#49	C-	Chicago	28.0
#48	C-	Grand Rapids	28.9
#47	C-	Sacramento	29.5
#46	C-	Detroit	29.5
#45	C-	Richmond	30.9
#44	C	Jacksonville	33.4

GRADE DISTRIBUTION

A+ / A / A-	10 cities
B+ / B / B-	22 cities
C+ / C / C-	17 cities
D	1 cities

Data sources: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS) · Federal Reserve Economic Data (FRED)
Unemployment, CLF Growth, Earnings, Employment, Weekly Hours sourced from BLS LAUS / SAE.
Building Permits from Census Bureau via FRED. Days on Market from Realtor.com / FRED.

Scoring methodology: percentile ranking across all 50 metros.
Full methodology: SCORING_README.md
Pipeline runs weekly via GitHub Actions.

Full Rankings

All 50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas · Sorted by composite score · August 2026

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	CLF YOY	DOM
1	Salt Lake City Salt Lake City-Murray	A+	77.3	3.6%	+4.6%	+3.2%	+1.0%	54 days
2	Raleigh Raleigh-Cary	A+	76.6	3.1%	+3.4%	+2.1%	+0.4%	54 days
3	Cincinnati Cincinnati	A+	73.7	3.9%	+7.2%	+1.0%	+0.1%	40 days
4	Hartford Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford	A+	69.7	2.7%	+5.2%	+1.9%	+2.8%	33 days
5	Charlotte Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia	A+	68.6	3.6%	+4.1%	+1.4%	+0.3%	57 days
6	Kansas City Kansas City	A+	68.4	3.7%	+7.4%	+0.7%	+0.5%	47 days
7	St. Louis St. Louis	A	63.5	3.8%	+2.8%	+0.5%	+0.7%	44 days
8	Austin Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos	A-	62.0	4.1%	+4.8%	+1.7%	+1.3%	67 days
9	Orlando Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford	A-	61.3	4.6%	+5.8%	+1.1%	+1.7%	74 days
10	Nashville Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin	A-	60.6	3.3%	+4.7%	+1.6%	-0.1%	58 days
11	Las Vegas Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas	B+	58.4	5.2%	+4.0%	+1.4%	+0.2%	57 days
12	San Jose San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara	B+	58.1	4.0%	+0.5%	+1.3%	-0.6%	40 days
13	Memphis Memphis	B+	57.9	4.8%	+6.6%	+0.1%	-1.4%	66 days
14	Philadelphia Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington	B+	57.3	4.1%	+1.5%	+0.7%	+2.0%	44 days
15	Dallas Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington	B+	57.0	4.7%	+3.4%	+1.3%	+0.7%	54 days
16	Pittsburgh Pittsburgh	B+	55.5	3.8%	+4.5%	-0.0%	+2.5%	50 days
17	Seattle Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue	B	54.8	5.0%	+5.8%	+0.8%	-1.0%	44 days
18	Tampa Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater	B	53.9	4.7%	+5.3%	+0.6%	+0.5%	72 days
19	Baltimore Baltimore-Columbia-Towson	B	53.7	4.0%	+4.9%	-0.1%	+1.2%	39 days
20	Columbus Columbus	B	51.6	3.3%	+3.3%	+0.0%	-0.4%	40 days
21	Atlanta Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell	B-	49.9	3.5%	+3.0%	-0.1%	+1.9%	56 days
22	Oklahoma City Oklahoma City	B-	49.4	4.2%	+4.9%	+0.4%	-0.0%	52 days
23	New York New York Newark-Jersey City	B-	49.1	4.5%	+1.9%	+1.0%	+1.2%	53 days
24	Houston Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands	B-	47.6	5.2%	+1.7%	+1.5%	+0.9%	50 days

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	CLF YOY	DOM
25	San Francisco San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont	B-	47.3	4.2%	+6.0%	+0.2%	-1.6%	39 days
26	Los Angeles Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim	B-	47.2	5.0%	+3.5%	+1.8%	-2.2%	52 days
27	Cleveland Cleveland	B-	46.2	3.4%	+0.1%	+0.6%	+1.8%	55 days
28	Birmingham Birmingham	B-	46.0	3.7%	+0.6%	+0.7%	-0.3%	58 days
29	Denver Denver-Aurora-Centennial	B-	45.2	3.9%	+1.9%	+0.3%	-2.1%	51 days
30	Washington DC Washington-Arlington-Alexandria	B-	45.0	4.1%	+5.3%	-2.1%	-1.7%	39 days
31	Providence Providence-Warwick	B-	44.7	4.3%	+2.8%	+0.6%	+1.7%	38 days
32	Boston Boston-Cambridge-Newton	B-	44.1	3.9%	+2.9%	+0.3%	+2.9%	46 days
33	San Diego San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad	C+	43.7	4.4%	+6.7%	+0.5%	-1.3%	45 days
34	Fresno Fresno	C+	43.3	7.7%	+5.1%	+2.5%	-1.7%	55 days
35	Miami Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach	C+	43.1	3.9%	+7.0%	+0.5%	-0.1%	85 days
36	Virginia Beach Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk	C+	42.9	4.0%	+5.5%	-0.7%	-1.1%	39 days
37	Phoenix Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler	C+	41.8	4.9%	+2.6%	+1.2%	-2.7%	67 days
38	Milwaukee Milwaukee-Waukesha	C+	40.9	3.8%	+1.5%	-0.1%	+1.7%	35 days
39	Riverside Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario	C+	38.6	5.3%	+6.0%	+0.8%	-1.9%	61 days
40	San Antonio San Antonio-New Braunfels	C	37.6	4.8%	+2.2%	+0.8%	+0.2%	65 days
41	Portland Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro	C	36.5	5.0%	+5.3%	-1.4%	-0.8%	57 days
42	Minneapolis Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington	C	36.3	4.4%	-0.1%	+1.4%	-1.0%	38 days
43	Indianapolis Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood	C	33.8	3.4%	+0.1%	-1.2%	+0.2%	47 days
44	Jacksonville Jacksonville	C	33.4	4.8%	+0.4%	+0.4%	+0.8%	63 days
45	Richmond Richmond	C-	30.9	3.8%	+2.5%	-0.8%	-0.8%	40 days
46	Detroit Detroit-Warren-Dearborn	C-	29.5	5.4%	+0.6%	+0.2%	+2.7%	39 days
47	Sacramento Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom	C-	29.5	4.8%	+1.1%	+0.3%	-1.4%	46 days
48	Grand Rapids Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood	C-	28.9	4.2%	+1.8%	+0.5%	-8.8%	37 days
49	Chicago Chicago-Naperville-Elgin	C-	28.0	5.3%	+3.1%	+0.2%	-0.5%	35 days
50	Louisville Louisville-Jefferson County	D	20.8	5.2%	+1.6%	-0.1%	+0.1%	43 days

Salt Lake City

Salt Lake City-Murray

A+

EXCELLENT

77.3th percentile

Rank 1 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		96
25% weight		
Unemployment		80
20% weight		
Wage Growth		60
15% weight		
Cost of Living		53
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		72
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		88
10% weight		
Days on Market		62
5% weight		
Office Economy		96
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.6% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +4.6% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +3.2% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY +1.0% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS +40.1% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 54 days median, +3.9% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL GROWING Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area boasts an overall grade of A+ with a composite score ranking in the 77.3th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its exceptional labor demand, with a top-tier composite score of 7.70, and its strong office economy, ranking in the 96th percentile. The combination of a 3.20% employment growth rate and a -0.796% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend suggests genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area has seen a 3.20% employment growth rate year-over-year, paired with a -0.796% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing a surge in job creation, with hours worked remaining relatively stable. The labor demand composite score of 7.70 further reinforces this notion, ranking in the top tier at the 96th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Salt Lake City-Murray stands at 3.60%, ranking in the top tier at the 80th percentile. This tight labor market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is relatively small. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive wages to attract top talent in this market.

Wage Growth

The city has experienced a 4.60% year-over-year wage growth rate, ranking above average at the 60th percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a manageable pace. Meanwhile, workers are seeing an increase in their purchasing power, which can have a positive impact on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of 6.71, based on \$265 per square foot and \$39.49 per hour, Salt Lake City-Murray ranks near the median at the 53rd percentile. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. The fact that PSF is rising by 1.1% year-over-year, however, may impact future affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Salt Lake City-Murray has grown by 0.96% year-over-year, ranking above average at the 72nd percentile. This expansion in labor force supply suggests that the city has a growing pool of potential workers, making it easier for businesses to hire and expand their operations.

Building Permits

The city has seen a 40.08% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, ranking in the top tier at the 88th percentile. This surge in permits indicates that housing supply is expanding, which can lead to improved affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market currently stands at 54 days, with a 3.9% year-over-year increase. This suggests that the housing market is normalizing, becoming slightly more accessible for relocating workers. However, the relatively fast pace of sales still indicates a competitive market.

Office Economy

Salt Lake City-Murray boasts a deep professional talent pool, ranking in the top tier at the 96th percentile. This makes the city an ideal location for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require specialized knowledge-economy workers. Conversely, the city may be less suited for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, a deep professional talent pool, and a relatively affordable cost of living. However, the tight labor market and rising wages may pose challenges for companies looking to hire and expand in this location, making it essential for decision-makers to factor in these constraints when considering Salt Lake City-Murray as a potential business location.

Raleigh

Raleigh-Cary

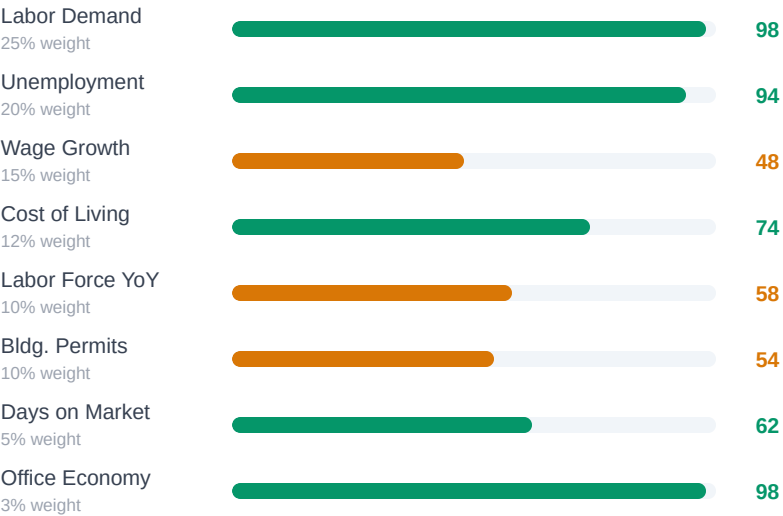
A+

EXCELLENT

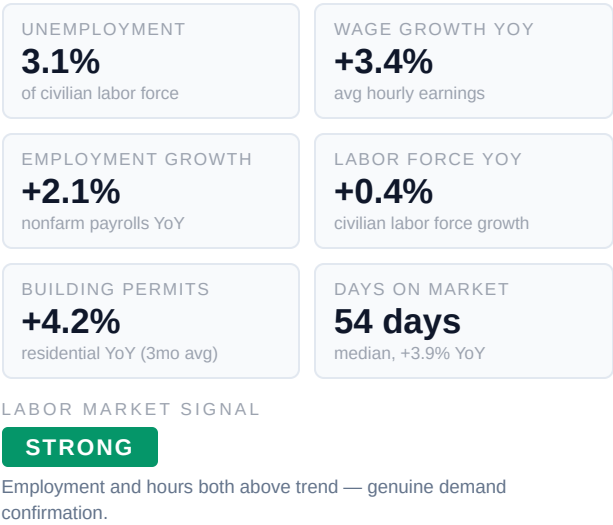
76.6th percentile

Rank 2 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Raleigh-Cary metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score ranking in the 76.6th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its exceptionally strong labor demand, with a top-tier composite score of 98th percentile, driven by a 2.07% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 1.137% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend. Additionally, its low unemployment rate of 3.10% and high office economy percentile rank of 98th also play significant roles in shaping its economic landscape.

Labor Demand

The Raleigh-Cary metro area exhibits a robust labor demand, with a 2.07% year-over-year employment growth rate and weekly hours 1.137% above its own trend, signaling genuine demand expansion. This combination indicates that the city is experiencing a significant increase in job creation, with workers putting in more hours, suggesting a thriving economy. The labor demand composite score of 8.33 further reinforces this assessment, ranking in the top tier at the 98th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Raleigh-Cary stands at 3.10%, which is relatively low, indicating a tight labor market. This tight market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. With an unemployment rate percentile rank of 94th, the market has little slack, making it a competitive environment for employers.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Raleigh-Cary is 3.43%, which is near the median, suggesting moderate wage increases. This rate of wage growth implies that employer labor costs are rising, but at a manageable pace, while workers are experiencing an increase in purchasing power. However, the 48th percentile rank in wage growth indicates that the city is not an outlier in terms of wage pressure, with many other metros experiencing similar or higher rates of growth.

Cost of Living

Raleigh-Cary has a cost of living percentile rank of 74th, indicating that it is more affordable than many of its peer cities, with a PSF to earnings ratio of \$217/sqft to \$37.64/hr, or 5.77. The fact that PSF is falling by 2.2% year-over-year relative to wages further enhances the city's affordability. This affordability advantage can be a significant talent attraction factor, as businesses can offer competitive wages without needing large premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Raleigh-Cary is growing at a year-over-year rate of 0.37%, which, while positive, indicates a relatively slow expansion of the workforce supply. This slow growth suggests that hiring capacity may be somewhat constrained, as the pool of potential workers is not increasing rapidly. However, the 58th percentile rank in labor force growth indicates that the city is not uniquely challenged in this regard, with many metros experiencing similar or slower growth rates.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Raleigh-Cary is +4.15%, indicating a moderate expansion of housing supply. This increase in permits suggests that developer confidence is present, and the future housing supply is likely to improve, which can help maintain or improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. The 54th percentile rank in building permits growth, however, indicates that the city is not leading in terms of housing supply expansion.

Days on Market

The current median days on market for homes in Raleigh-Cary is 54 days, with a year-over-year increase of 3.9%, placing it at the 62nd percentile. This increase in days on market, combined with the absolute level, suggests a slightly slower and more accessible market for relocating workers, providing them with more time to find suitable housing. However, the market remains relatively competitive, and relocating workers may still face challenges in finding homes quickly.

Office Economy

Raleigh-Cary boasts a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy percentile rank of 98th, indicating a strong presence of jobs in professional and office sectors. This makes the city highly suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions, where access to specialized knowledge workers is crucial. Conversely, it may be less ideal for industries that are more industrial or logistics-dominant, which require different types of workforce skills.

The Raleigh-Cary metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, low unemployment, and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for certain types of industries. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to factor in is the potential for hiring challenges due to the tight labor market, which may necessitate offering competitive wages to attract and retain talent.

Cincinnati

Cincinnati

A+

EXCELLENT

73.7th percentile

Rank 3 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		48
25% weight		
Unemployment		92
20% weight		
Wage Growth		96
15% weight		
Cost of Living		90
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		48
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		76
10% weight		
Days on Market		88
5% weight		
Office Economy		44
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.9% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +7.2% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +1.0% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY +0.1% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS +24.8% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 40 days median, +8.1% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL GROWING Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cincinnati earns an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 73.7th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its exceptionally low unemployment rate of 3.90% and strong wage growth of +7.22% year-over-year, indicating a tight labor market with rising labor costs. These metrics suggest a competitive environment for businesses looking to hire and retain top talent.

Labor Demand

Cincinnati's employment growth rate stands at +0.97% year-over-year, while weekly hours are -0.372% below trend, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 5.29, near the median. This combination signals a moderate expansion of genuine demand, as the city is adding jobs, albeit with hours slightly below trend. The labor market is growing, but not at an accelerated pace.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Cincinnati is 3.90%, placing it in the top tier at the 92nd percentile. This indicates a very tight labor market with little slack, making it challenging for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, companies may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain talent in this competitive environment.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Cincinnati is +7.22% year-over-year, ranking it in the top tier at the 96th percentile. This rapid wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers, which can be a challenge for businesses. However, it also translates to increased purchasing power for workers, potentially boosting local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Cincinnati's cost of living is relatively affordable, with a PSF of \$192/sqft and hourly earnings of \$35.56, resulting in a ratio of 5.40. The city's cost of living percentile rank is 90th, indicating it is more affordable than most peers. This affordability advantage can attract talent without requiring significant wage premiums, making it an attractive location for businesses.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Cincinnati is growing at a rate of +0.14% year-over-year, near the median. This slow growth indicates a slightly expanding workforce supply, which can support hiring needs, but may not be sufficient to meet rapid demand growth.

Building Permits

Residential building permits in Cincinnati are increasing by +24.76% year-over-year, above the average. This rise in permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which can improve affordability and support workforce growth in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Cincinnati is 40 days, with an 8.1% year-over-year increase. This indicates a relatively slow market, ranked in the top tier at the 88th percentile. For workers relocating to Cincinnati, this means a more accessible and less competitive housing market.

Office Economy

Cincinnati's professional and office worker share is near the median, ranking at the 44th percentile. This suggests a moderate depth of talent pool, making it suitable for a variety of businesses, but potentially less ideal for those requiring a highly specialized or deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies.

In conclusion, Cincinnati offers businesses a unique combination of low unemployment, strong wage growth, and affordability, making it an attractive location for talent attraction and retention. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential for rising labor costs due to the tight labor market and rapid wage growth, which may impact business profitability and competitiveness.

Hartford

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford

A+

EXCELLENT

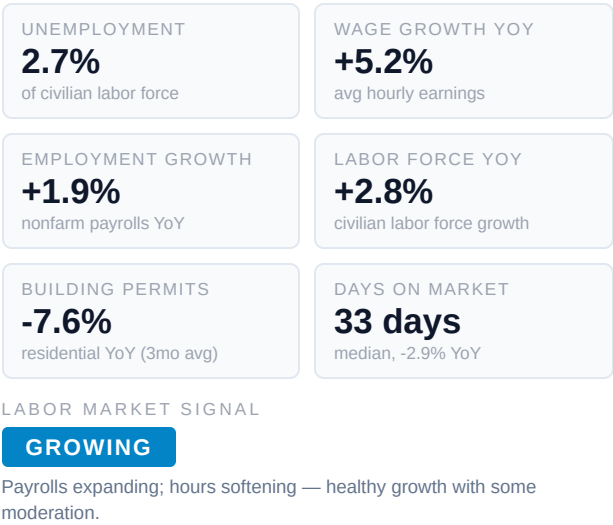
69.7th percentile

Rank 4 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score ranking in the 69.7th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its exceptionally low unemployment rate of 2.70% and its strong labor demand composite score of 6.61, which ranks in the 88th percentile. The combination of a high employment growth rate and low unemployment suggests a highly competitive job market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is +1.88% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.321% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are not excessively above trend despite strong job growth, indicating that the labor market is absorbing new jobs without overburdening existing workers. The labor demand composite score of 6.61 reinforces this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is 2.70%, ranking in the 98th percentile, which means the job market is extremely tight. This tight market implies that businesses may face significant challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is limited, and wage pressure is likely to be high. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is +5.21%, ranking in the 72nd percentile. This moderate to fast wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, while worker purchasing power is increasing. As a result, businesses may need to factor in higher labor costs, but they can also benefit from a more affluent local consumer base.

Cost of Living

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford has a cost of living ratio of \$253/sqft to \$39.67/hr, with a percentile rank of 22, indicating that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The PSF is rising 4.1% year-over-year, which further exacerbates the affordability issue. This means that the city may struggle to attract talent without offering wage premiums to offset the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is growing at a rate of +2.77% year-over-year, ranking in the 96th percentile. This rapid labor force growth indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire. The increasing labor pool provides a structural tailwind for hiring and talent acquisition.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford has decreased by -7.56% year-over-year, ranking in the 38th percentile. This decline in building permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. As a result, businesses may need to consider the potential impact on their employees' ability to find affordable housing.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is 33 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -2.9%. This fast-paced market means that homes are selling quickly, making it challenging for relocating workers to find available housing. The low days on market percentile rank of 4 indicates a highly competitive housing market, which may require businesses to provide relocation assistance or other incentives to attract talent.

Office Economy

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford has an office economy percentile rank of 34, indicating a relatively shallow professional talent pool. This city is best suited for businesses that do not require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics companies. However, it may not be the ideal location for tech, finance, or consulting firms that rely on a specialized workforce.

The Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford metro area offers businesses a highly competitive job market with strong labor demand and low unemployment. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the relatively expensive cost of living, which may require wage premiums to attract and retain talent. Despite this challenge, the city's expanding labor force and growing economy make it an attractive location for businesses looking to establish or expand their operations.

Charlotte

Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia

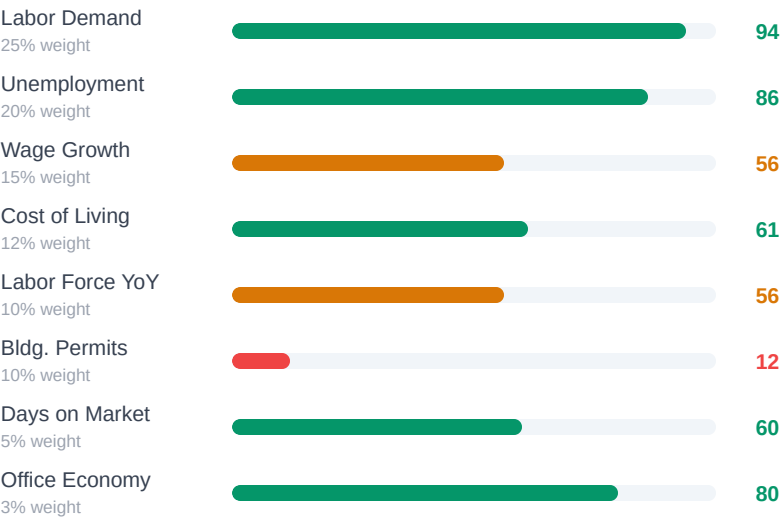
A+

EXCELLENT

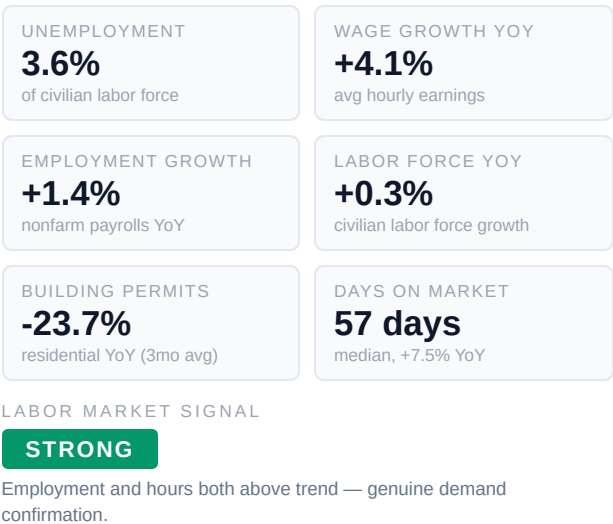
68.6th percentile

Rank 5 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area has earned an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 68.6th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. The city's economic character is largely defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score of 7.35, and its low unemployment rate of 3.60%, which signals a tight labor market. These metrics, combined with a top-tier employment growth rate of +1.36% and weekly hours deviation of +1.141%, indicate a city with genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +1.36% and weekly hours deviation of +1.141% signal a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion. This combination indicates that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, suggesting a healthy and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 7.35, ranked in the top tier at the 94th percentile, further reinforces this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 3.60% is relatively low, ranking in the top tier at the 86th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with limited slack. This means that businesses may face challenges in finding and hiring qualified workers, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate also suggests that workers have more bargaining power, which could drive up labor costs.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +4.14% is moderate, ranking near the median at the 56th percentile. This rate suggests that labor costs are rising, but not excessively so, and that workers are seeing some improvement in their purchasing power. However, the moderate wage growth may not be sufficient to keep pace with the low unemployment rate and tight labor market.

Cost of Living

The city's cost of living, with a PSF of \$220/sqft and an earnings ratio of \$37.80/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.82, is relatively affordable, ranking above average at the 61st percentile. This means that the city has a talent attraction advantage, as workers can afford to live and work in the area without requiring significant wage premiums. The fact that PSF is falling by -0.5% YoY further enhances the city's affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of +0.33% year-over-year, which is near the median at the 56th percentile. This indicates that the labor force supply is expanding, albeit slowly, which should help to alleviate some of the hiring challenges posed by the tight labor market. However, the slow growth rate may not be sufficient to keep pace with the city's job growth.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -23.67%, which is a significant decline, ranking in the bottom tier at the 12th percentile. This suggests that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability challenges and make it more difficult for workers to relocate to the area. The decline in building permits is a concern for businesses that rely on a steady supply of new talent.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 57 days, with a year-over-year increase of +7.5%, ranking above average at the 60th percentile. This indicates that the housing market is slowing down, making it more accessible for workers to relocate to the area. However, the relatively fast pace of sales still suggests a competitive market, which may require businesses to offer relocation assistance or other incentives to attract talent.

Office Economy

The city's professional and office worker share is 3.36, ranking in the top tier at the 80th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This makes the city an attractive location for businesses that require specialized knowledge workers. However, the city may be less suited for industries that require a large workforce with more general skills.

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion, a tight labor market with limited slack, and a relatively affordable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses is the tightening housing supply, which could lead to future affordability challenges and make it more difficult to attract and retain talent.

Kansas City

Kansas City

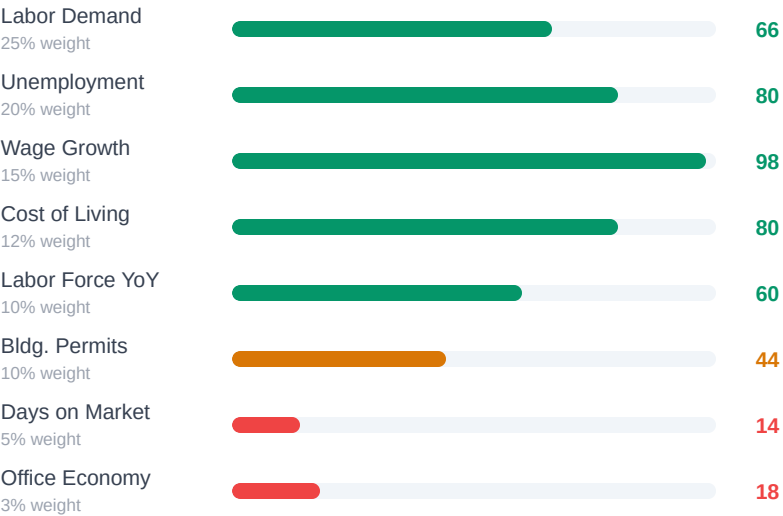
A+

EXCELLENT

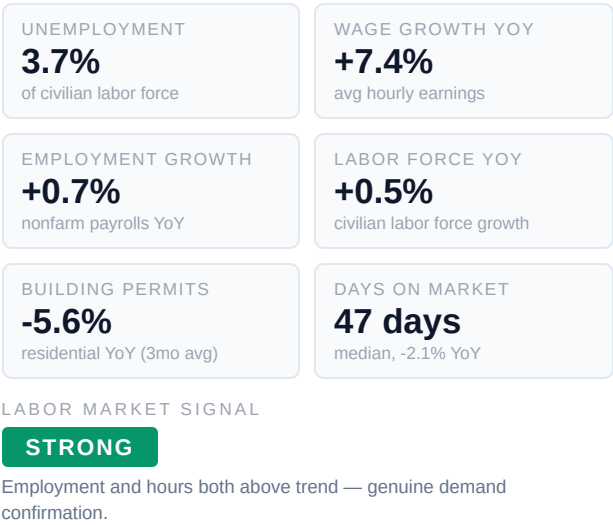
68.4th percentile

Rank 6 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Kansas City earns an overall grade of A+ with a composite score of 68.4th percentile, ranking it among the top US metros. The city's economic character is largely defined by its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 7.38%, and its low unemployment rate of 3.70%, which ranks in the 80th percentile. These metrics suggest a highly competitive labor market with rising labor costs.

Labor Demand

Kansas City's employment growth rate of 0.69% and weekly hours deviation of 0.321% above its own trend indicate genuine demand expansion, signaling that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours. This combination suggests a strong labor market with increasing demand for workers. The labor demand composite score of 5.59, ranking in the 66th percentile, further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The city's unemployment rate of 3.70% is relatively low, ranking in the 80th percentile, which means the labor market is tight. This tight market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as workers have more bargaining power and may command higher wages. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of 7.38%, Kansas City is experiencing rapid wage increases, ranking in the 98th percentile. This fast wage growth will lead to rising labor costs for employers, but it also means that workers will have increased purchasing power, benefiting local businesses that rely on consumer spending.

Cost of Living

Kansas City's cost of living, with a PSF of \$197/sqft and an earnings ratio of \$36.13/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.45, ranks in the 80th percentile, indicating that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers. This affordability advantage will help attract talent without requiring significant wage premiums, making it an attractive location for businesses.

Labor Force Growth

The city's labor force is growing at a rate of 0.50% year-over-year, ranking in the 60th percentile, which means that the workforce supply is expanding. This growth in the labor force will provide businesses with a larger pool of potential employees, making it easier to hire and staff operations.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -5.58%, ranking in the 44th percentile, indicating that housing supply is tightening. This decrease in building permits may lead to future affordability challenges and constraints on workforce accommodation, potentially limiting the city's ability to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 47 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -2.1%, ranking in the 14th percentile. This fast-paced market means that homes are selling quickly, making it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. Businesses may need to provide relocation assistance or adjust their hiring timelines to accommodate the competitive housing market.

Office Economy

Kansas City's professional and office worker share ranks in the 18th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This makes the city less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but more suitable for industries with different workforce requirements.

In conclusion, Kansas City offers businesses a highly competitive labor market with strong wage growth and a relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for talent attraction and retention. However, the city's tightening housing supply and competitive housing market pose significant risks and constraints that decision-makers should carefully consider when evaluating Kansas City as a potential business location.

St. Louis

St. Louis

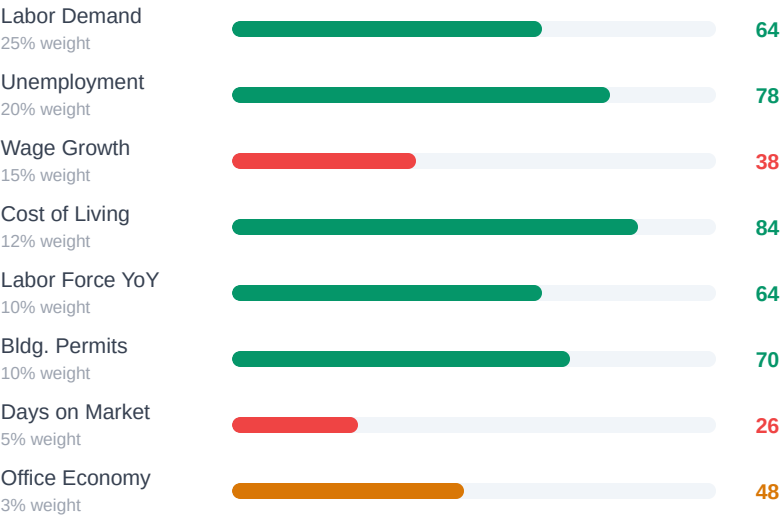
A

VERY GOOD

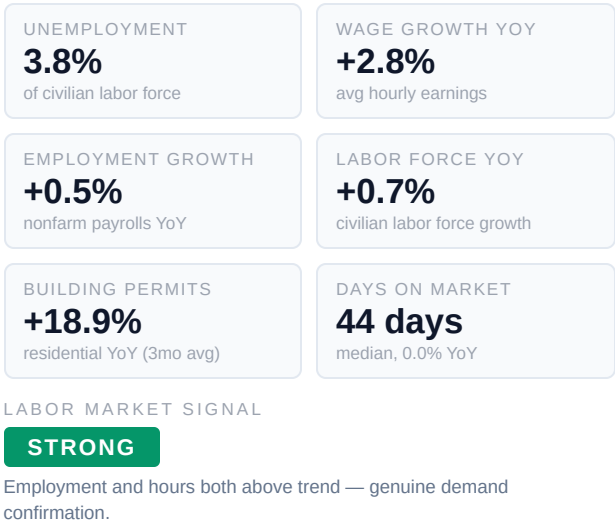
63.5th percentile

Rank 7 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

St. Louis earns an overall grade of A, ranking in the 63.5th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its above-average labor demand and low unemployment rate of 3.80%. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.58, combining a +0.49% employment growth rate and a +0.598% weekly hours deviation from its own trend, signals genuine demand expansion. This, coupled with its tight labor market, defines the city's current economic character.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.49% and weekly hours deviation of +0.598% indicate that St. Louis is experiencing genuine demand expansion, with more jobs being added and hours worked above the trend. This combination suggests a healthy labor market where businesses are likely to find a strong workforce. The labor demand composite score of 5.58 further reinforces this, placing the city above average in terms of labor demand.

Unemployment

With an unemployment rate of 3.80%, St. Louis has a tight labor market, ranking in the 78th percentile. This low unemployment rate implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the market has less slack, potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. For a business trying to hire in St. Louis, this means being prepared to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

St. Louis experiences a year-over-year wage growth of +2.84%, which is below average, ranking in the 38th percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are increasing, but at a slower pace than in many other cities. While this may not significantly erode profit margins, it also means that worker purchasing power is not increasing as rapidly as it could be.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in St. Louis, with a PSF of \$164/sqft and an earnings ratio of \$37.84/hr, resulting in a ratio of 4.33, places it in the top tier for affordability, ranking in the 84th percentile. This high affordability score means that St. Louis has a significant talent attraction advantage, as workers can maintain a high standard of living without requiring substantial wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in St. Louis is growing at a rate of +0.69% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This positive growth rate suggests that the labor pool is not shrinking, providing a favorable condition for businesses looking to hire and expand their operations in the city.

Building Permits

With an 18.86% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, St. Louis is seeing an expansion in its housing supply. This rise in permits signals developer confidence in the market and suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation are likely to improve, making it easier for relocating workers to find housing.

Days on Market

Homes in St. Louis currently sit on the market for a median of 44 days, with a year-over-year change of +0.0%. This relatively fast market, ranking below average in the 26th percentile, means that homes are selling quickly, which can make it challenging for relocating workers to find and secure housing.

Office Economy

St. Louis has a professional and office worker share that places it near the median, ranking in the 48th percentile. This indicates a moderately deep talent pool suited for businesses requiring professional and office skills, making it a viable location for tech, finance, and consulting firms, but perhaps less ideal for industries requiring large numbers of industrial or logistics workers.

In conclusion, St. Louis offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market, moderate wage growth, and high affordability, making it an attractive location for talent and business expansion. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential challenge in hiring due to the low unemployment rate, which may necessitate offering competitive salaries to attract and retain top talent.

Austin

Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos

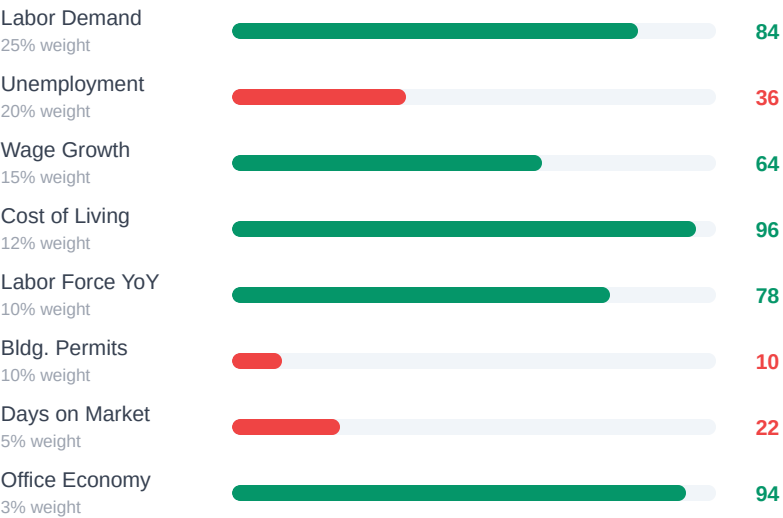
A-

GOOD

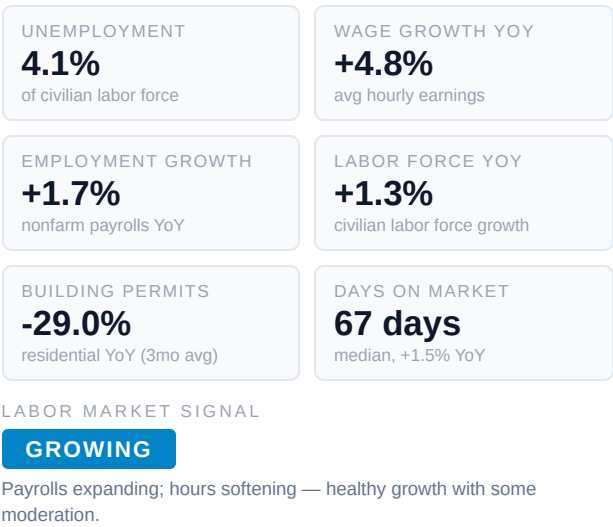
62.0th percentile

Rank 8 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos metro area has earned an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking in the 62.0th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its top-tier labor demand, with an 84th percentile ranking, and its highly affordable cost of living, ranked in the 96th percentile. These metrics signal a strong and attractive environment for businesses, with 1.70% employment growth year-over-year and a cost of living ratio of \$234/sqft to \$37.54/hr, which is decreasing by 8.6% year-over-year.

Labor Demand

The Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos metro area has seen employment growth of 1.70% year-over-year, combined with a -0.262% deviation in weekly hours from its own 12-month baseline. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are slightly below trend during a period of job growth, indicating a healthy and sustainable labor market. The labor demand composite score of 6.42 ranks in the top tier, at the 84th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos stands at 4.10%, ranking below average at the 36th percentile. This indicates a market with some slack, rather than being extremely tight, which means businesses may find it relatively easier to hire compared to cities with lower unemployment rates. However, the rate is not so high as to indicate significant weakness in local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

Year-over-year wage growth in the metro area is 4.80%, ranking above average at the 64th percentile. This rate of wage growth is relatively fast, suggesting that labor costs for employers are rising, but it also indicates strong worker purchasing power. Businesses should be prepared for a moderately inflationary labor market environment.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$234/sqft to \$37.54/hr and a year-over-year decrease of 8.6% in PSF, Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos is highly affordable, ranking in the 96th percentile. This affordability is a significant talent attraction advantage, as businesses can offer competitive wages without needing large premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the metro area has grown by 1.27% year-over-year, ranking above average at the 78th percentile. This expansion in labor force supply is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it indicates a growing pool of potential workers. The implication is that hiring capacity is likely to be supported by an increasing workforce.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -29.04%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile. This significant decline suggests that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. This trend signals a potential risk for businesses reliant on a readily available and affordable housing stock for their employees.

Days on Market

The current median days on market for homes is 67 days, with a year-over-year increase of 1.5%. This indicates a slightly slower market, ranking below average at the 22nd percentile. For workers relocating to this city, the housing market is relatively competitive but still accessible, with homes taking a couple of months to sell on average.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors is significant, with the city ranking in the top tier at the 94th percentile. This deep talent pool makes Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos well-suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions, but less ideal for those in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors.

The Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion, affordable cost of living, and a deep professional talent pool. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, signaled by a sharp decline in building permits, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Orlando

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford

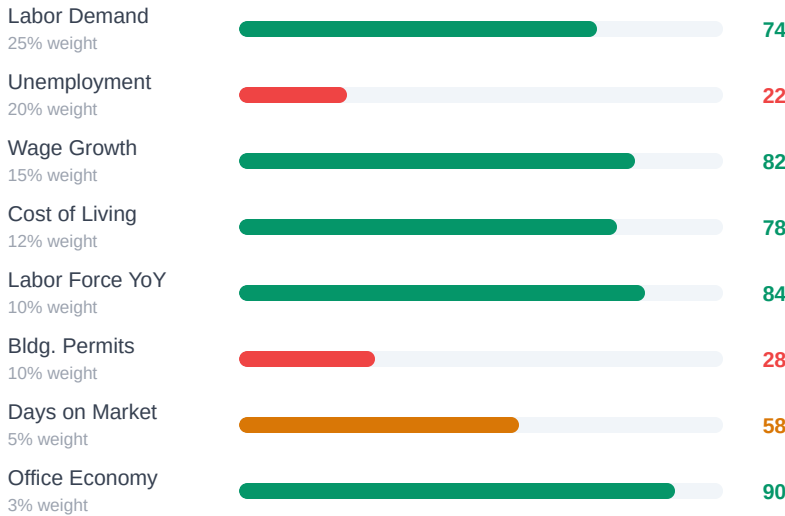
A-

GOOD

61.3th percentile

Rank 9 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.6%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+5.8%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+1.1%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

+1.7%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-11.7%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

74 days

median, -1.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area has earned an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking at the 61.3th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the 74th percentile, and its top-tier wage growth, at 5.78% year-over-year. These metrics signal a city with genuine job expansion and rising labor costs.

Labor Demand

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area has seen employment growth of 1.11% year-over-year, combined with a 0.294% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, indicating that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, a sign of a healthy and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 6.15 further reinforces this trend, ranking in the 74th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford stands at 4.60%, which ranks in the 22nd percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight market also suggests that workers may have more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is 5.78%, ranking in the 82nd percentile, which is considered fast. This rapid wage growth implies that labor costs for employers are rising, but it also means that workers have increasing purchasing power, which can benefit local businesses. The strong wage growth is a double-edged sword, offering benefits to workers but increasing costs for employers.

Cost of Living

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford has a cost of living score that ranks in the 78th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$223/sqft to \$33.52/hr, or 6.65. The fact that the PSF is falling by 3.0% year-over-year is a key driver of the city's affordability. This makes the city more attractive for talent, as workers can afford a higher quality of life without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is growing at a rate of 1.74% year-over-year, ranking in the 84th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire. The growing labor force provides a larger pool of potential employees, making it easier for companies to find the talent they need.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford has decreased by 11.73% year-over-year, ranking in the 28th percentile. This decline suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. The decrease in building permits is a concern for businesses that rely on a steady supply of new housing to attract and retain employees.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is 74 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 1.3%. This ranks in the 58th percentile, indicating a relatively balanced market. For workers relocating to the city, this means that the housing market is neither extremely competitive nor overly accessible, providing a moderate environment for finding a home.

Office Economy

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy score ranking in the 90th percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which rely on specialized knowledge workers. However, the city may be less suitable for industries that require a large workforce in industrial or logistics roles.

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion and a growing workforce, making it an attractive location for companies looking to expand. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce, potentially offsetting the benefits of the city's otherwise favorable economic conditions.

Nashville

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin

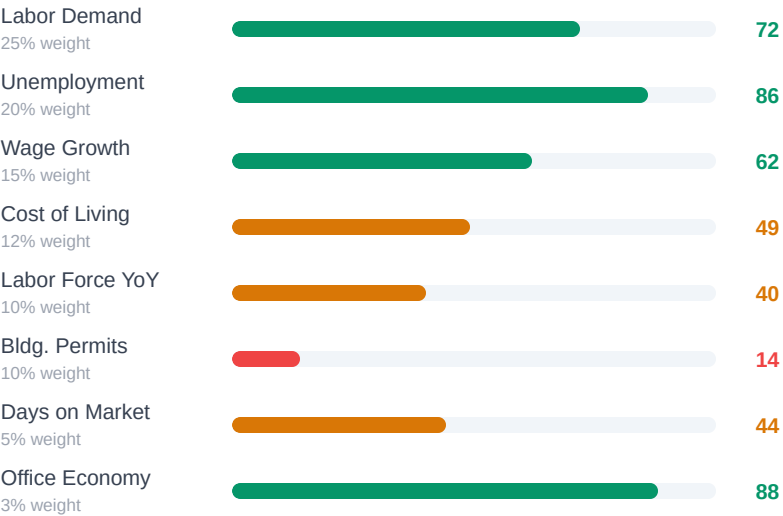
A-

GOOD

60.6th percentile

Rank 10 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin has an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking it at the 60.6th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the 72nd percentile, and its low unemployment rate, ranking in the 86th percentile at 3.30%. These metrics signal a city with a tight labor market and genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The city's employment growth rate is 1.56% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by -0.424%, indicating a genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in slightly fewer hours than expected, suggesting a healthy labor market. The labor demand composite score of 6.06 further supports this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin is 3.30%, ranking in the 86th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is relatively small. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive wages to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in the city is 4.66%, ranking in the 62nd percentile, indicating moderate to fast wage growth. This implies that employer labor costs are rising, but workers are also experiencing increased purchasing power. As a result, businesses may need to factor in higher labor costs, but they can also expect a more affluent local consumer base.

Cost of Living

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin has a cost of living score in the 49th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$260/sqft to \$35.38/hr, or 7.35. The fact that the PSF is falling by 0.8% year-over-year suggests that the city is becoming more affordable relative to wages. This makes it an attractive location for talent, as workers can enjoy a relatively low cost of living without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the city is growing at a rate of -0.14% year-over-year, ranking in the 40th percentile, indicating a slightly contracting labor pool. This means that the supply of workers is not expanding as quickly as demand, which may pose a challenge for businesses looking to hire. As a result, companies may need to invest in training and development programs to attract and retain top talent.

Building Permits

The city is experiencing a decline in building permits, with a year-over-year change of -21.89%, ranking in the 14th percentile. This suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which may lead to increased competition for available housing and higher costs for workers. As a result, businesses may need to factor in higher relocation costs or offer housing assistance to attract talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin is 58 days, with a year-over-year increase of 5.5%. This indicates a relatively slow market, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, the rising DOM may also signal a normalization of the market, rather than a decline in demand.

Office Economy

The city has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy score ranking in the 88th percentile. This makes it an attractive location for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require specialized knowledge workers. However, the city may be less suited for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

In conclusion, Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin offers a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion, a tight unemployment market, and moderate to fast wage growth. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses is the tightening housing supply, which may lead to increased competition for available housing and higher costs for workers. As a result, companies should carefully consider their relocation and hiring strategies to mitigate these risks and capitalize on the city's attractive economic character.

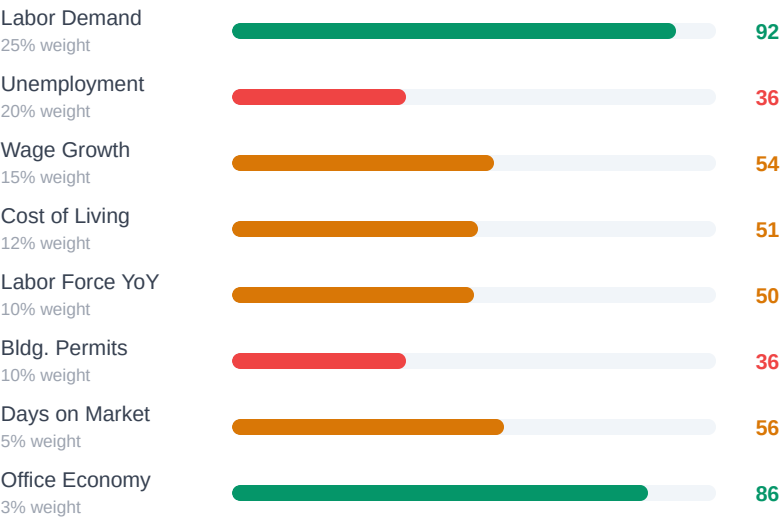
Las Vegas

Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas

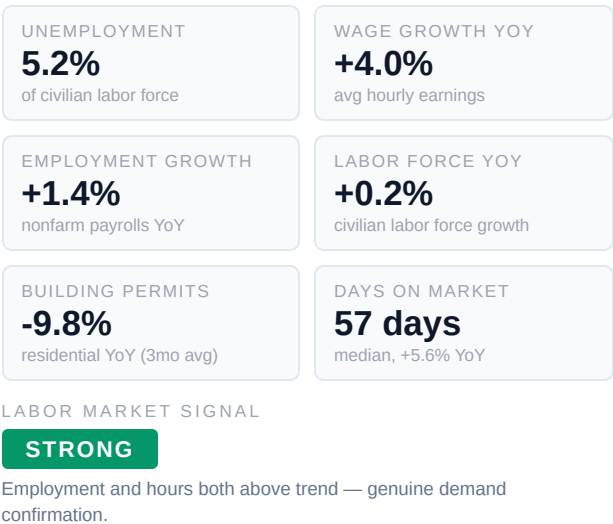
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
58.4th percentile
Rank 11 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area has earned an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking at the 58.4th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a top-tier composite score of 7.02, and its relatively high office economy share, ranking at the 86th percentile. The labor demand is driven by a combination of employment growth and hours worked above trend.

Labor Demand

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area has seen employment growth of +1.42% year-over-year, combined with a +0.733% deviation in weekly hours from its own 12-month baseline. This signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. The top-tier labor demand composite score of 7.02 confirms this strong labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in the Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area stands at 5.20%, ranking at the 36th percentile, indicating a market with some slack. This means that businesses may find it relatively easier to hire in this market, although it also suggests weaker local consumer demand. The unemployment rate is not extremely low, giving employers a bit more flexibility in hiring.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in the Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area is +3.95%, ranking near the median at the 54th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not extremely rapidly, and worker purchasing power is increasing at a steady pace. This balance may appeal to businesses looking for a stable labor cost environment.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in the Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area is near the median, with a percentile rank of 51, and a price-to-salary ratio of 8.02, based on \$262/sqft and \$32.65/hr. The fact that PSF is falling by -2.2% year-over-year is a key driver of affordability. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which could be a talent attraction advantage without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area has grown by +0.22% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 50th percentile. This slow growth rate indicates that the labor force supply is expanding, but at a modest pace. This modest growth may slightly limit the hiring capacity of businesses in the area.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in the Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area has decreased by -9.84% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 36th percentile. This decline in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in the Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area is 57 days, with a year-over-year increase of +5.6%. This indicates a relatively balanced market, neither extremely competitive nor overly accessible for relocating workers. The rising days on market may signal a healthy normalization of the housing market.

Office Economy

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area has a deep professional talent pool, with an office/professional worker share ranking at the 86th percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, or HQ sectors, but less ideal for industries with primarily industrial or logistics roles.

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area offers businesses a strong labor demand environment and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for certain industries. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

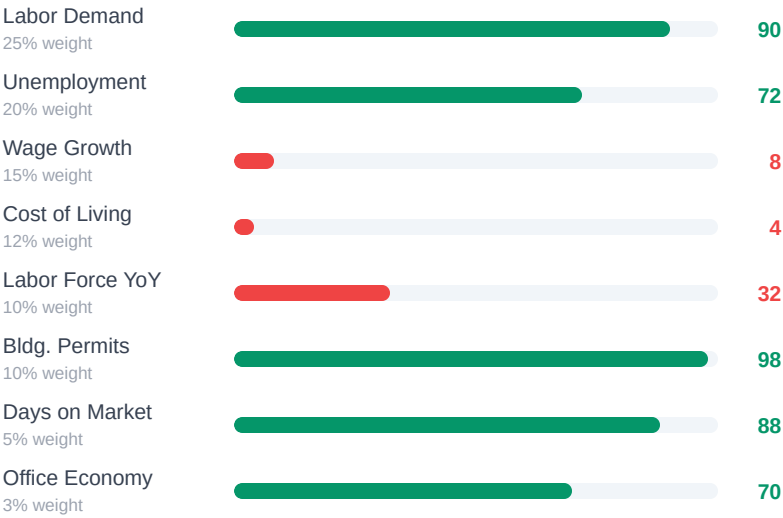
San Jose

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara

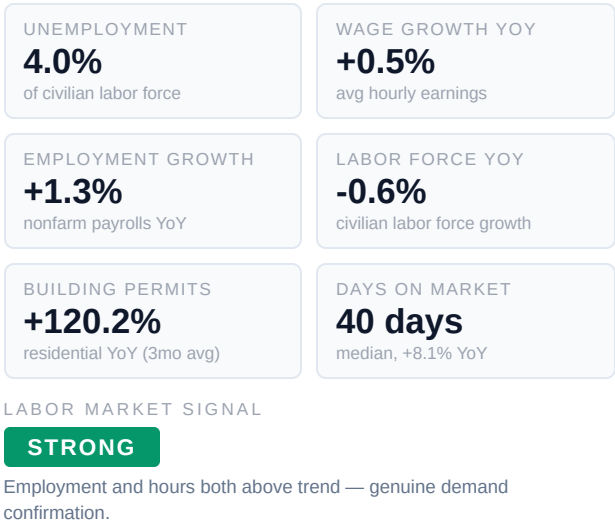
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
58.1th percentile
Rank 12 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has earned an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking it at the 58.1th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a top-tier composite score of 7.01, and its extremely high cost of living, ranked at the 4th percentile. The labor demand is driven by a 1.34% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 0.839% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend.

Labor Demand

The combination of a 1.34% employment growth rate and a 0.839% increase in weekly hours above trend signals genuine demand expansion in the San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area. This indicates that the city is experiencing a surge in job creation and workers are putting in more hours, suggesting a strong and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 7.01, ranked at the 90th percentile, further reinforces this notion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara stands at 4.00%, ranking at the 72nd percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in finding available workers, and wage pressure is likely to be higher. As a result, companies looking to hire in this area may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara is 0.51%, ranked at the 8th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also means that workers may have weaker bargaining power. As a result, businesses may not face significant pressure to increase wages, but workers may not have the same level of purchasing power as in other areas.

Cost of Living

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara has a cost of living ranked at the 4th percentile, with a PSF of \$797/sqft and an average hourly earnings of \$53.77/hr, resulting in a ratio of 14.82. This indicates that the city is extremely expensive relative to peers. However, the fact that PSF is falling by 3.6% year-over-year is a key driver of its relatively low affordability score. Despite this, the high cost of living may make it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara is contracting at a rate of -0.60% year-over-year, ranked at the 32nd percentile. This decline in labor force supply may pose a structural headwind for hiring, making it more challenging for businesses to find the workers

they need. As a result, companies may need to consider strategies to attract workers from other areas or invest in training and development programs.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara has increased by 120.21% year-over-year, ranked at the 98th percentile. This surge in building permits suggests that housing supply is expanding rapidly, which may lead to improved affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara is 40 days, with a year-over-year increase of 8.1%, ranked at the 88th percentile. This indicates a relatively slow market, which may be beneficial for workers relocating to the area as they have more time to find a home. However, this also suggests that the housing market may be normalizing, which could lead to more stable and predictable conditions for businesses and workers alike.

Office Economy

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara has a professional and office worker share ranked at the 70th percentile, with a composite score of 3.10. This indicates a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. The city is well-suited for businesses that require specialized knowledge-economy workers, but may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area offers businesses a strong labor demand and a deep talent pool, making it an attractive location for companies in the tech and finance sectors. However, the high cost of living and stagnant wage growth may pose challenges for businesses looking to attract and retain talent, and the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential difficulty in finding available workers due to the contracting labor force supply.

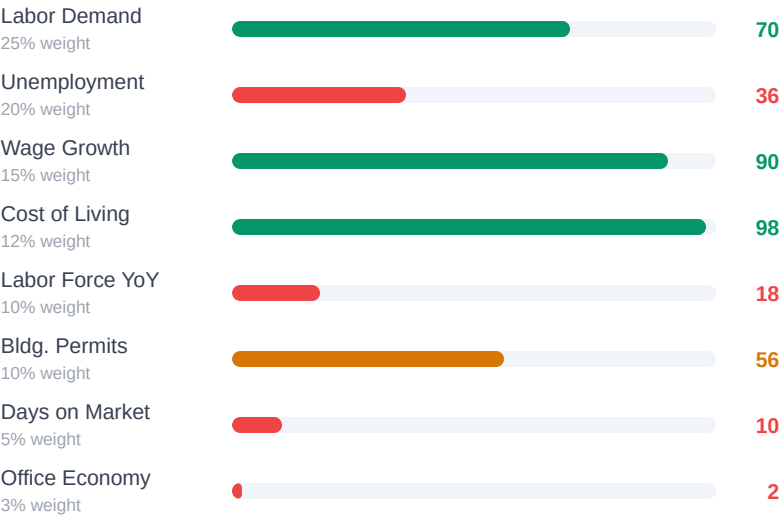
Memphis

Memphis

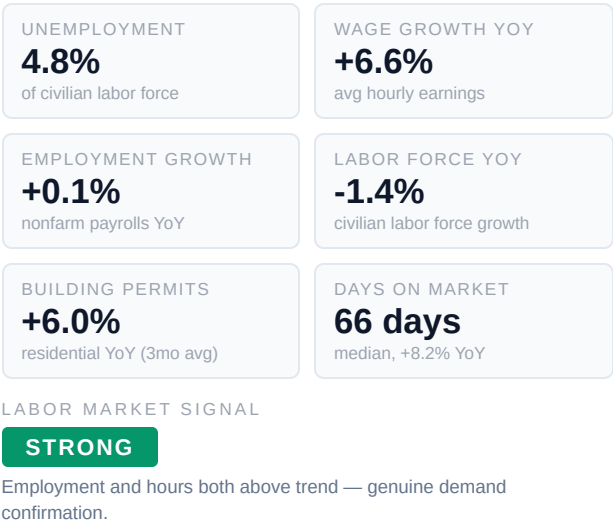
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
57.9th percentile
Rank 13 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Memphis earns an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking at the 57.9th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its top-tier wage growth of 6.63% year-over-year and its highly affordable cost of living, with a PSF to wages ratio of 4.70, ranking in the 98th percentile. These metrics suggest a city with strong labor market dynamics and attractive living costs.

Labor Demand

Memphis exhibits a labor demand composite score of 5.81, ranking in the 70th percentile, driven by employment growth of 0.06% year-over-year and weekly hours 1.422% above its own trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. The labor market is thus characterized by a genuine increase in labor demand.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Memphis stands at 4.80%, ranking in the 36th percentile, indicating a market with some slack. This implies that businesses may find it somewhat easier to hire in Memphis compared to tighter labor markets, although wage pressure may still be present. The relatively higher unemployment rate suggests that the city's labor market is not as competitive as others.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of 6.63%, Memphis ranks in the 90th percentile, indicating fast-rising wages. This rapid wage growth implies increasing labor costs for employers but also enhances worker purchasing power, contributing to a stronger local economy. Businesses should factor in the potential for higher labor costs when considering Memphis as a location.

Cost of Living

Memphis offers a highly affordable cost of living, with a PSF to wages ratio of 4.70 and a percentile rank of 98, driven by a PSF of \$154/sqft that is falling by 6.1% year-over-year relative to wages of \$32.74/hr. This affordability advantage is a significant talent attraction factor, as businesses can offer competitive wages without needing large premiums to offset high living costs. The city's affordability is a major draw for workers and businesses alike.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Memphis is contracting at a rate of -1.37% year-over-year, ranking in the 18th percentile. This decline in labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, as businesses may face challenges in finding sufficient skilled workers to meet their needs. The shrinking labor pool is a concern for companies looking to expand or establish operations in Memphis.

Building Permits

Memphis has seen a year-over-year increase in residential building permits of 5.95%, ranking near the median at the 56th percentile. This expansion in housing supply suggests that developer confidence is present, and future affordability may improve, supporting workforce accommodation and attraction. However, the moderate pace of permit growth may not fully keep up with demand, potentially limiting the improvement in affordability.

Days on Market

Homes in Memphis are currently sitting on the market for 66 days, with a year-over-year increase of 8.2%, ranking in the 10th percentile. This slower market means that relocating workers may find it more accessible to purchase or rent a home, as there is less competition and pressure to act quickly. The rising days on market indicate a normalization of the housing market, making it more favorable for buyers.

Office Economy

Memphis has a relatively shallow professional talent pool, ranking in the 2nd percentile with an office/professional worker share of 0.38. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses requiring deep knowledge-economy talent, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but may be more appropriate for industries with different skill requirements, like logistics or manufacturing. The city's economic profile is more aligned with traditional industries rather than office-intensive sectors.

In conclusion, Memphis offers businesses an attractive combination of affordable living costs and strong wage growth, making it a competitive location for talent attraction and retention. However, the city's shrinking labor force supply poses a significant risk and constraint for businesses looking to hire and expand, requiring careful consideration and planning to mitigate this challenge. Overall, Memphis presents a mixed economic profile that businesses must carefully weigh when making location decisions.

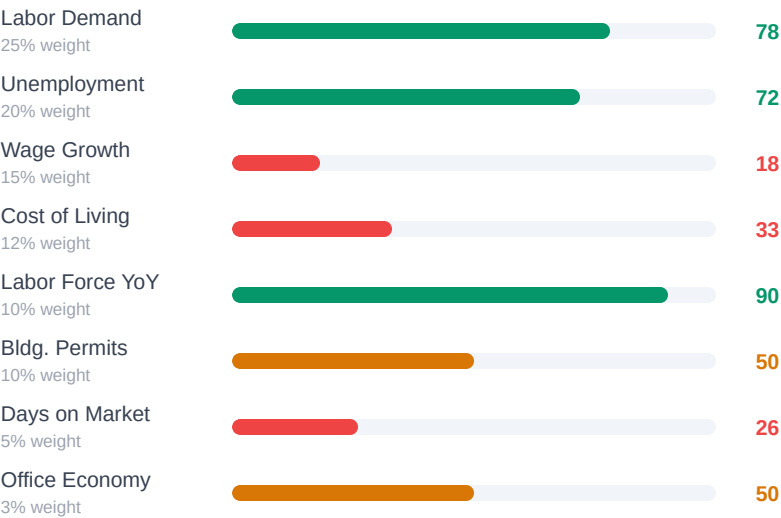
Philadelphia

Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington

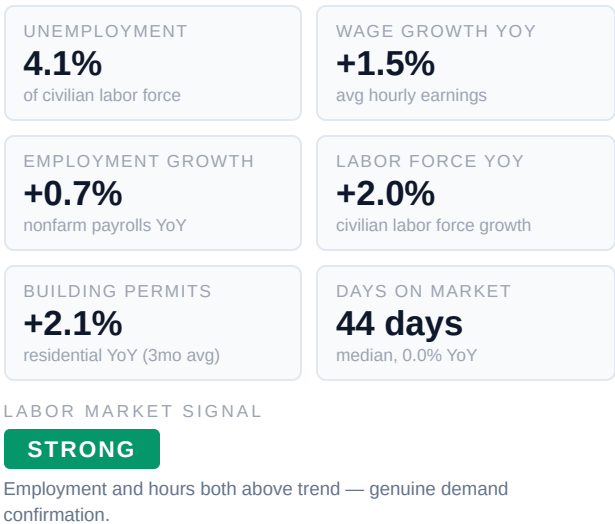
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
57.3th percentile
Rank 14 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro area has earned an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking it at the 57.3th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the 78th percentile, and its labor force growth, which is expanding at a rate of 2.00% year-over-year. The combination of these metrics suggests a city with a growing workforce and increasing job opportunities.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington is 0.74% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.922%. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth, indicating that the labor market is experiencing an increase in job openings and workers are putting in more hours to meet the demand.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington is 4.10%, which ranks in the 72nd percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington is +1.51%, which ranks in the 18th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth means that labor costs for employers are not increasing rapidly, but it also implies that workers may have weaker bargaining power and lower purchasing power.

Cost of Living

Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington has a cost of living score that ranks in the 33rd percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$231/sqft to \$32.62/hr, or 7.08. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which may make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington is growing at a rate of 2.00% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This growth in the labor force means that businesses have a larger pool of potential workers to hire from, making it easier to find and recruit talent.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington is increasing by 2.10% year-over-year, which is near the median. This moderate growth in building permits suggests that the housing supply is expanding, but not rapidly, which may help to improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington is 44 days, with no year-over-year change. This relatively fast pace of home sales means that workers relocating to the city may face a competitive housing market, making it challenging to find and secure a home quickly.

Office Economy

Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington has an office economy score that ranks in the 50th percentile, indicating a moderate depth of professional talent. This city is well-suited for businesses that require a mix of office and non-office workers, but may not be the best fit for companies that require a highly specialized or deep knowledge-economy talent pool.

The Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro area offers businesses a growing workforce, increasing job opportunities, and a moderate cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the relatively tight labor market, which may lead to challenges in hiring and retaining top talent, and the stagnant wage growth, which may impact worker purchasing power and labor costs.

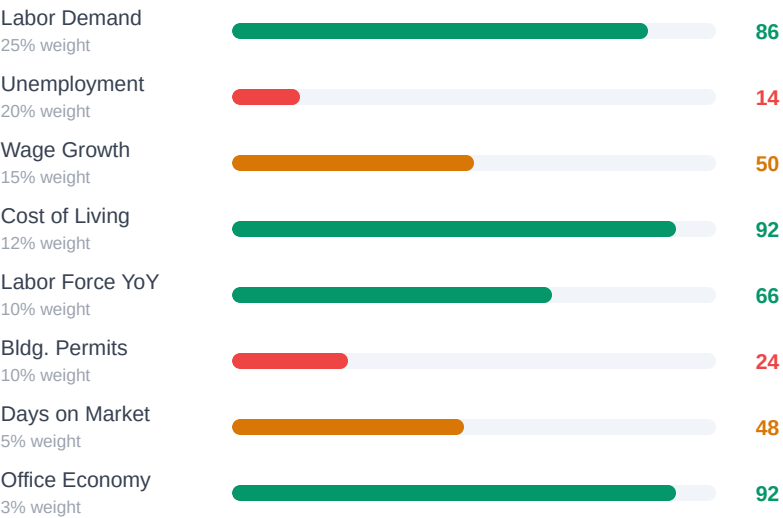
Dallas

Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington

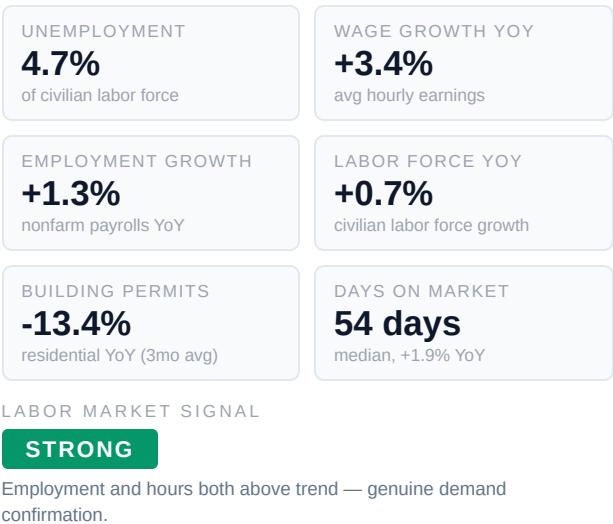
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
57.0th percentile
Rank 15 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area has earned an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking it at the 57.0th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a top-tier composite score of 86th percentile, and its highly affordable cost of living, ranked at the 92nd percentile. The labor demand is driven by a 1.26% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 0.463% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend.

Labor Demand

The combination of a 1.26% employment growth rate and a 0.463% increase in weekly hours above trend signals genuine demand expansion in the Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area. This indicates that the city is experiencing a period of job growth, with hours worked also increasing, suggesting a strong and vibrant labor market. The labor demand composite score of 6.53 further reinforces this assessment, ranking the city at the 86th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington stands at 4.70%, which ranks at the 14th percentile, indicating a relatively high level of unemployment compared to other cities. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it easier for businesses to hire workers without facing significant wage pressure. However, this also implies weaker local consumer demand compared to cities with lower unemployment rates.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is 3.44%, ranking near the median at the 50th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are increasing, but at a manageable pace. At the same time, workers are experiencing a modest increase in their purchasing power, which can contribute to a stable and growing local economy.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$201/sqft to \$38.32/hr, and a year-over-year decrease of 1.9% in PSF, Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington ranks at the 92nd percentile in terms of affordability. This makes the city an attractive location for talent, as the cost of living is relatively low compared to other metros, reducing the need for wage premiums to attract and retain workers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is growing at a rate of 0.73% year-over-year, which ranks above average at the 66th percentile. This expansion in the labor force supply suggests that the city has a growing pool of potential workers, making it easier for businesses to find the talent they need to expand or establish operations.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -13.44%, indicating a contraction in housing supply. This decline in building permits suggests that the city may face future affordability challenges and potential workforce accommodation issues, as the supply of new housing units is not keeping pace with demand.

Days on Market

The current median days on market for homes in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is 54 days, with a year-over-year increase of 1.9%. This relatively moderate pace of home sales, ranking near the median at the 48th percentile, suggests that the housing market is neither extremely competitive nor overly accessible for relocating workers.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share ranked at the 92nd percentile, Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington has a deep talent pool suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. This makes the city an attractive location for companies seeking specialized knowledge-economy workers, but less ideal for those in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors.

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, affordable cost of living, and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for certain types of businesses. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to consider is the potential future affordability challenges and workforce accommodation issues arising from the decline in residential building permits, which could impact the city's ability to attract and retain talent over the long term.

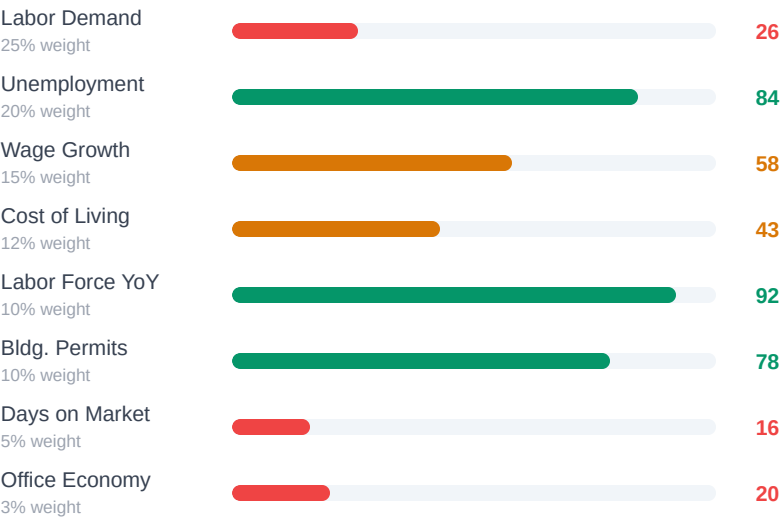
Pittsburgh

Pittsburgh

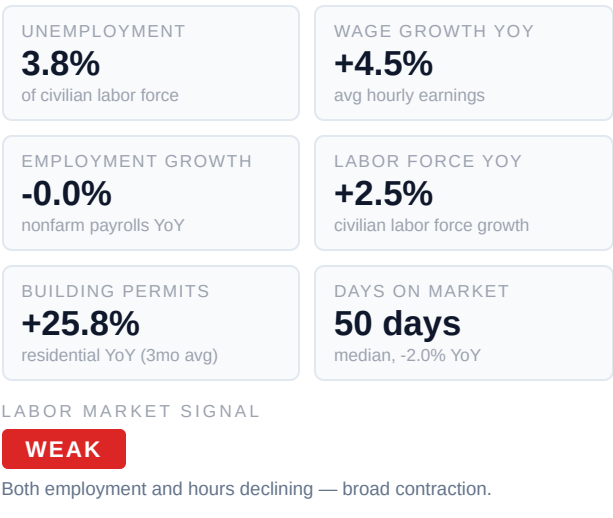
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
55.5th percentile
Rank 16 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Pittsburgh earns an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking it at the 55.5th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 3.80% and its strong labor force growth of +2.55% YoY, indicating a tight labor market with an expanding workforce. These metrics suggest a city with a skilled and growing workforce, but also one where hiring may be competitive.

Labor Demand

Pittsburgh's employment growth rate is -0.02% YoY, and weekly hours are deviating -0.470% from the city's own 12-month baseline, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 4.27, which ranks below average at the 26th percentile. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion or survivor squeeze. The negative employment growth and below-trend hours suggest a slowing job market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Pittsburgh is 3.80%, ranking at the 84th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is relatively small, and wage pressure may be higher. In practical terms, companies looking to hire in Pittsburgh may need to offer competitive salaries and benefits to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Pittsburgh is +4.48% YoY, ranking near the median at the 58th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so. At the same time, workers in Pittsburgh are seeing their purchasing power increase, which can have positive effects on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Pittsburgh's cost of living, with a PSF of \$174/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$33.21/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.24, ranks near the median at the 43rd percentile. This means that the city is neither extremely affordable nor extremely expensive relative to its peers. However, the fact that PSF is rising +1.8% YoY may put upward pressure on costs, making it less attractive for talent without wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Pittsburgh is growing at a rate of +2.55% YoY, ranking at the 92nd percentile, indicating a rapidly expanding workforce. This means that the supply of workers is increasing, which can make it easier for businesses to hire and find the talent they need. The growing labor force is a significant advantage for companies looking to locate in Pittsburgh.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Pittsburgh is increasing by +25.84% YoY, ranking above average at the 78th percentile. This suggests that housing supply is expanding, which can help improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. The increase in building permits is a positive sign for future affordability and workforce accommodation in Pittsburgh.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Pittsburgh is 50 days, with a YoY decrease of -2.0%. This ranks at the 16th percentile, indicating a relatively fast-paced market. For workers relocating to Pittsburgh, this means that they may face a competitive housing market, where homes are selling quickly, and they need to act fast to secure a property.

Office Economy

Pittsburgh's office economy, with a composite score ranking at the 20th percentile, indicates a relatively shallow professional talent pool. This means that the city may be less suited for businesses that require a deep pool of specialized office workers, such as tech or finance companies. However, Pittsburgh may be more attractive to companies with industrial or logistics-oriented operations.

In conclusion, Pittsburgh offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market, moderate wage growth, and an expanding workforce, making it an attractive location for companies looking to hire and grow. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the competitive hiring environment, where wage pressure may be higher due to the low unemployment rate, and businesses may need to offer competitive salaries and benefits to attract top talent.

Seattle

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue

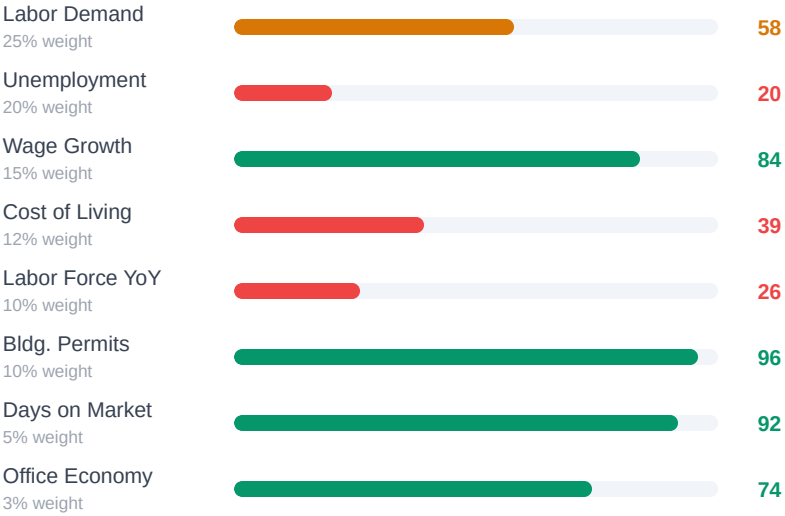
B

AVERAGE

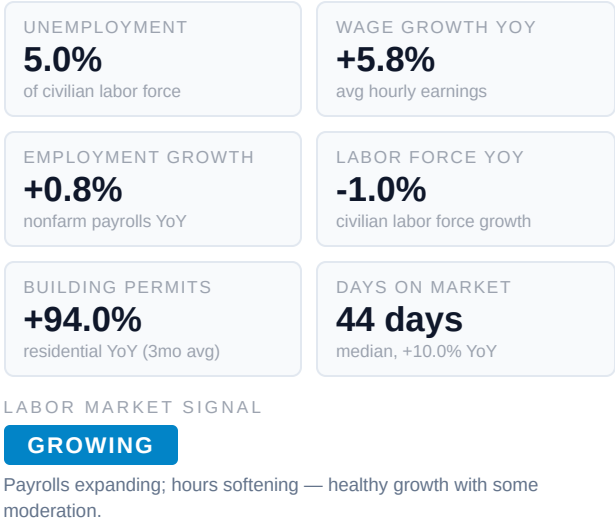
54.8th percentile

Rank 17 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 54.8th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong wage growth and building permits expansion. The city's economic character is most defined by its top-tier wage growth of 5.79% year-over-year and its rapid expansion in building permits, up 93.96% year-over-year. These metrics suggest a city with a strong, growing economy, but also one with potential labor cost and affordability implications.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 0.81% year-over-year, combined with a weekly hours deviation of -0.048% from its own trend, indicating a near median labor demand composite score of 5.39. This combination signals a moderate expansion in jobs, but with hours worked slightly below trend, suggesting some degree of labor market slack. The labor demand is not as strong as in other metros, but it does indicate genuine demand expansion rather than contraction.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 5.00%, ranking in the 20th percentile, which means the market has more slack than most other metros. This implies that businesses may find it easier to hire in this city compared to tighter labor markets, but it also suggests weaker local consumer demand due to the higher unemployment rate. For a business trying to hire, this could mean less competition for talent, but also potentially less skilled workers available.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 5.79%, ranking in the top tier at the 84th percentile. This fast wage growth rate implies rising labor costs for employers, but it also means good news for worker purchasing power. As wages rise, businesses may face increasing costs, but the local workforce will have more disposable income to spend, potentially boosting local economic activity.

Cost of Living

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue has a cost of living score that ranks in the 39th percentile, with a PSF to earnings ratio of \$438/sqft to \$47.42/hr, or 9.24, and a year-over-year decrease in PSF of -2.2%. This means the city is less affordable than many of its peers, which could make it harder to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The falling PSF relative to wages is a positive sign, but the overall affordability score suggests that businesses may need to compensate employees for the higher cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is contracting at a rate of -0.96% year-over-year, ranking in the 26th percentile. This negative growth rate indicates that the labor force supply is shrinking, which could pose a structural headwind for hiring in the future.

Businesses may face challenges in finding skilled workers as the labor pool contracts, making it essential to plan for potential talent shortages.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is 93.96%, ranking in the top tier at the 96th percentile. This rapid expansion in residential building permits signals that housing supply is likely to increase, which could improve affordability and make it easier for workers to relocate to the city. As housing supply expands, the city may become more attractive to potential employees, reducing the need for wage premiums to compensate for high living costs.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 44 days, with a year-over-year increase of 10.0%, ranking in the top tier at the 92nd percentile. This slower market means that homes are sitting longer before being sold, which could make it easier for relocating workers to find housing. However, this also indicates a less competitive market, which might suggest demand erosion if not accompanied by strong job growth.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue ranks in the 74th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This city is well-suited for businesses that rely on specialized, knowledge-economy workers, but it may be less ideal for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

In conclusion, Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue offers businesses a strong, growing economy with a highly skilled workforce, driven by top-tier wage growth and an expanding housing supply. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's less affordable cost of living, which may require businesses to offer wage premiums to attract and retain talent, potentially increasing labor costs.

Tampa

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater

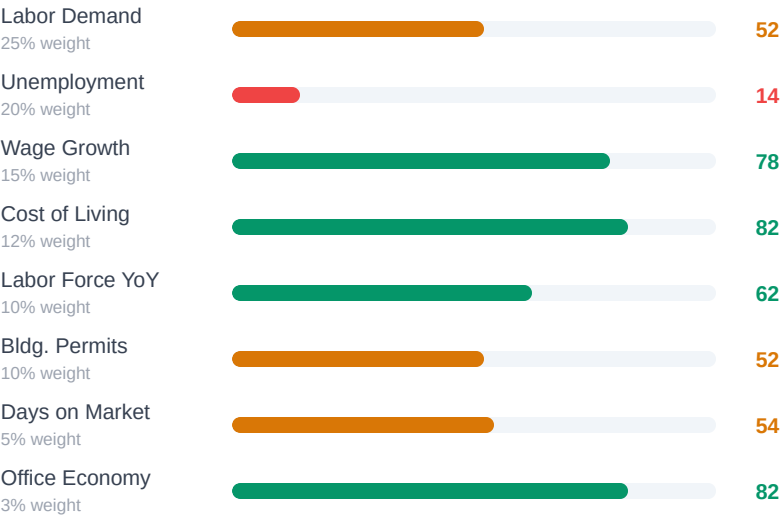
B

AVERAGE

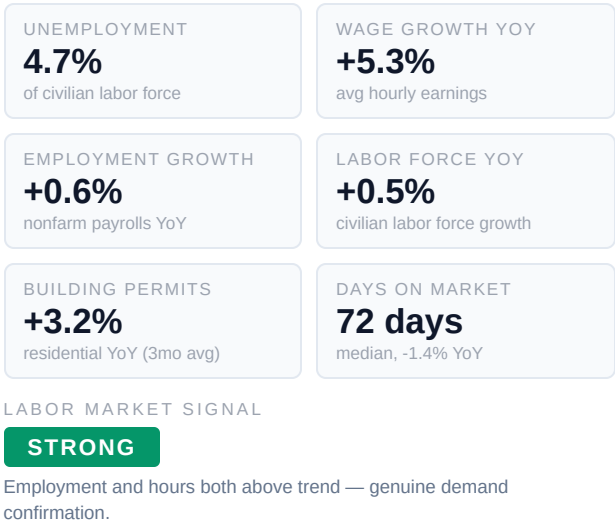
53.9th percentile

Rank 18 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 53.9th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its above-average wage growth and highly affordable cost of living. The city's economic character is defined by a wage growth rate of 5.33% year-over-year and a cost of living ratio of \$236/sqft to \$37.12/hr, resulting in a top-tier affordability score. These metrics suggest a city with a strong labor market and attractive living costs.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 0.56% year-over-year, combined with a 0.240% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend, indicating a genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing modest job growth with hours worked increasing, suggesting a healthy labor market. The labor demand composite score of 5.32 places the city near the median, indicating a balanced labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 4.70%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile, indicating a relatively loose labor market. This means that businesses may find it easier to hire in this city compared to others, as there is less competition for workers. However, the looser labor market may also contribute to weaker local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 5.33%, placing it above average at the 78th percentile. This rapid wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers may be rising, but it also indicates strong worker purchasing power. As a result, businesses may need to factor in higher labor costs, but they can also expect a more affluent local consumer base.

Cost of Living

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater has a cost of living ratio of \$236/sqft to \$37.12/hr, with the price per square foot falling 4.8% year-over-year, resulting in a top-tier affordability score at the 82nd percentile. This means that the city is highly affordable relative to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring wage premiums. The falling price per square foot is a key driver of this affordability, suggesting a favorable housing market.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is growing at a rate of 0.52% year-over-year, placing it above average at the 62nd percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire in the city. The growing labor force suggests that the city has a structural advantage in terms of hiring capacity.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is increasing by 3.19% year-over-year, placing it near the median at the 52nd percentile. This moderate growth in building permits suggests that the housing supply is expanding, which should help maintain affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. The increase in permits is a positive sign for future affordability and workforce attraction.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 72 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 1.4%. This suggests that the housing market is relatively competitive, but still accessible for relocating workers. The decreasing days on market indicates a moderately hot market, which may pose some challenges for workers looking to relocate to the city.

Office Economy

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater has a deep professional talent pool, with an office/professional worker share of 3.38, placing it in the top tier at the 82nd percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a highly skilled and specialized workforce. However, the city may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth, highly affordable living costs, and a growing labor force, making it an attractive location for talent and investment. However, the city's relatively loose labor market and moderate housing market growth may pose some challenges for businesses looking to hire and accommodate a growing workforce, and decision-makers should factor in these risks when considering a location in this city. Overall, the city's strengths make it a compelling choice for businesses looking to tap into a skilled and affordable workforce.

Baltimore

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson

B

AVERAGE

53.7th percentile

Rank 19 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		22
25% weight		
Unemployment		60
20% weight		
Wage Growth		68
15% weight		
Cost of Living		86
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		74
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		32
10% weight		
Days on Market		86
5% weight		
Office Economy		28
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT of civilian labor force 4.0%	WAGE GROWTH YOY avg hourly earnings +4.9%
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH nonfarm payrolls YoY -0.1%	LABOR FORCE YOY civilian labor force growth +1.2%
BUILDING PERMITS residential YoY (3mo avg) -10.3%	DAYS ON MARKET median, +5.4% YoY 39 days
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL WEAK Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Baltimore-Columbia-Towson metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 53.7th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its above-average unemployment rate of 4.00% and strong wage growth of +4.94% year-over-year. The city's economic character is also defined by its cost of living, with a PSF to wages ratio of \$216/sqft to \$37.54/hr, indicating a relatively affordable market. This affordability, combined with low unemployment, presents a unique economic landscape.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is -0.10% year-over-year, accompanied by a -0.673% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend, signaling a contraction in labor demand. This combination indicates a lack of genuine demand expansion, suggesting that the city's job market is not experiencing significant growth. The negative hours deviation further supports this conclusion, pointing to a potential survivor squeeze where remaining workers may absorb the workload of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is 4.00%, ranking in the 60th percentile, which indicates a relatively tight labor market with some slack. For a business trying to hire in this market, the low unemployment rate implies that it may be moderately challenging to find suitable candidates, potentially leading to upward pressure on wages. However, the presence of some slack suggests that hiring is still feasible without extreme difficulty.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is +4.94%, placing it above average in the 68th percentile. This rate of wage growth is relatively fast, suggesting that labor costs for employers are rising. On the other hand, workers in the area are experiencing an increase in purchasing power, which can be beneficial for local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson has a cost of living score in the 86th percentile, with a PSF to wages ratio of \$216/sqft to \$37.54/hr, and the PSF is falling by -2.3% year-over-year. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, making it attractive for talent without necessitating significant wage premiums. The falling PSF relative to wages is a key driver of this affordability, enhancing the city's appeal for both workers and businesses.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is growing at a rate of +1.23% year-over-year, ranking in the 74th percentile. This positive growth rate signifies that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a favorable condition for businesses looking to hire, as it

implies a larger and potentially more diverse talent pool.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is -10.35%, indicating a tightening in housing supply. This decline suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as a lack of new housing developments can lead to increased competition for existing homes and potentially higher prices.

Days on Market

The current median days on market for homes in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is 39 days, with a year-over-year increase of +5.4%, placing it in the top tier of the 86th percentile. This slower market means that homes are sitting longer before being sold, which can be beneficial for workers relocating to the city, as it indicates a less competitive and more accessible housing market.

Office Economy

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson has an office economy score in the 28th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow professional talent pool. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but may be more appropriate for industries with different workforce requirements.

The Baltimore-Columbia-Towson metro area offers businesses a unique combination of affordability, low unemployment, and strong wage growth, making it an attractive location for certain types of industries. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, signaled by the decline in building permits, which could impact future workforce accommodation and affordability.

Columbus

Columbus

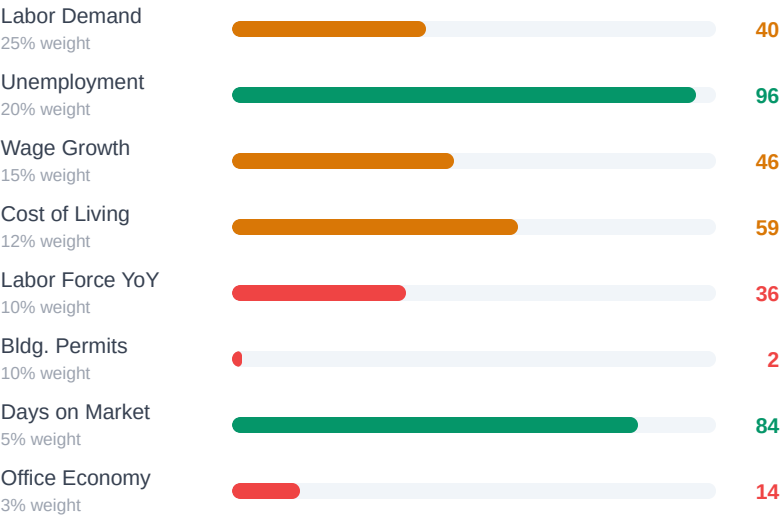
B

AVERAGE

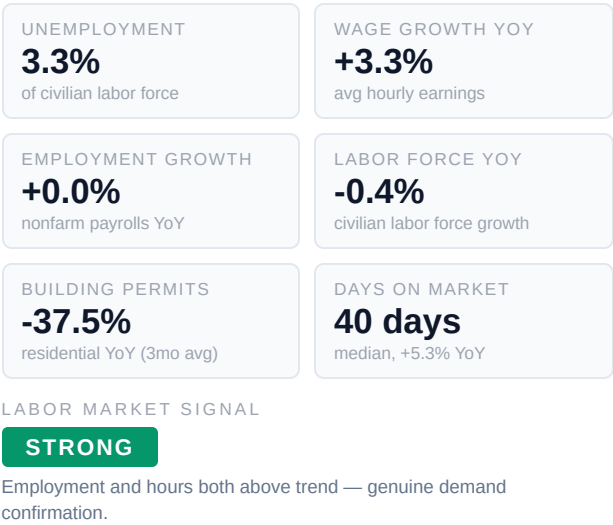
51.6th percentile

Rank 20 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Columbus, with an overall grade of B and a composite score ranking it at the 51.6th percentile among 50 US metros, is characterized by its low unemployment rate of 3.30% and a near-median labor demand composite score of 4.57. The city's economic character is most defined by its tight labor market and moderate labor demand growth, with employment growth at +0.02% year-over-year and weekly hours deviating +0.246% from its own trend. These metrics suggest a city with a strong but not overheating economy.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.02% and hours deviation of +0.246% indicate a moderate expansion of labor demand, signaling genuine demand for workers rather than a survivor squeeze. This combination suggests that businesses are adding jobs, albeit slowly, and workers are putting in slightly more hours than usual, indicating a healthy but not booming labor market. The labor demand composite score of 4.57, ranking at the 40th percentile, further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 3.30% ranks at the 96th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market with little slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in Columbus may face significant competition for workers, potentially driving up wages and making it harder to attract talent. The low unemployment rate suggests that workers have strong bargaining power in this market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +3.31% ranks at the 46th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not extremely quickly, and that workers are seeing some improvement in their purchasing power. However, the moderate pace of wage growth may not be sufficient to keep up with cost of living increases or to attract top talent from other cities.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of 6.02, based on \$207 per square foot and \$34.40 per hour, Columbus ranks at the 59th percentile in terms of affordability. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which could be a talent attraction advantage for businesses without needing to offer significant wage premiums. The stable year-over-year change in PSF versus wages also supports this assessment.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is contracting at a rate of -0.43% year-over-year, ranking at the 36th percentile. This indicates that the labor force supply is shrinking, which could create a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion in the city. The declining labor force growth

rate may limit the city's ability to support rapid business growth or expansion.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -37.46%, ranking at the 2nd percentile, indicating a sharp decline in housing supply expansion. This suggests that the city's housing market may be tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. The low ranking in building permits is a concern for businesses relying on a steady supply of new housing for their employees.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 40 days, with a year-over-year increase of +5.3%, ranking at the 84th percentile. This indicates a slower market, where homes are taking longer to sell, which could be beneficial for workers relocating to the city as it may provide more time to find a suitable home. However, this trend may also signal a normalization of the housing market rather than a significant downturn in demand.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share ranking at the 14th percentile, Columbus has a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses requiring a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but may be more appropriate for industries with different skill requirements, such as logistics or manufacturing.

In conclusion, Columbus offers businesses a relatively affordable and stable economic environment, with a tight labor market and moderate labor demand growth. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses in this city is the shrinking labor force supply and the tightening housing market, which could limit the city's ability to support rapid business growth or expansion. Decision-makers should carefully consider these factors when evaluating Columbus as a potential business location.

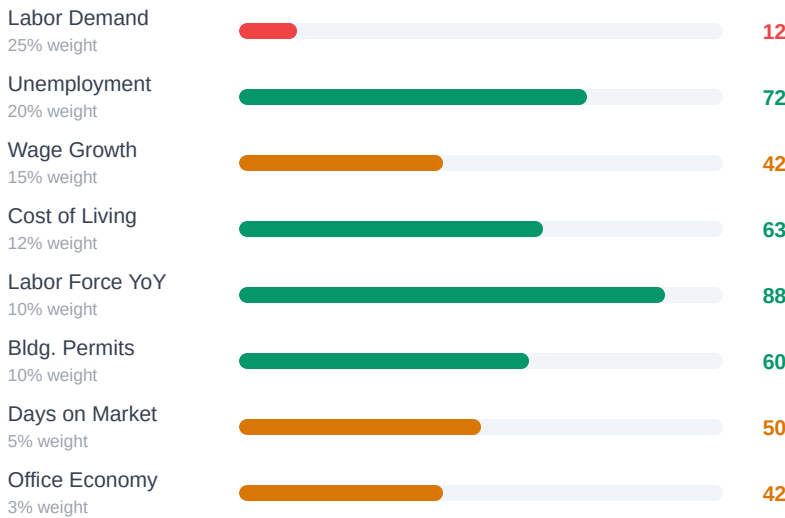
Atlanta

Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
49.9th percentile
Rank 21 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT
3.5%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY
+3.0%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH
-0.1%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY
+1.9%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS
+7.4%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET
56 days
median, +3.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 49.9th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier, and its high labor force growth rate, at 1.93% year-over-year. The labor demand metric, in particular, signals a contraction in the job market, with employment growth at -0.11% year-over-year.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Atlanta is -0.11% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.454%. This combination signals a contraction in the job market, rather than genuine demand expansion, as hours are not increasing in line with job growth. The labor demand composite score of 3.69 is in the bottom tier, indicating a weak job market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Atlanta is 3.50%, which is relatively low and corresponds to an above-average percentile rank of 72. This indicates a tight labor market with some slack, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire. The low unemployment rate implies that businesses may face wage pressure and competition for talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Atlanta is +2.99%, which is near the median. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are increasing, but not excessively, and worker purchasing power is relatively stable. The wage growth rate is not exceptionally high, which may limit the attractiveness of the city for businesses seeking to minimize labor costs.

Cost of Living

Atlanta has a cost of living percentile rank of 63, indicating that it is more affordable than many of its peer cities. The ratio of \$197 per square foot to \$37.03 per hour is relatively high, but the city's affordability is supported by a stable year-over-year change in PSF. This makes Atlanta an attractive location for talent, as businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to compensate for high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Atlanta is growing at a rate of 1.93% year-over-year, which is in the top tier. This expansion in labor supply suggests that the city has a growing workforce, making it easier for businesses to hire and expand their operations. The increasing labor force growth rate is a positive indicator for businesses looking to establish or grow their presence in the city.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Atlanta is increasing by 7.37% year-over-year, which is an above-average rate. This expansion in housing supply suggests that the city is likely to experience improving affordability and a more accommodating environment for its growing workforce. The increase in building permits is a positive signal for businesses concerned about the long-term affordability and livability of the city.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Atlanta is currently 56 days, with a year-over-year increase of 3.7%. This indicates a relatively stable and accessible housing market for workers relocating to the city. The moderate days on market suggest that the city's housing market is not excessively competitive, making it easier for businesses to attract and retain talent.

Office Economy

Atlanta has an office economy percentile rank of 42, indicating a moderately deep professional talent pool. The city is relatively well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors, but may not offer the same level of specialization as other cities with a more prominent office economy. The city's office economy is not exceptionally strong, which may limit its attractiveness for businesses seeking a highly specialized workforce.

In conclusion, Atlanta offers businesses a relatively affordable and growing labor market, with a moderate cost of living and expanding housing supply. However, the city's low labor demand and relatively weak office economy may pose a risk for businesses seeking to establish a strong presence in the city, particularly those in highly specialized industries. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's weak job market, which may limit the availability of skilled talent and hinder business growth.

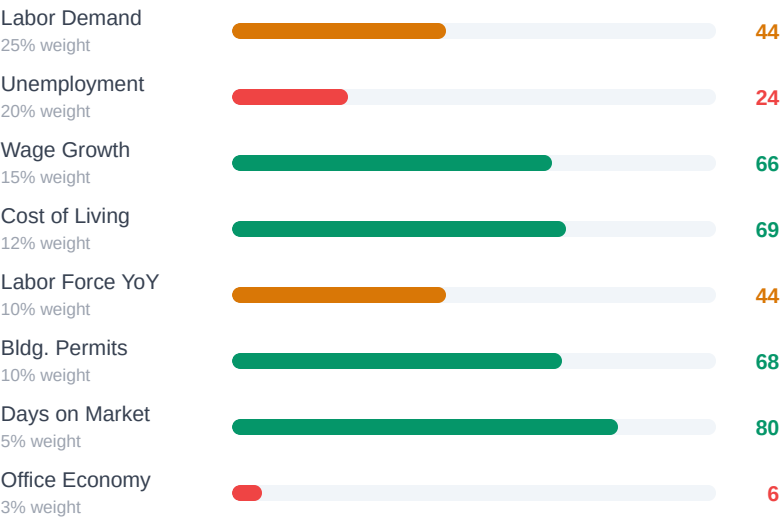
Oklahoma City

Oklahoma City

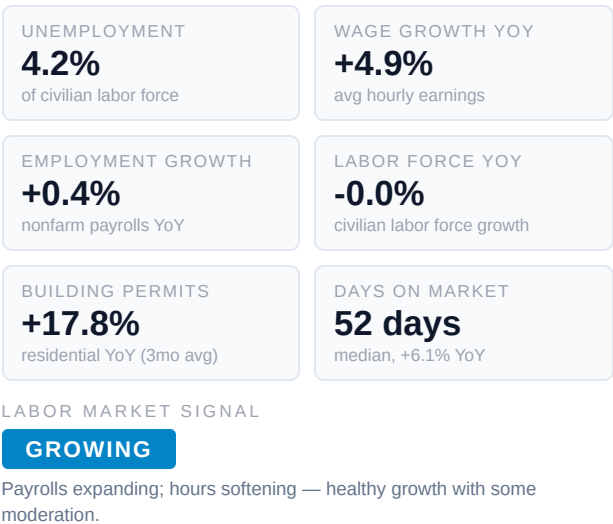
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
49.4th percentile
Rank 22 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Oklahoma City has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 49.4th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its above-average wage growth of 4.86% year-over-year and its relatively high cost of living, with a PSF to wages ratio of 5.13. These metrics suggest a city with rising labor costs but also increasing worker purchasing power.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Oklahoma City is 0.43% year-over-year, combined with a weekly hours deviation of -0.070% from its own trend, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 4.83, which ranks near the median at the 44th percentile. This signals a moderate expansion of genuine demand, as hours are not significantly above trend during job growth. The labor market is thus characterized by a slow but steady increase in jobs.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Oklahoma City is 4.20%, ranking below average at the 24th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market with some slack. For a business trying to hire in this city, the practical implication is that it may face moderate competition for talent, potentially leading to upward pressure on wages.

Wage Growth

Oklahoma City experiences above-average wage growth of 4.86% year-over-year, ranking at the 66th percentile. This fast wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers but also increasing purchasing power for workers, making the city more attractive for talent seeking better compensation.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living percentile rank of 69th, Oklahoma City is more affordable than many of its peers, considering its PSF of \$172/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$33.54, resulting in a ratio of 5.13. This affordability advantage means that businesses can attract talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Oklahoma City has a year-over-year growth rate of -0.04%, indicating a slight contraction in the labor pool. This implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential workers is not expanding, potentially making it more challenging for businesses to find the talent they need.

Building Permits

The city saw a year-over-year increase in residential building permits of 17.78%, ranking above average at the 68th percentile. This rise in permits signals an expansion in future housing supply, which should improve affordability and make it easier for workers to relocate to the city, accommodating workforce growth.

Days on Market

Homes in Oklahoma City currently sit on the market for a median of 52 days, with a year-over-year increase of 6.1%, placing it in the top tier at the 80th percentile. This slower market means that workers relocating to the city will find a more accessible and less competitive housing market, which can be an advantage for businesses looking to attract talent.

Office Economy

Oklahoma City has a relatively shallow professional talent pool, ranking at the 6th percentile in terms of the share of jobs in professional and office sectors. This makes the city less suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, or HQ operations that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, but it may be more appropriate for industries with different workforce needs.

In conclusion, Oklahoma City offers a unique blend of above-average wage growth and affordability, making it an attractive location for businesses seeking to balance labor costs with talent attraction. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's shallow professional talent pool, which may limit its appeal for certain types of businesses, particularly those in knowledge-intensive sectors.

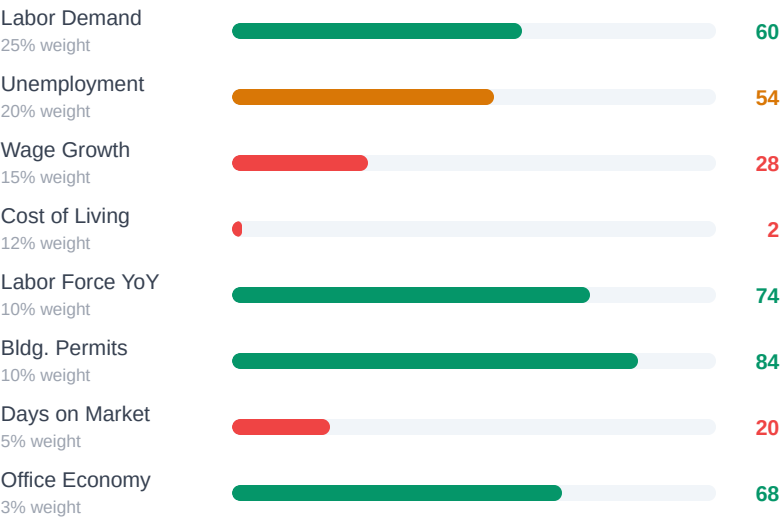
New York

New York Newark-Jersey City

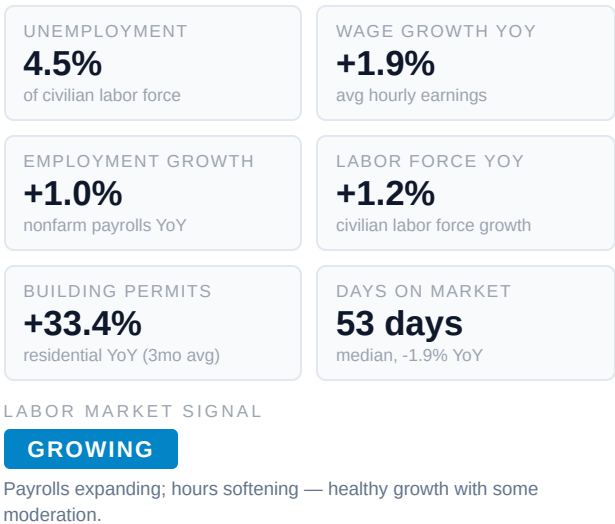
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
49.1th percentile
Rank 23 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 49.1th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its above-average labor demand, with a composite score of 5.42, and its extremely low affordability, with a cost of living percentile rank of 2. The labor demand is driven by employment growth of 0.96% year-over-year and a weekly hours deviation of -0.228% from its own trend.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 0.96% year-over-year, combined with a weekly hours deviation of -0.228% from its own trend, signals a genuine demand expansion, albeit with some moderation in hours worked. This suggests that the city is adding jobs, but the existing workforce is not being overutilized. The labor demand composite score of 5.42 ranks in the 60th percentile, indicating a relatively strong job market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.50% ranks in the 54th percentile, indicating a near-median level of slack in the labor market. This means that while the market is not extremely tight, it is also not overly loose, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire. The practical implication is that businesses may need to offer competitive wages to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of 1.95% is below average, ranking in the 28th percentile. This suggests that labor costs are not rising rapidly, but worker purchasing power is also not increasing significantly. The moderate wage growth implies that employers may not face significant pressure to increase wages, but workers may not have strong bargaining power either.

Cost of Living

The city's cost of living is extremely high, with a percentile rank of 2, indicating that it is one of the most expensive cities in the US. The PSF of \$522/sqft, combined with an average hourly wage of \$40.39, results in a ratio of 12.92, making it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering significant wage premiums. The 2.8% year-over-year increase in PSF further exacerbates the affordability issue.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of 1.23% year-over-year, ranking in the 74th percentile. This indicates that the labor force supply is expanding, making it easier for businesses to hire. The growing labor force provides a positive implication for hiring capacity, as there are more potential workers available.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is 33.43%, ranking in the 84th percentile. This significant increase in permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which may improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. The strong growth in building permits is a positive signal for future workforce accommodation.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 53 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 1.9%. This indicates a relatively fast-moving market, making it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. The below-average percentile rank of 20 suggests that the market is competitive, and workers may need to act quickly to secure housing.

Office Economy

The city's office economy is relatively deep, with a professional worker share ranking in the 68th percentile. This makes it well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. However, it may be less suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses, which may require a different type of workforce.

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area offers businesses a strong labor demand and expanding labor force, but its extremely high cost of living and competitive housing market pose significant challenges. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the need to offer significant wage premiums to attract and retain talent, which may impact business profitability and competitiveness.

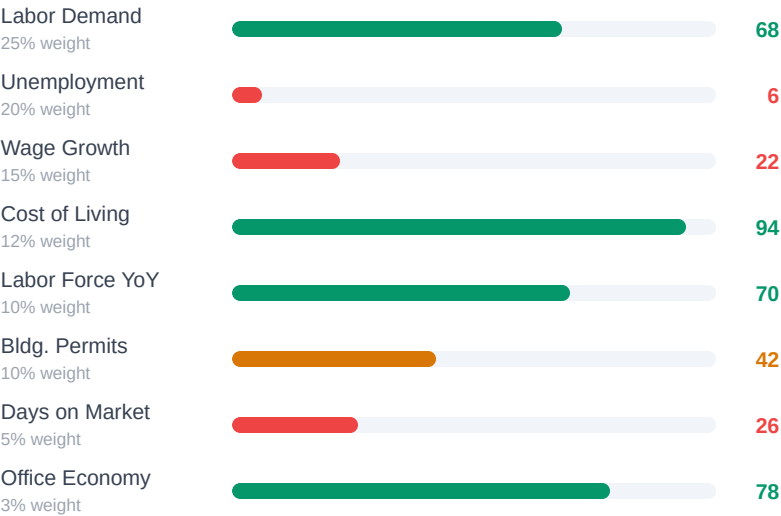
Houston

Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands

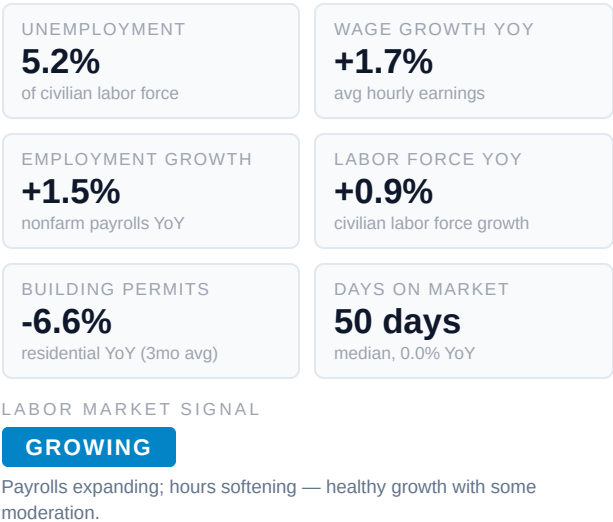
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
47.6th percentile
Rank 24 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking at the 47.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its high labor demand composite score, ranking at the 68th percentile, and its very low unemployment rate of 5.20%, which ranks at the 6th percentile. The combination of these metrics suggests a tight labor market with strong job growth.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is 1.46% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by -0.639%, still ranking above average at the 68th percentile. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as jobs are being added and hours are running above trend, indicating a healthy labor market. The labor demand composite score of 5.71 further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in this metro area is 5.20%, ranking at the 6th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market with little slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this area will face significant competition for talent, leading to potential wage pressure. The low unemployment rate implies that workers have more bargaining power, making it challenging for employers to attract and retain staff.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is 1.71%, ranking below average at the 22nd percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so. However, worker purchasing power is not increasing significantly, which may impact local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$171/sqft to \$36.90/hr, and a year-over-year decrease of 2.3% in PSF, this city ranks at the 94th percentile in terms of affordability. This means that Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is very affordable relative to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. The falling PSF value is a key driver of this high affordability score.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in this metro area is growing at a rate of 0.88% year-over-year, ranking above average at the 70th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, providing a positive implication for hiring capacity. As the labor force grows, businesses will have access to a larger pool of potential employees.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -6.61%, ranking near the median at the 42nd percentile. This decline in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability concerns and impact workforce accommodation. The decrease in building permits signals a potential supply squeeze, making it essential for businesses to consider the long-term implications of this trend.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 50 days, with a year-over-year change of 0.0%. This ranks below average at the 26th percentile, indicating a relatively fast-paced market. For workers relocating to this city, the housing market is competitive, making it challenging to find and secure a home quickly.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is 3.34, ranking above average at the 78th percentile. This suggests a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. However, the city may be less suitable for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand and affordability, making it an attractive location for talent. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tight labor market, which may lead to significant wage pressure and competition for talent. This should be carefully considered when evaluating the city as a potential business location.

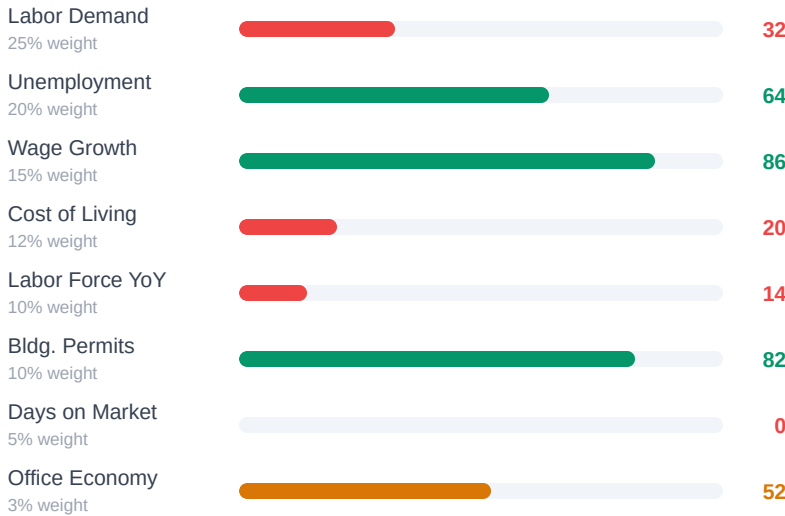
San Francisco

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
47.3th percentile
Rank 25 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.2%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+6.0%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.2%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-1.6%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

+32.1%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

39 days
median, -13.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 47.3th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 5.99%, and its low labor force growth, with a year-over-year decline of -1.59%. These metrics signal a tight labor market with rising labor costs.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is 0.22% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.149% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a labor demand contraction, as hours are not running above trend despite modest job growth. This suggests that the labor market is not experiencing genuine demand expansion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is 4.20%, ranking it at the 64th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the low unemployment rate puts upward pressure on wages. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is 5.99%, ranking it at the 86th percentile, indicating fast wage growth. This implies that labor costs for employers are rising, while worker purchasing power is increasing. As a result, businesses may need to factor in higher labor costs when considering this location.

Cost of Living

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont has a cost of living score ranking it at the 20th percentile, with a PSF of \$629/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$49.82, resulting in a ratio of 12.63. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive, which may make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The fact that PSF is falling -4.8% year-over-year is a positive sign, but the overall affordability score remains low.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is declining -1.59% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor pool. This signals a structural headwind for hiring, as the shrinking labor force may limit the availability of skilled workers. Businesses may need to consider this constraint when planning their workforce expansion.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is increasing 32.14% year-over-year, indicating an expansion of housing supply. This suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may improve, as the increased supply of housing may help to moderate prices.

Days on Market

The median days on market in San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont is 39 days, with a year-over-year decline of -13.3%. This indicates a highly competitive market, where homes are selling quickly. As a result, relocating workers may face challenges in finding affordable housing, which could impact their decision to move to this city.

Office Economy

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont has an office economy score ranking it at the 52nd percentile, with a share of professional and office workers indicating a moderately deep talent pool. This city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors, but may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area offers businesses a highly skilled and productive workforce, with strong wage growth and a deep talent pool. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the low labor force growth, which may limit the availability of skilled workers and drive up labor costs.

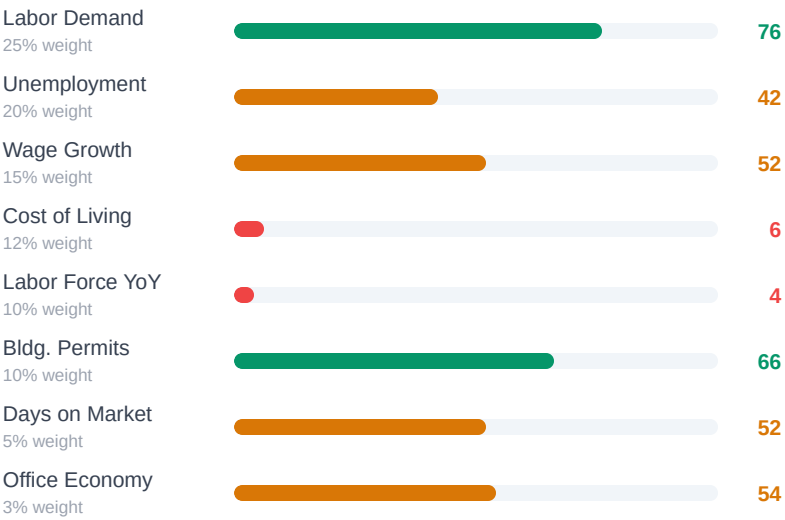
Los Angeles

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim

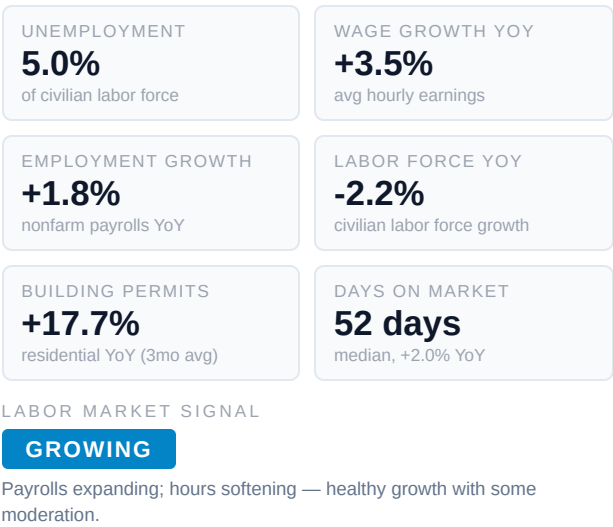
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
47.2th percentile
Rank 26 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 47.2th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand, with a composite score of 6.18 ranking it at the 76th percentile, and its cost of living, which is ranked at the 6th percentile due to a high PSF to wages ratio of \$659/sqft to \$41.61/hr. The labor demand and cost of living metrics provide a mixed picture of the city's economic health.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is 1.83% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.681% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, as jobs are being added and hours are running above trend, indicating a strong labor market. The labor demand composite score of 6.18 confirms this, ranking the city at the 76th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is 5.00%, ranking it at the 42nd percentile. This rate indicates a near-median level of slack in the labor market, making it neither extremely tight nor very loose. For a business trying to hire in this city, the moderate unemployment rate means that finding talent may be manageable, but not extremely easy or difficult.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is 3.48%, ranking it at the 52nd percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not extremely quickly. At the same time, worker purchasing power is increasing, which can have positive effects on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim has a cost of living ranked at the 6th percentile, indicating that it is one of the more expensive cities in the US. The PSF to wages ratio of \$659/sqft to \$41.61/hr is high, making it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums. However, the fact that PSF is falling -1.9% year-over-year may provide some relief in the future.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is shrinking at a rate of -2.24% year-over-year, ranking it at the 4th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply poses a significant structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is decreasing.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is increasing by 17.69% year-over-year, ranking it at the 66th percentile. This expansion in housing supply is a positive sign for future affordability and workforce accommodation, as it may help to alleviate some of the pressure on the housing market.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is 52 days, with a year-over-year increase of 2.0%. This indicates a near-median level of market competitiveness, making it neither extremely fast nor slow for workers to find housing. However, the rising days on market may signal a healthy normalization of the market.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim is ranked at the 54th percentile, indicating a moderate depth of talent pool. This city is suited for businesses that require a mix of professional and non-professional workers, but may not be the best fit for those requiring a highly specialized or deep knowledge-economy talent pool.

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area offers a mixed picture for businesses, with a strong labor demand and moderate wage growth, but also a high cost of living and shrinking labor force supply. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the challenging labor market conditions, particularly the shrinking labor force supply, which may make it difficult to find and retain talent.

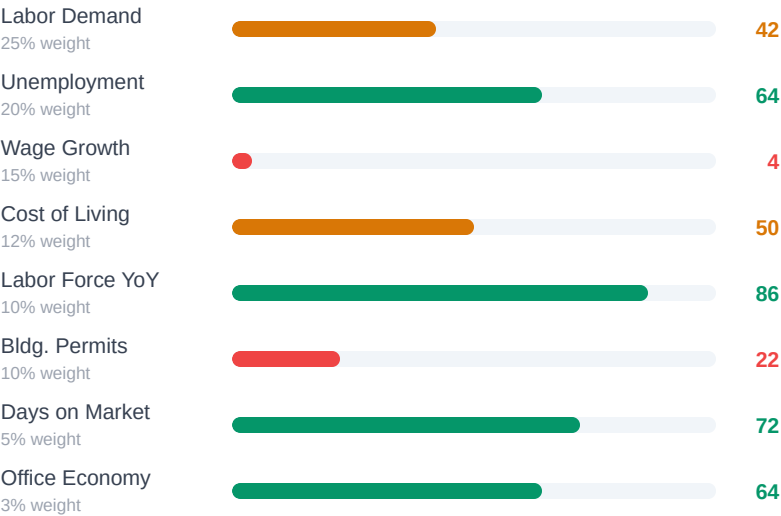
Cleveland

Cleveland

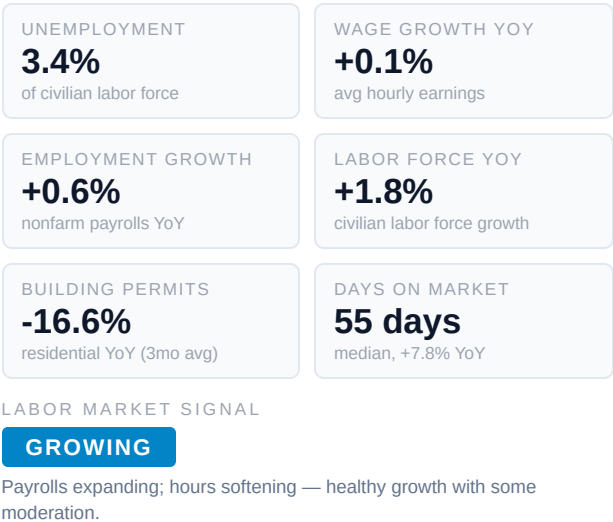
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
46.2th percentile
Rank 27 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cleveland, with an overall grade of B- and a composite score ranking it 46.2th percentile out of 50 US metros, is characterized by its near-median labor demand and low wage growth. The city's economic character is most defined by its labor force growth of +1.80% YoY, ranking it in the top tier (86th percentile), and its stagnant wage growth of +0.10% YoY, placing it in the bottom tier (4th percentile). These metrics suggest a city with an expanding workforce but struggling to increase earnings.

Labor Demand

Cleveland's employment growth rate is +0.57% YoY, and its weekly hours deviation from trend is -0.438%, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 4.66, which ranks near the median (42th percentile). This combination signals a moderate expansion of jobs, but with hours worked below trend, indicating some degree of survivor squeeze. The city is adding jobs, but the existing workforce is not seeing a significant increase in hours worked.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Cleveland is 3.40%, ranking it above average (64th percentile), indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight market also suggests that workers may have more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

Cleveland's YoY wage growth rate is +0.10%, which is stagnant and ranks in the bottom tier (4th percentile). This slow wage growth means that labor costs for employers are not increasing significantly, but it also implies weak bargaining power for workers and limited growth in purchasing power. Businesses may benefit from a flat cost environment, but workers may not see significant improvements in their earnings.

Cost of Living

Cleveland's cost of living, with a PSF of \$143/sqft and an earnings ratio of 4.21, ranks near the median (50th percentile). However, the PSF has increased by 13.5% YoY, making the city less affordable. This means that the city may not have a significant talent attraction advantage without offering wage premiums to offset the rising cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Cleveland is growing at a rate of +1.80% YoY, ranking it in the top tier (86th percentile). This expanding workforce supply is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it indicates a growing pool of potential workers. The increasing labor force can help support business growth and expansion.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Cleveland has decreased by -16.61% YoY, ranking it below average (22th percentile). This decline in permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. The decrease in permits is a concern for businesses that rely on a stable and affordable housing market for their workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Cleveland is 55 days, with a YoY increase of +7.8%, ranking it above average (72th percentile). This means that homes are sitting on the market for a relatively longer period, making it a more accessible market for workers relocating to the city. The slower market can give workers more time to find a suitable home, reducing the stress of relocation.

Office Economy

Cleveland's professional and office worker share ranks above average (64th percentile), indicating a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. The city is well-suited for businesses that require specialized knowledge-economy workers, but may not be as attractive for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

In conclusion, Cleveland offers businesses a growing labor force and a relatively tight labor market, but also presents challenges such as stagnant wage growth and a tightening housing market. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's slow wage growth, which may limit the attractiveness of the city to workers and hinder business growth.

Birmingham

Birmingham

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
46.0th percentile
Rank 28 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		54
Unemployment 20% weight		42
Wage Growth 15% weight		10
Cost of Living 12% weight		57
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		38
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		86
Days on Market 5% weight		40
Office Economy 3% weight		46

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.7% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +0.6% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.7% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -0.3% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS +39.5% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 58 days median, +1.8% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Birmingham, with an overall grade of B- and a composite score ranking it at the 46.0th percentile among 50 US metros, is characterized by its near-median labor demand and bottom-tier wage growth. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.35, driven by a +0.65% employment growth rate and a +0.140% weekly hours deviation from its own trend, signals a genuine but modest demand expansion. The unemployment rate and wage growth are the two metrics that most define this city's current economic character, with the latter being a significant concern.

Labor Demand

Birmingham's employment growth rate of +0.65% and weekly hours deviation of +0.140% from its own trend indicate a modest expansion in labor demand. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, rather than a survivor squeeze or contraction. The near-median labor demand composite score of 5.35 suggests a stable but unremarkable job market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Birmingham stands at 3.70%, ranking it at the 42nd percentile. This rate indicates a near-median level of slack in the labor market, suggesting that while it may not be extremely difficult to hire, there is not an overwhelming surplus of workers either. For a business trying to hire in this city, the moderate unemployment rate implies a manageable but not highly competitive hiring environment.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of +0.57%, Birmingham ranks at the 10th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth implies a flat cost environment for employers but weak bargaining power for workers. As a result, worker purchasing power is not increasing significantly, which could impact local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Birmingham's cost of living, with a PSF of \$160/sqft and an earnings ratio of \$32.79/hr, resulting in a ratio of 4.88, ranks it at the 57th percentile in terms of affordability. This near-median ranking suggests that the city is neither extremely affordable nor overly expensive relative to its peers. The -1.2% YoY decrease in PSF is a positive sign for affordability. This means that Birmingham can attract talent without necessarily requiring significant wage premiums, although it does not stand out as a particularly affordable option.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Birmingham is shrinking at a rate of -0.28% year-over-year. This contraction in labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of potential workers is decreasing. For businesses looking to expand or establish operations in

the city, this trend implies that finding and retaining talent may become increasingly challenging over time.

Building Permits

Birmingham has seen a significant increase of +39.50% in residential building permits year-over-year, ranking it at the 86th percentile. This surge in permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodate workforce growth in the future. This is a positive signal for businesses considering relocation, as it indicates that the city is likely to become more attractive to potential employees due to an increasing supply of housing.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Birmingham is 58 days, with a year-over-year increase of +1.8%. This indicates a near-median pace of home sales, neither extremely fast nor slow. For a worker relocating to this city, the market is somewhat competitive but still accessible, with homes not selling at an exceptionally rapid pace.

Office Economy

Birmingham's professional and office worker share, ranked at the 46th percentile, suggests a moderately deep talent pool suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, or HQ sectors. However, it is not as strong as in cities with a higher concentration of such industries. This city is best suited for businesses that can thrive in a mixed economy with a moderate presence of professional services, but it may not be the ideal location for those requiring a highly specialized or abundant office-based workforce.

In conclusion, Birmingham offers a stable but unremarkable economic environment for businesses, with modest labor demand expansion and significant concerns around stagnant wage growth. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker to factor in is the shrinking labor force, which poses a challenge for hiring and talent retention. Despite this, the city's expanding housing supply and moderate cost of living are positives that could attract businesses looking for a balance between affordability and access to a diverse workforce.

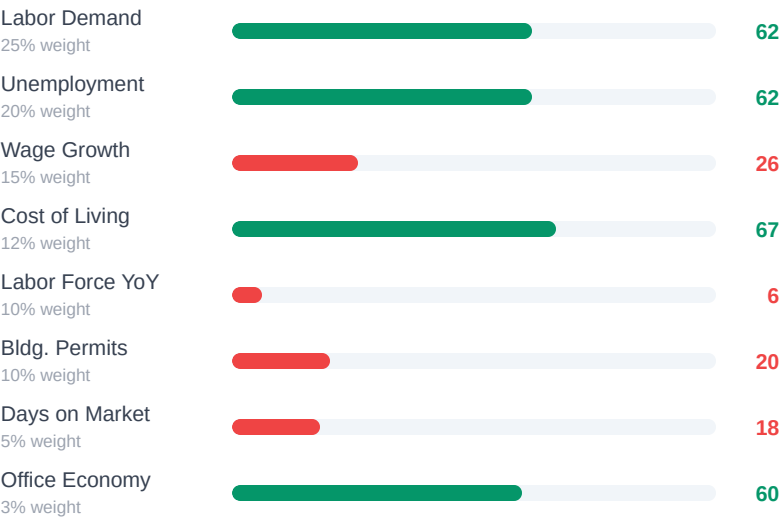
Denver

Denver-Aurora-Centennial

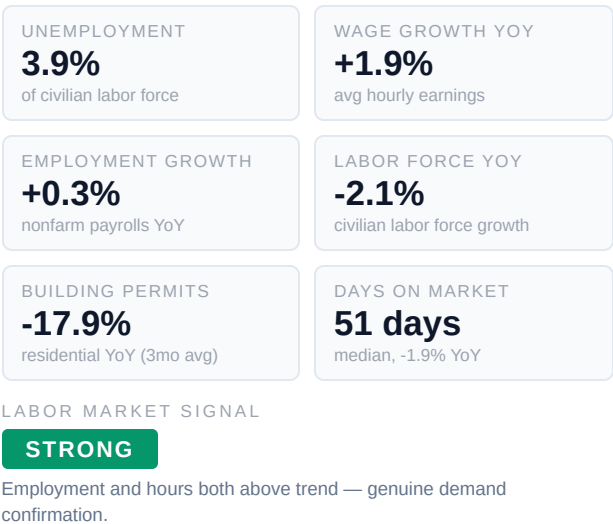
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
45.2th percentile
Rank 29 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 45.2th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its above-average labor demand, with a composite score of 5.42, and its below-average wage growth, at +1.94% year-over-year. The labor demand is driven by employment growth of +0.31% and weekly hours deviation of +0.687% from its own trend.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.31% and hours deviation of +0.687% signal genuine demand expansion, as both metrics are above average. This combination indicates that the city is experiencing an increase in jobs and workers are putting in more hours, suggesting a strong labor market. The labor demand composite score of 5.42 further supports this, ranking it above average at the 62nd percentile.

Unemployment

The actual unemployment rate is 3.90%, which is above average, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as there are fewer unemployed workers available. The practical implication is that companies may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent in this market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate is +1.94%, which is below average, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth means that employer labor costs are not increasing rapidly, but it also implies that worker purchasing power is not growing strongly. As a result, businesses may not face significant pressure to increase wages, but workers may not have as much disposable income to spend.

Cost of Living

The city has a cost of living percentile rank of 67th, indicating that it is more affordable relative to its peers. The PSF of \$284/sqft is decreasing by -3.1% year-over-year, and the ratio of PSF to hourly earnings of \$42.59/hr is 6.67. This affordability advantage means that businesses can attract talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The year-over-year growth rate of the civilian labor force is -2.15%, indicating that the labor force is contracting. This means that the supply of workers is shrinking, which can create a structural headwind for hiring. Businesses may need to consider this constraint when planning their workforce expansion.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -17.89%, indicating that housing supply is tightening. This decline in permits suggests that the future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 51 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -1.9%. This relatively fast market means that homes are selling quickly, which can make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. However, the decrease in days on market suggests that the market may be normalizing slightly.

Office Economy

The city has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy percentile rank of 60th. This makes it well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. However, it may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area offers businesses a relatively tight labor market with above-average labor demand, but also presents challenges such as stagnant wage growth and a contracting labor force. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor force, which can limit hiring capacity and create structural headwinds for workforce expansion.

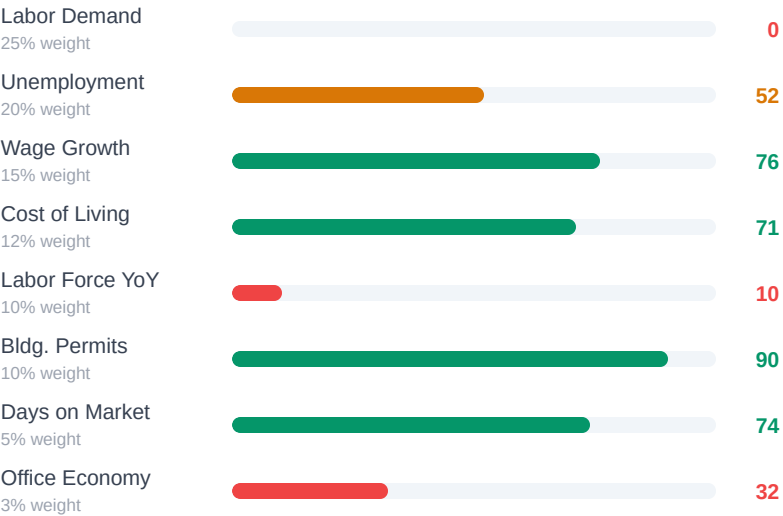
Washington DC

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria

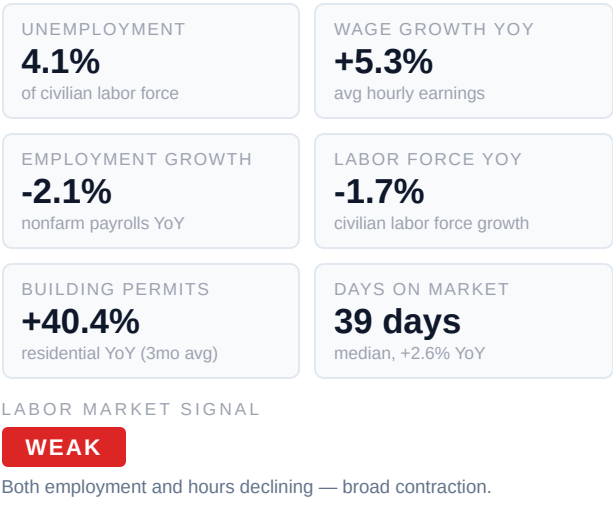
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
45.0th percentile
Rank 30 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Washington-Arlington-Alexandria metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 45.0th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its weak labor demand, with a labor demand composite score of 1.50, and its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 5.31% in hourly earnings. The combination of a -2.15% employment growth rate and a -0.969% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend suggests a contraction in labor demand.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is -2.15%, indicating a decline in job additions, while the weekly hours deviation from its own trend is -0.969%, signaling hours are below trend. This combination suggests a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion or survivor squeeze. The labor demand composite score of 1.50 is in the bottom tier, reinforcing this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 4.10%, which is near the median, ranking at the 52nd percentile. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, it's not so high as to indicate significant weakness in local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 5.31%, which is above average, ranking at the 76th percentile. This indicates strong wage growth, suggesting rising labor costs for employers but also good worker purchasing power. Employers should factor in the potential for increasing labor costs when considering this location.

Cost of Living

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria has a cost of living score that ranks at the 71st percentile, with a PSF of \$305/sqft and hourly earnings of \$45.17, resulting in a ratio of 6.75. The PSF is decreasing by 1.9% year-over-year, which is a key driver of its above-average affordability score. This makes the city more attractive for talent without needing significant wage premiums, as the cost of living is relatively more affordable compared to peer cities.

Labor Force Growth

The labor force in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is shrinking at a rate of -1.70% year-over-year, indicating a contraction in the workforce supply. This suggests a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of potential employees is decreasing.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria has increased by 40.37% year-over-year, which is in the top tier, ranking at the 90th percentile. This significant increase signals that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodate workforce growth in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 39 days, with a year-over-year increase of 2.6%. This ranks at the 74th percentile, indicating a slightly slower market. For workers relocating to this city, the housing market is relatively accessible, although the slight increase in days on market may signal a normalization rather than a highly competitive environment.

Office Economy

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria has an office economy score that ranks at the 32nd percentile, indicating a less deep professional talent pool compared to other cities. This city is less suited for businesses requiring a strong presence of tech, finance, or consulting talent but may be more appropriate for industries with less specialized office needs.

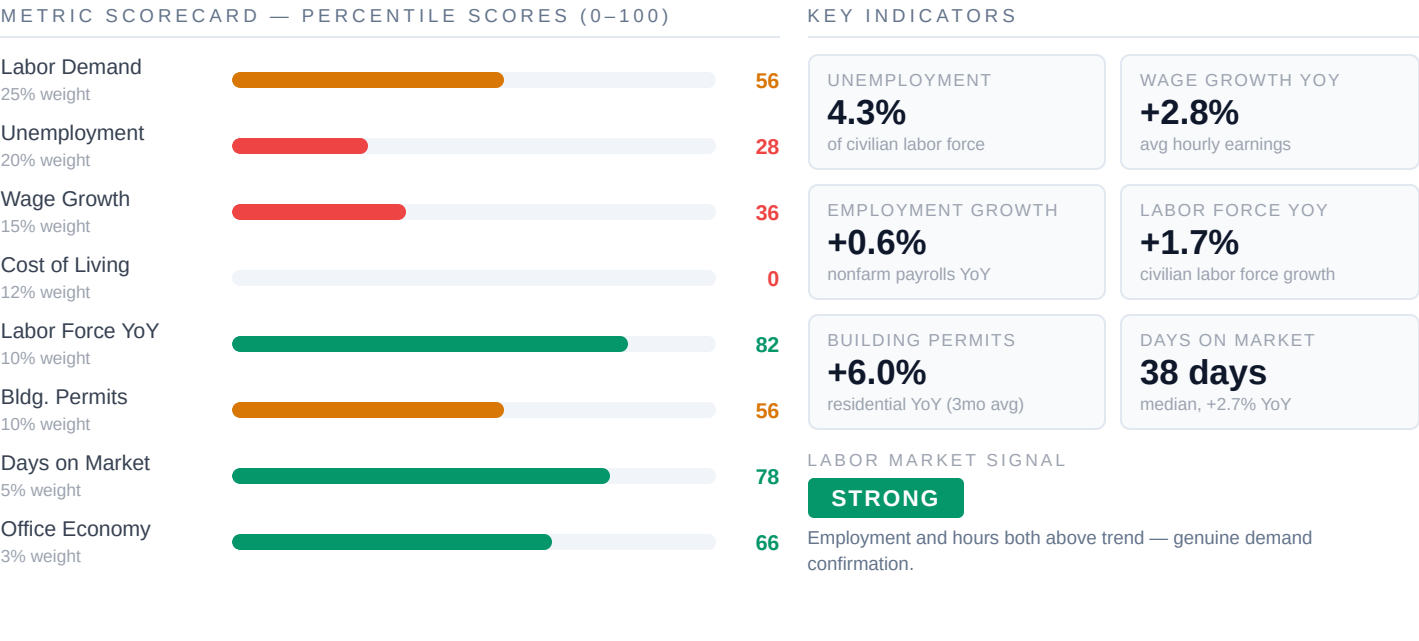
The bottom line for businesses considering Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is that while it offers strong wage growth and an expanding housing supply, its weak labor demand and shrinking labor force are significant constraints. The single biggest risk for a decision-maker is the challenge in finding and hiring talent due to the contracting labor pool, which could hinder business growth and expansion plans.

Providence

Providence-Warwick

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
44.7th percentile
Rank 31 of 50 metros



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Providence-Warwick metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it 44.7th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 4.30% and its high cost of living, with a PSF to wages ratio of 10.10, ranking it at the 0th percentile for affordability. The labor demand composite score of 5.37, near the median at the 56th percentile, also plays a significant role in shaping the local economy.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Providence-Warwick is +0.60% year-over-year, combined with a +0.226% deviation in weekly hours from its own 12-month baseline. This signals a genuine demand expansion, as both jobs and hours worked are increasing. The labor demand composite score of 5.37, near the median, further supports this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Providence-Warwick is 4.30%, ranking it at the 28th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight market also implies upward pressure on wages.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Providence-Warwick is +2.76%, which is below average, ranking it at the 36th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace, and worker purchasing power is increasing, albeit not rapidly. This could impact businesses' decisions on staffing and compensation.

Cost of Living

Providence-Warwick has a cost of living score ranking it at the 0th percentile, with a PSF to wages ratio of 10.10, driven by a PSF of \$367/sqft that has increased by 8.6% year-over-year, compared to hourly earnings of \$36.34. This makes the city one of the more expensive places to live, which could hinder talent attraction without offering wage premiums to offset the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Providence-Warwick is growing at a rate of +1.69% year-over-year, ranking it at the 82nd percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it suggests a larger pool of potential employees.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Providence-Warwick has increased by +5.95% year-over-year, ranking it near the median at the 56th percentile. This suggests that housing supply is expanding, which could improve affordability and accommodation for the workforce in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Providence-Warwick is 38 days, with a year-over-year increase of +2.7%, ranking it at the 78th percentile. This indicates a slower market, which could make it more accessible for workers relocating to the city, as they have more time to find a home.

Office Economy

Providence-Warwick has an office economy score ranking it at the 66th percentile, with a share of professional and office workers indicating a deep talent pool. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less ideal for those in industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Providence-Warwick metro area offers businesses a growing labor force and an expanding housing supply, but its high cost of living and tight labor market pose significant challenges. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the need to offer competitive wages to attract and retain talent in this expensive city, which could impact business profitability and growth plans.

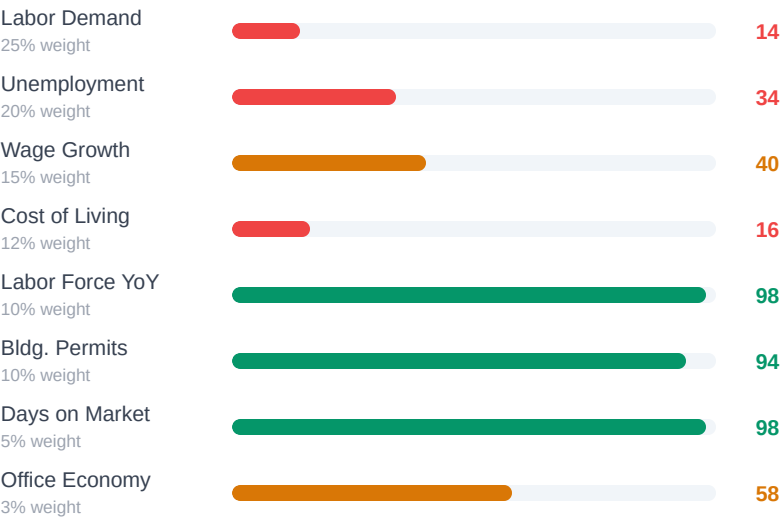
Boston

Boston-Cambridge-Newton

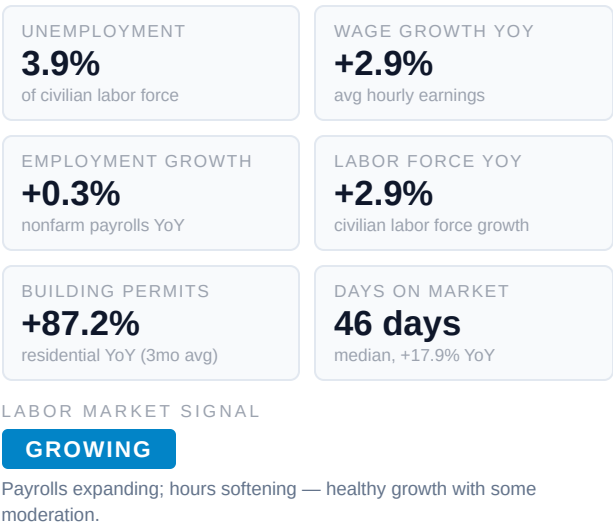
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
44.1th percentile
Rank 32 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Boston-Cambridge-Newton metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 44.1th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor force growth, with a year-over-year increase of 2.87%, and its high cost of living, with a PSF to earnings ratio of 10.45. The labor demand composite score of 3.73, ranking in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile, also plays a significant role in shaping the city's economic landscape.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is 0.27% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.951% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, as the small increase in employment is accompanied by a decrease in hours worked. This suggests that the city is not experiencing genuine demand expansion, but rather a potential survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is 3.90%, ranking in the below-average tier at the 34th percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market with some slack, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire in this city. As a result, businesses may face some wage pressure when trying to attract and retain talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is 2.89%, ranking near the median at the 40th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so. At the same time, workers in the city are experiencing a modest increase in purchasing power.

Cost of Living

Boston-Cambridge-Newton has a cost of living percentile rank of 16, indicating that it is an expensive city relative to its peers. The PSF to earnings ratio of 10.45, with PSF at \$474/sqft and earnings at \$45.37/hr, highlights the challenge of attracting talent without offering wage premiums. However, the fact that PSF is falling by 1.0% year-over-year is a positive sign for affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is growing at a rate of 2.87% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 98th percentile. This rapid expansion of the labor force supply suggests that businesses have a large and growing pool of potential workers to draw from, making it easier to hire and staff operations.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is increasing by 87.24% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 94th percentile. This surge in building permits indicates that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodation options for the workforce in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is 46 days, with a year-over-year increase of 17.9%. This rising days on market, ranking in the top tier at the 98th percentile, suggests a slowing market that is becoming more accessible for relocating workers. However, the relatively fast pace of sales still indicates a competitive market.

Office Economy

Boston-Cambridge-Newton has a deep professional talent pool, ranking in the near-median tier at the 58th percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors that require a high concentration of office workers. However, it may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Boston-Cambridge-Newton metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a growing labor force and expanding housing supply, making it an attractive location for companies looking to hire and staff operations. However, the city's high cost of living and moderate wage growth rate pose significant challenges for businesses trying to attract and retain talent without offering substantial wage premiums, which is the single biggest risk or constraint that decision-makers should factor in when considering this location.

San Diego

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad

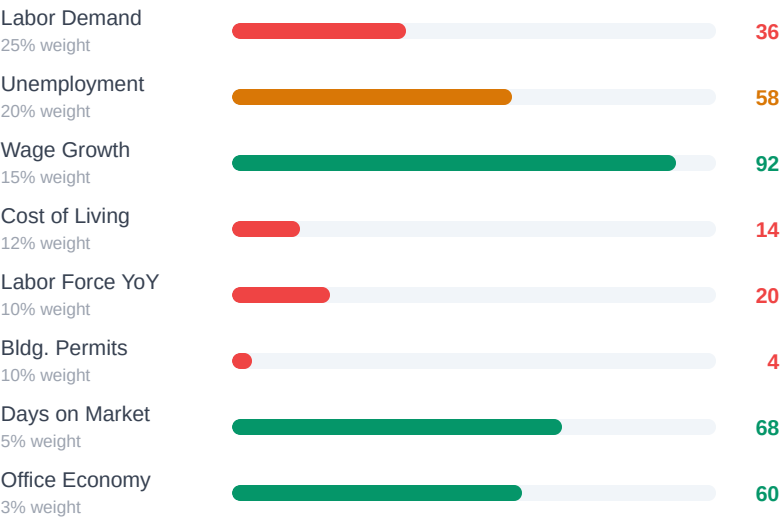
C+

POOR

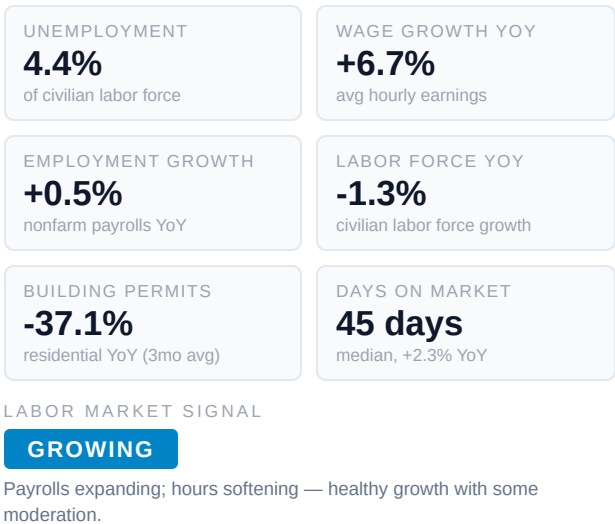
43.7th percentile

Rank 33 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 43.7th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 6.72%, and its high cost of living, with a PSF to wages ratio of 13.69. The combination of these two metrics suggests a challenging environment for businesses looking to attract and retain talent without offering significant wage premiums.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 0.51% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.482% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not experiencing genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 4.53 further reinforces this assessment, ranking below average at the 36th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 4.40%, ranking near the median at the 58th percentile. This suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, the unemployment rate is not low enough to indicate a significant surplus of available workers.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 6.72%, ranking in the top tier at the 92nd percentile. This rapid wage growth signals rising labor costs for employers, but also indicates strong worker purchasing power. Businesses operating in this city can expect to face increasing pressure to adjust their compensation packages to remain competitive.

Cost of Living

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has a cost of living percentile rank of 14th, indicating that it is an expensive city relative to its peers. The PSF to wages ratio of 13.69, with PSF at \$600/sqft and wages at \$43.84/hr, further reinforces this assessment. This means that businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract talent, as the high cost of living can be a significant deterrent.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is contracting at a rate of -1.30% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 20th percentile. This decline in labor force supply signals a structural headwind for hiring, making it more challenging for businesses to find and retain workers.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is -37.09%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile. This sharp decline in building permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which can lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for workforce accommodation.

Days on Market

The median days on market in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 45 days, with a year-over-year increase of 2.3%. This signals a slightly slower market, ranking above average at the 68th percentile. For workers relocating to this city, the market is relatively accessible, but the rising days on market may indicate a normalization of the market rather than a significant slowdown.

Office Economy

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has a professional and office worker share of 2.92, ranking above average at the 60th percentile. This indicates a deep talent pool suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. However, the city may be less suited for industries with significant industrial or logistics requirements.

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area offers businesses a strong and growing economy with a highly skilled workforce, but also presents significant challenges in terms of cost of living and labor force growth. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the high cost of living, which can make it difficult to attract and retain talent without offering substantial wage premiums, potentially eroding profit margins and competitiveness.

Fresno

Fresno

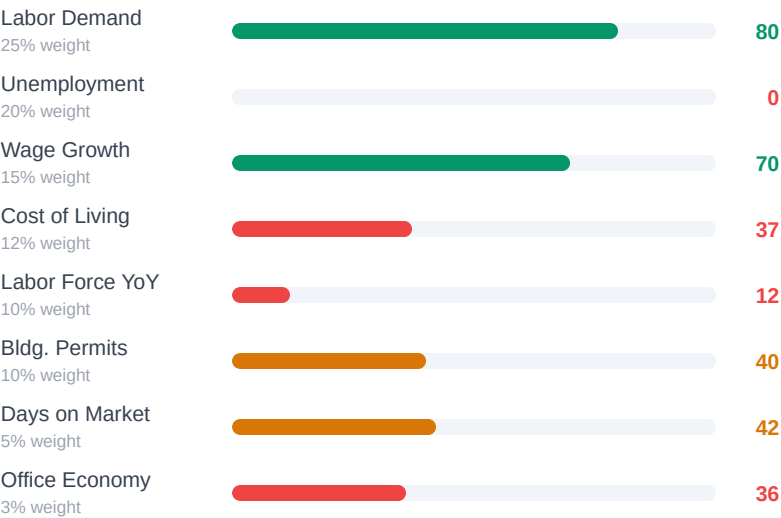
C+

POOR

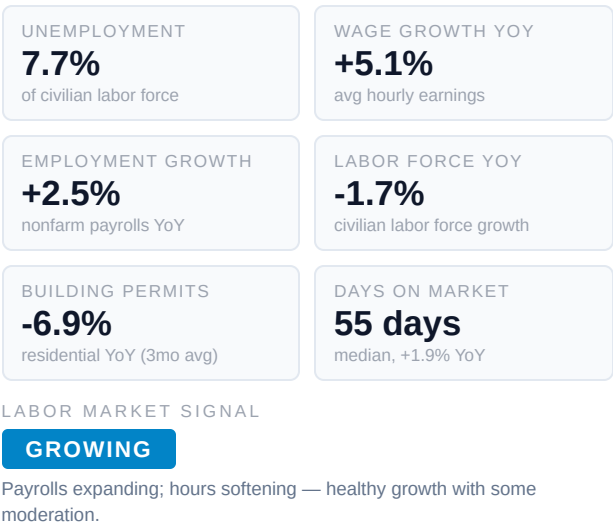
43.3th percentile

Rank 34 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The city of Fresno has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 43.3th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its high labor demand, with an 80th percentile ranking, and its low unemployment rate, which is actually a concern due to its bottom tier ranking of 0th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. Specifically, the labor demand composite score of 6.28 and the unemployment rate of 7.70% are key metrics that shape the city's economic landscape.

Labor Demand

Fresno's employment growth rate is 2.47% year-over-year, and its weekly hours deviation from trend is -1.481%, resulting in a labor demand composite score that signals genuine demand expansion. This combination indicates that the city is adding jobs and, despite hours being slightly below trend, is experiencing a genuine increase in labor demand. The top tier ranking of 80th percentile for labor demand suggests a strong job market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Fresno is 7.70%, which is in the bottom tier, ranking 0th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market with little slack. This tight market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is limited, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate suggests that workers have strong bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Fresno is 5.14%, ranking above average at the 70th percentile. This moderate to fast wage growth rate implies that labor costs for employers are rising, while workers are experiencing an increase in purchasing power. As a result, businesses may need to factor in higher labor costs, while workers may enjoy improved living standards.

Cost of Living

Fresno has a cost of living ratio of \$263/sqft to \$33.85/hr, resulting in a below average ranking of 37th percentile. This means that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which may make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The static year-over-year change in PSF of 0.0% does not provide relief, suggesting that affordability is not improving.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Fresno is contracting at a rate of -1.69% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at 12th percentile. This decline in labor force supply implies that the city's hiring capacity may be constrained, making it challenging for businesses to find the talent they need. The shrinking labor pool is a structural headwind for hiring.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Fresno is -6.89%, ranking near the median at 40th percentile. This decline in permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for housing, ultimately affecting the city's ability to attract and accommodate workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Fresno is 55 days, with a year-over-year increase of 1.9%. This near median ranking of 42nd percentile indicates a relatively balanced market, neither extremely competitive nor extremely accessible. However, the rising days on market may signal a normalization of the market, making it slightly easier for relocating workers to find housing.

Office Economy

Fresno's professional and office worker share is ranked below average at 36th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This suggests that the city is less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but may be more suitable for industries with different workforce requirements.

The city of Fresno offers a strong labor demand and moderate wage growth, making it an attractive location for businesses that can navigate its tight labor market and relatively high cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's shrinking labor force, which may limit hiring capacity and require businesses to offer competitive wages to attract and retain talent.

Miami

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach

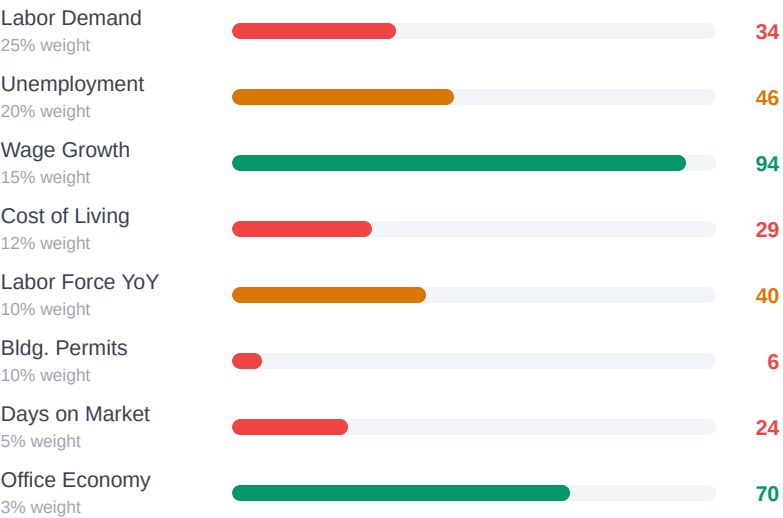
C+

POOR

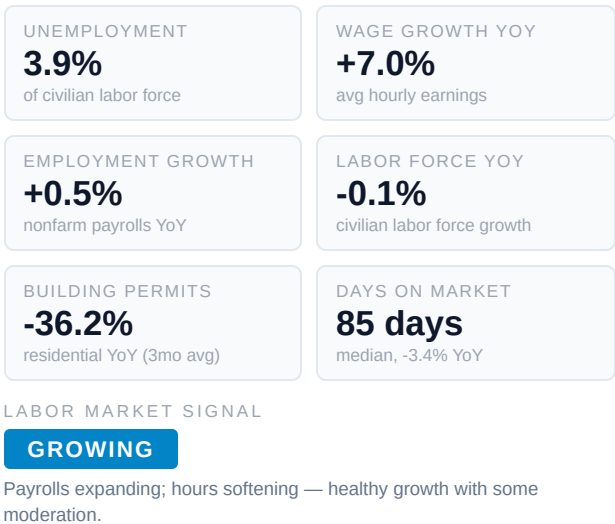
43.1th percentile

Rank 35 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 43.1th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 7.02%, and its struggling labor demand, with a composite score of 4.52, ranking below average at the 34th percentile. These metrics suggest a complex economic environment with both opportunities and challenges for businesses.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 0.48% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.452% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, as the modest job growth is not sufficient to offset the decline in working hours, indicating a potential survivor squeeze where remaining workers absorb the load of eliminated roles. This scenario may lead to increased productivity pressures on the existing workforce.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 3.90%, ranking near the median at the 46th percentile. This suggests a relatively balanced labor market with neither significant tightness nor slack. For businesses trying to hire in this market, the moderate unemployment rate implies a manageable but not overly competitive environment for attracting talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 7.02%, placing it in the top tier at the 94th percentile. This rapid wage growth indicates rising labor costs for employers but also signifies strong worker purchasing power. Businesses operating in this market should anticipate increasing wage pressures and plan accordingly to maintain competitiveness.

Cost of Living

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach has a cost of living score ranking it below average at the 29th percentile, with a PSF to earnings ratio of \$356/sqft to \$34.68/hr, or 10.27. Although the PSF is decreasing by 0.8% year-over-year, the city remains relatively expensive compared to its peers. This expense may necessitate wage premiums to attract talent, potentially offsetting some of the benefits of the strong wage growth.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is growing at a rate of -0.14% year-over-year, indicating a slight contraction in the labor pool. This modest decline suggests a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential workers is not expanding. Businesses may face challenges in finding sufficient talent to support growth initiatives.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -36.23%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile. This significant decline in building permits signals a tightening of the housing supply, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased challenges for workforce accommodation in the future. This trend poses a risk to the city's ability to attract and retain workers.

Days on Market

The current median days on market for homes in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 85 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -3.4%. This relatively fast market, with homes selling quickly, may pose challenges for relocating workers trying to find housing. The competitive housing market could necessitate relocation assistance or other incentives to attract talent.

Office Economy

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach has an office economy score ranking it above average at the 70th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool in professional and office sectors. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ operations that rely on specialized knowledge workers. However, it may be less ideal for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for certain types of businesses. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, signaled by the sharp decline in building permits, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in attracting and retaining workers.

Virginia Beach

Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk

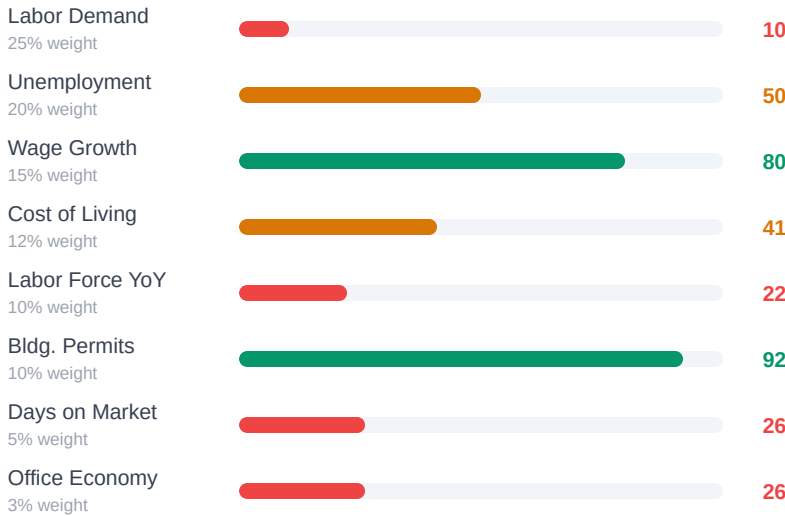
C+

POOR

42.9th percentile

Rank 36 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.0%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+5.5%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.7%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-1.1%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

+77.2%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

39 days
median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 42.9th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its weak labor demand, with a labor demand composite score in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile, and strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 5.54% in hourly earnings, ranking it in the top tier at the 80th percentile. These two metrics suggest a complex economic environment with both challenges and opportunities.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in this metro area is -0.68% year-over-year, and weekly hours are only 0.075% above the 12-month trend, indicating a contraction in labor demand rather than genuine expansion. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. The labor demand composite score of 3.27 is in the bottom tier, confirming the weak labor market conditions.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in this metro area is 4.00%, which is near the median, ranking it at the 50th percentile. This suggests a relatively balanced labor market with neither significant tightness nor slack. For a business trying to hire in this area, the moderate unemployment rate implies a manageable but not overly competitive hiring environment.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in this metro area is 5.54%, which is relatively fast and ranks in the top tier at the 80th percentile. This rapid wage growth implies increasing labor costs for employers but also stronger purchasing power for workers. Businesses should factor in the potential for rising labor costs when considering this location.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$224/sqft to \$35.13/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.38, and a percentile rank of 41, this city is near the median in terms of affordability. The PSF is increasing by 2.8% year-over-year, which does not help affordability. This moderate affordability means that businesses may not have a significant talent attraction advantage without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in this metro area is shrinking by -1.05% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor supply. This negative growth rate, ranking in the 22nd percentile, suggests a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of potential workers is decreasing.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits has increased by 77.17% year-over-year, which is a very strong signal of developer confidence and an expanding future housing supply. This top-tier growth, ranking at the 92nd percentile, suggests that affordability may improve, and the city may become more attractive for workforce accommodation.

Days on Market

Homes in this metro area are currently sitting on the market for a median of 39 days, with no year-over-year change. This relatively fast market, ranking in the 26th percentile, implies that relocating workers may face a competitive housing market, which could be a challenge for businesses trying to attract talent.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in this metro area is below average, ranking in the 26th percentile. This suggests a less deep talent pool for businesses requiring specialized knowledge-economy workers, making it less suited for tech, finance, or consulting headquarters decisions but potentially more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

In conclusion, the Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area offers a complex economic environment with strong wage growth but weak labor demand and a shrinking labor force. The single biggest risk or constraint for a business considering this location is the challenging labor market conditions, which could impact hiring capacity and labor costs. Despite these challenges, the area's strong building permit growth suggests potential for future improvements in affordability and workforce accommodation.

Phoenix

Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler

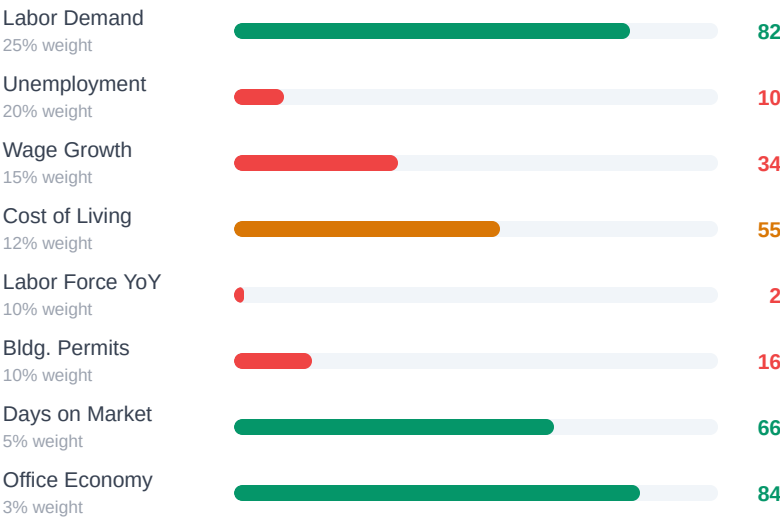
C+

POOR

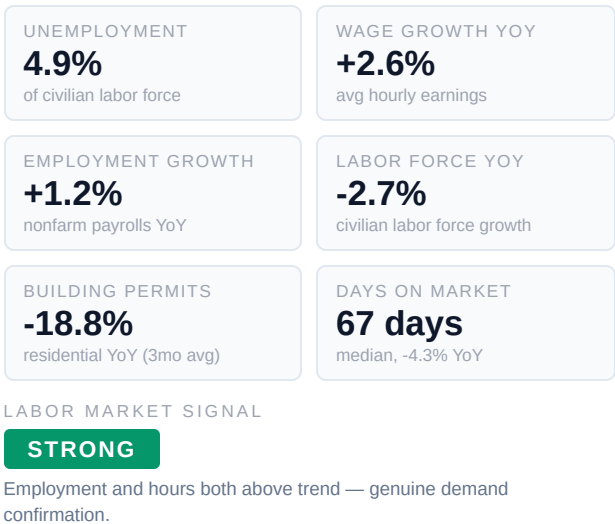
41.8th percentile

Rank 37 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 41.8th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with an 82nd percentile ranking, and its low unemployment rate, which is in the 10th percentile. Specifically, the labor demand composite score of 6.34 and the unemployment rate of 4.90% are key metrics that shape the city's economic landscape.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is +1.23% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating +0.313% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as both jobs and hours are increasing, indicating a strong and growing labor market. The labor demand composite score of 6.34, ranked in the 82nd percentile, further reinforces this trend.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is 4.90%, which is in the 10th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with little slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city may face challenges in finding available workers, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate suggests that workers have significant bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is +2.61%, which is ranked in the 34th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that employer labor costs are rising, but not excessively so, and that workers have some, but not significant, purchasing power gains. The moderate wage growth may help attract workers, but may not be sufficient to drive significant economic growth.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler, with a PSF of \$267/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$37.56/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.11, is ranked in the 55th percentile, indicating a near-median affordability level. The fact that PSF is falling -1.5% year-over-year relative to wages suggests some improvement in affordability. This means that the city may have a moderate talent attraction advantage, as workers may not require significant wage premiums to afford the cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is contracting at a rate of -2.70% year-over-year, which is ranked in the 2nd percentile, indicating a significant structural headwind for hiring. The shrinking labor pool means that businesses may face challenges in finding workers, and may need to invest in training and development programs to attract and retain talent.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is -18.76%, which is ranked in the 16th percentile, indicating a tightening housing supply. This suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of housing is not keeping pace with demand. The decline in building permits may lead to increased housing costs and reduced affordability.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is 67 days, with a year-over-year decline of -4.3%. The 66th percentile ranking indicates a relatively fast market, but the decline in days on market suggests some normalization. This means that workers relocating to this city may face a competitive housing market, but the normalization trend may make it more accessible.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is 3.52, ranked in the 84th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This city is well-suited for businesses that require specialized knowledge-economy workers, but may not be as attractive for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area offers businesses a strong labor demand and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for knowledge-economy businesses. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tight labor market and shrinking labor pool, which may lead to significant challenges in finding and retaining workers, and may require investments in training and development programs to attract and retain talent.

Milwaukee

Milwaukee-Waukesha

C+

POOR

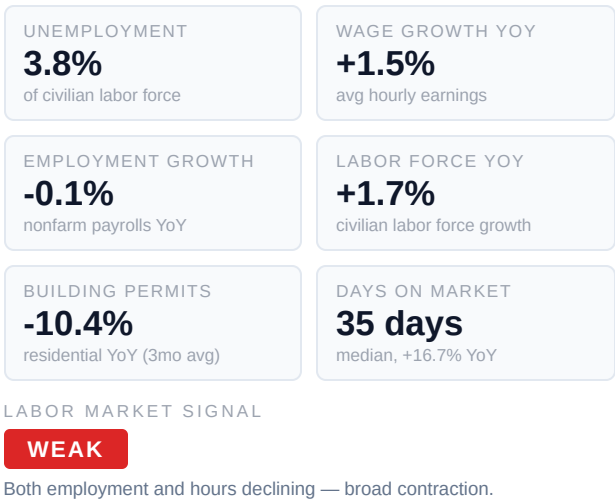
40.9th percentile

Rank 38 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Milwaukee-Waukesha metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 40.9th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score of 4.17, and its slow wage growth, at +1.46% year-over-year. The labor demand metric, in particular, signals a contraction in the job market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Milwaukee-Waukesha is -0.09% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -1.171% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in the job market, rather than genuine demand expansion or survivor squeeze. The low labor demand composite score of 4.17, ranking in the 24th percentile, further reinforces this notion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Milwaukee-Waukesha is 3.80%, which is relatively low and ranks in the 68th percentile. This indicates a tight labor market with some slack, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire in this city. As a result, businesses may face some wage pressure when trying to attract and retain talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Milwaukee-Waukesha is +1.46%, which is relatively slow and ranks in the 16th percentile. This slow wage growth implies a flat cost environment for employers, but it also means workers have weak bargaining power. As a result, businesses may not face significant labor cost pressures, but workers may not have strong purchasing power either.

Cost of Living

Milwaukee-Waukesha has a cost of living score that ranks in the 18th percentile, with a PSF of \$227/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$36.01/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.30. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive, which could make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The fact that PSF is rising +1.8% year-over-year further exacerbates the affordability concerns.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Milwaukee-Waukesha is growing at a rate of +1.66% year-over-year, which ranks in the 80th percentile. This indicates that the labor force supply is expanding, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire in this city. The growing labor force can help mitigate some of the hiring challenges posed by the tight labor market.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Milwaukee-Waukesha is decreasing by -10.38% year-over-year, which ranks in the 30th percentile. This decline in building permits signals a tightening of the housing supply, which could lead to affordability concerns and

challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Milwaukee-Waukesha is currently 35 days, with a year-over-year increase of +16.7%, ranking in the 96th percentile. This indicates a relatively slow market, which could be beneficial for workers relocating to the city as they have more time to find a home. However, this could also be a sign of a weakening demand for housing.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Milwaukee-Waukesha ranks in the 30th percentile, with a composite score of 1.94. This indicates a relatively shallow talent pool, making the city less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies. However, the city may be more suitable for businesses with industrial or logistics-dominated economies.

The Milwaukee-Waukesha metro area offers businesses a relatively slow-growing labor market with moderate hiring challenges. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses in this city is the potential for affordability concerns and a tightening housing supply, which could impact their ability to attract and retain talent.

Riverside

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario

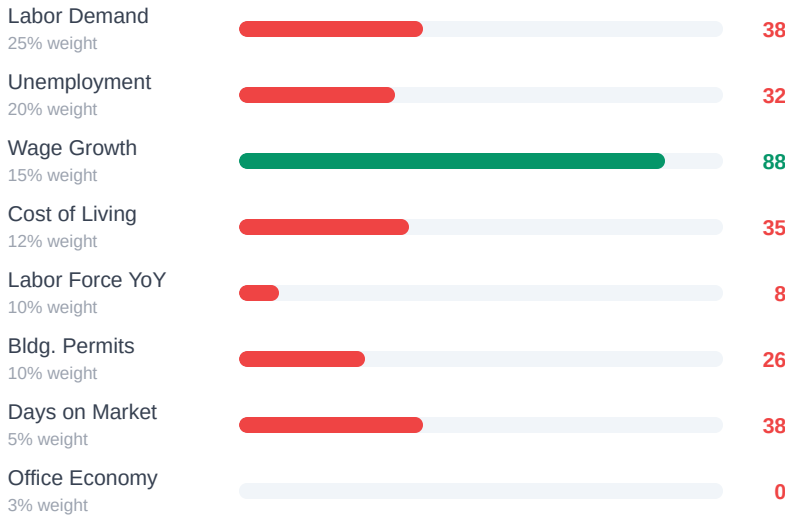
C+

POOR

38.6th percentile

Rank 39 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

5.3%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+6.0%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.8%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-1.9%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-13.3%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

61 days

median, -1.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 38.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its below-average labor demand, with an employment growth rate of +0.79% and weekly hours deviation of -0.845%, and its strong wage growth of +6.02% year-over-year. These metrics signal a mixed economic environment, with some positive trends but also areas of concern.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.79% and weekly hours deviation of -0.845% combine to signal a labor market that is not experiencing genuine demand expansion. This suggests that while some jobs are being added, the hours worked are below trend, indicating a potential survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This mixed signal warrants caution for businesses considering location decisions.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 5.30% indicates a labor market with some slack, ranking below average at the 32nd percentile. This means that businesses may find it relatively easier to hire in this market, but may also face weaker local consumer demand. The practical implication is that companies may need to balance the benefits of a slightly looser labor market with the potential drawbacks of lower consumer spending power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +6.02% is strong, ranking in the top tier at the 88th percentile. This signals rising labor costs for employers, but also good news for worker purchasing power. As wages continue to grow, businesses may need to factor in increasing labor costs, but may also benefit from a more affluent local consumer base.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is below average, with a percentile rank of 35th, and a PSF to earnings ratio of \$333/sqft to \$35.60/hr, or 9.35. The fact that PSF is falling -1.8% year-over-year is a key driver of this affordability score. This means that the city may have a talent attraction advantage, as workers may be drawn to the area's relatively lower cost of living without requiring wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is contracting at a rate of -1.87% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile. This signals a shrinking labor pool, which may pose a structural headwind for hiring in the future. Businesses may need to consider strategies to attract

and retain talent in a market with a declining labor force.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -13.30%, indicating a tightening of housing supply. This signals a potential future affordability challenge and may make it more difficult for workers to relocate to the area. As housing supply continues to contract, businesses may need to factor in the potential impacts on workforce accommodation and talent attraction.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 61 days, with a year-over-year direction of -1.6%. This suggests a relatively fast-moving market, which may make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. However, the slight decrease in days on market may indicate a healthy normalization of the market, rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

The professional talent pool in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is relatively shallow, ranking in the bottom tier at the 0th percentile. This means that the city may be less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies. However, the area may be more attractive to industries with fewer specialized roles, such as logistics or manufacturing.

The Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario metro area offers a mixed economic environment, with strong wage growth but also concerns around labor demand and labor force contraction. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering this location is the potential future affordability challenge posed by a tightening housing supply, which may impact workforce accommodation and talent attraction.

San Antonio

San Antonio-New Braunfels

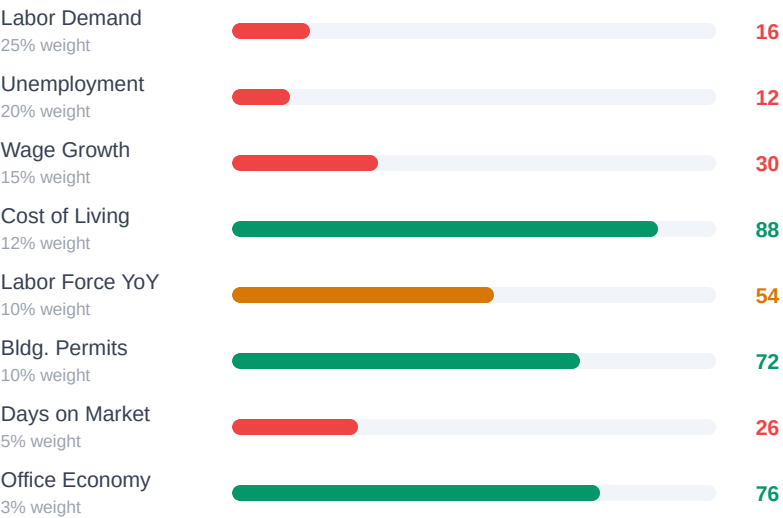
C

VERY POOR

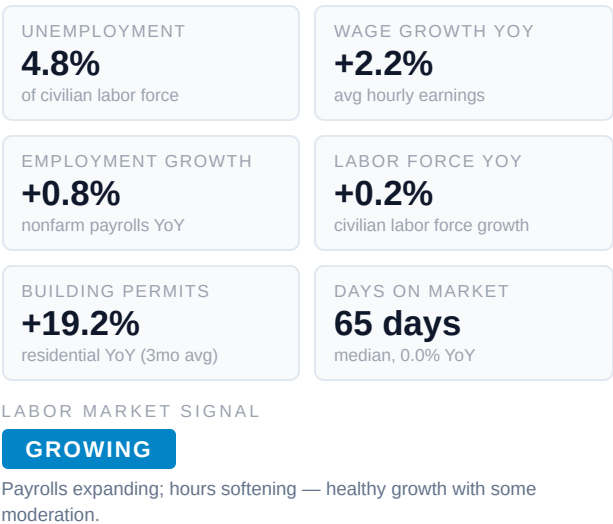
37.6th percentile

Rank 40 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Antonio-New Braunfels metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 37.6th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score defined largely by its low labor demand and high cost of living affordability. The labor demand composite score of 3.99, combining a +0.85% employment growth rate and a -1.731% weekly hours deviation, signals a weak labor market. The cost of living, with a PSF of \$172/sqft and a ratio of 5.30 to hourly earnings of \$32.47, ranks in the top tier at the 88th percentile.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.85% and weekly hours deviation of -1.731% indicate a labor market that is not experiencing genuine demand expansion, as hours are running below trend despite some job growth. This combination suggests that the labor market is not particularly strong, with potential for a survivor squeeze where remaining workers absorb the load of eliminated roles. The labor demand composite score of 3.99 falls in the bottom tier, at the 16th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.80% is relatively high, ranking in the bottom tier at the 12th percentile, indicating a labor market with some slack. This means that businesses may find it easier to hire in this market, but may also face weaker local consumer demand. The relatively high unemployment rate suggests that the market is not tight, giving employers some leverage in hiring.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +2.20% is below average, ranking at the 30th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace, and worker purchasing power is increasing, but not rapidly. The moderate wage growth may help keep labor costs in check, but may not be sufficient to drive strong consumer demand.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in San Antonio-New Braunfels is relatively affordable, with a PSF of \$172/sqft and a ratio of 5.30 to hourly earnings of \$32.47, ranking in the top tier at the 88th percentile. This affordability is driven by a -4.4% year-over-year decrease in PSF, making the city more attractive for talent without requiring wage premiums. The high affordability score is a significant advantage for businesses looking to attract and retain workers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of +0.23% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 54th percentile, indicating a slowly expanding workforce supply. This moderate growth rate suggests that hiring capacity is increasing, but at a slow pace, which may not keep

up with rapid business expansion. The labor force growth rate is not a significant constraint, but may not be sufficient to support rapid growth.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is +19.22%, ranking above average at the 72nd percentile, indicating an expanding housing supply. This increase in permits suggests that developer confidence is strong, and future housing supply is likely to improve, making the city more attractive for workers and helping to keep affordability in check. The rising permits are a positive signal for future workforce accommodation.

Days on Market

The median days on market is 65 days, with a year-over-year change of +0.0%, ranking below average at the 26th percentile. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, where homes are selling quickly, making it competitive for relocating workers to find housing. The low days on market percentile suggests that the market is hot, and workers may face challenges in finding affordable housing.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers is 3.22, ranking above average at the 76th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. The city's office economy is well-suited for businesses that require specialized knowledge workers, but may not be as attractive for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses. The strong office economy is a significant advantage for businesses looking to tap into a skilled workforce.

The San Antonio-New Braunfels metro area offers businesses a unique combination of affordability and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for businesses that require specialized knowledge workers. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the weak labor demand, which may limit the city's ability to support rapid business expansion and require careful planning to attract and retain workers.

Portland

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro

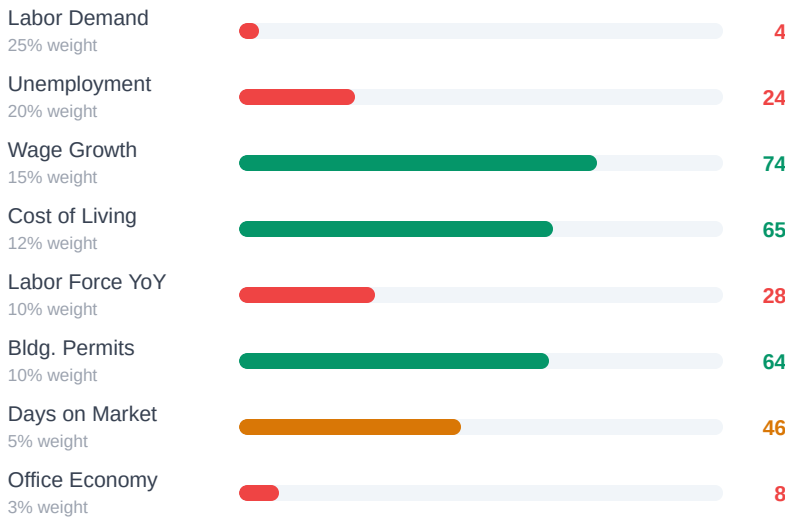
C

VERY POOR

36.5th percentile

Rank 41 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

5.0%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+5.3%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-1.4%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-0.8%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

+12.6%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

57 days
median, +3.6% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

WEAK

Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 36.5th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score largely defined by its weak labor demand and limited office economy. The labor demand composite score of 2.28, combining a -1.44% employment growth rate and a -0.393% weekly hours deviation from trend, suggests a contraction in job opportunities. Additionally, the office/professional worker share is at the bottom tier, ranking 8th percentile.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is -1.44% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.393% from the city's own 12-month baseline, indicating a contraction in labor demand. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion, with hours below trend during a period of job losses, suggesting a survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This scenario points to a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or hire.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is 5.00%, ranking at the 24th percentile, which indicates a market with some slack but not excessively loose. For a business trying to hire, this means there is a pool of available workers, but the market is not so tight that it would drive up wages significantly due to intense competition for labor.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is +5.27%, placing it at the 74th percentile, which is above average. This rate of wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but it also means that workers have increasing purchasing power, which can be beneficial for local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro has a cost of living score that ranks at the 65th percentile, with a PSF of \$306/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$42.18/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.25. The PSF is falling by -2.2% year-over-year, which is a key driver of its above-average affordability score. This makes the city more attractive for talent without needing significant wage premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is growing at a rate of -0.81% year-over-year, indicating a contraction in the labor force supply. This implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of potential workers is shrinking, making it more challenging for businesses to find and recruit talent.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro has increased by +12.62% year-over-year, signaling an expansion in future housing supply. This growth in building permits suggests that developer confidence is strong, and the city is likely to see improvements in affordability and an easier time accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

Homes in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro are currently sitting on the market for a median of 57 days, with a year-over-year increase of +3.6%. This indicates a market that is normalizing, becoming slightly less competitive for buyers. For a worker relocating to this city, the housing market is becoming more accessible, with less pressure to act quickly on a purchase.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro ranks at the 8th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these areas. This makes the city less suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, or those looking to establish a headquarters, but it may be more appropriate for industries with different labor requirements.

The Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area offers a mix of above-average wage growth and improving affordability, which could attract talent and support local consumer demand. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for a business considering this location is the weak labor demand and contracting labor force, which could significantly hinder hiring and expansion plans.

Minneapolis

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington

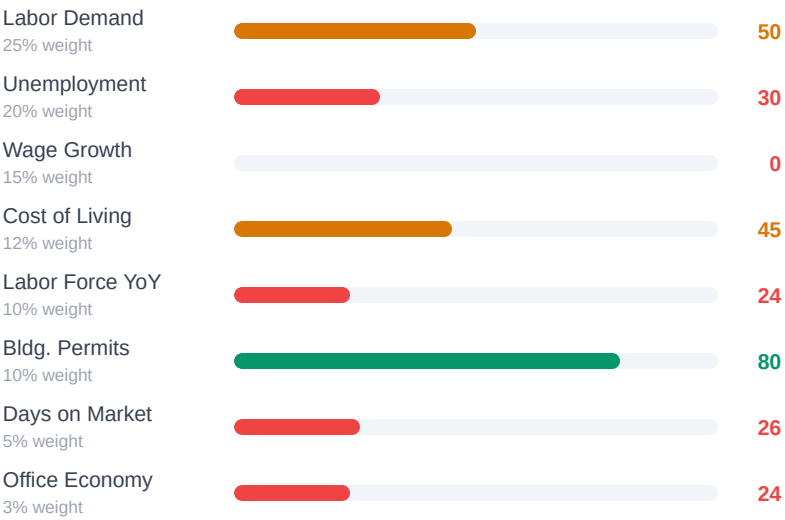
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VERY POOR

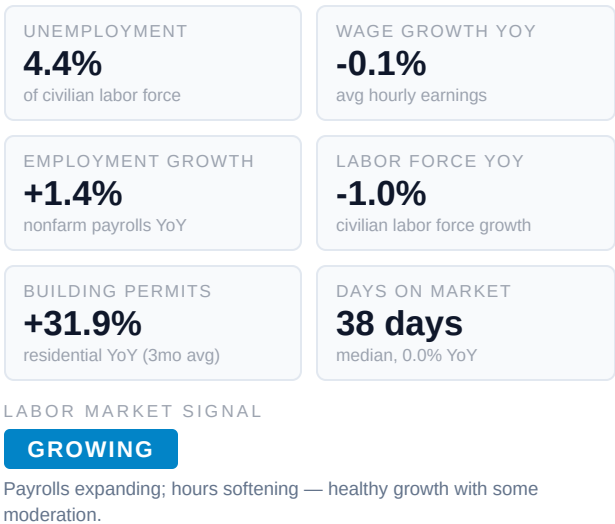
36.3th percentile

Rank 42 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 36.3th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score reflecting a mix of mediocre labor demand and cost of living. The city's economic character is most defined by its near-median labor demand composite score of 5.31 and its bottom-tier wage growth of -0.14% year-over-year. These metrics suggest a city with limited job market momentum and stagnant wages.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is +1.36% year-over-year, while weekly hours are -0.894% below the city's own trend. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion, as the modest job growth is not accompanied by increased hours worked, suggesting some level of labor market slack. The labor demand composite score of 5.31 is near the median, indicating a neutral labor market condition.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is 4.40%, ranking below average at the 30th percentile. This indicates a labor market with some slack, making it relatively easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, the practical implication is that local consumer demand may be weaker due to the higher unemployment rate.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is -0.14%, ranking at the bottom tier. This stagnant wage growth signals a flat labor cost environment for employers, but it also means weak bargaining power for workers and limited growth in worker purchasing power. The implication is that businesses may not face significant wage pressure, but the local workforce may not have strong disposable income.

Cost of Living

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington has a cost of living ratio of \$208/sqft to \$40.22/hr, with a percentile rank of 45th, indicating a near-median affordability level. The city's PSF is falling by -1.9% year-over-year, which is a positive factor for affordability. This means that the city may not have a significant talent attraction advantage without offering wage premiums, as its affordability is average compared to peers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is contracting at a rate of -0.97% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 24th percentile. This indicates a shrinking labor pool, which poses a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion in the city. The

implication is that businesses may face challenges in finding and retaining talent in the long term.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is +31.92%, ranking at the top tier. This significant increase in permits signals an expansion in future housing supply, which should improve affordability and accommodate workforce growth. The implication is that the city is likely to become more attractive for relocating workers and businesses due to the anticipated improvement in housing affordability.

Days on Market

The current median days on market for homes in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is 38 days, with a year-over-year change of +0.0%, ranking below average at the 26th percentile. This indicates a relatively fast-paced housing market, which may be competitive for relocating workers. The implication is that businesses may need to consider the potential challenges their employees could face in finding and securing housing in the city.

Office Economy

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington has an office economy percentile rank of 24th, indicating a relatively shallow professional talent pool. The city is less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but may be more appropriate for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses. The implication is that businesses with specialized office sector needs may find the city less attractive due to its limited talent pool.

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area offers businesses a mix of average affordability and a relatively slack labor market, but the single biggest risk or constraint is the stagnant wage growth and shrinking labor force, which may limit the city's attractiveness for businesses requiring a skilled and growing workforce. The city's expanding housing supply is a positive factor, but the competitive housing market and limited office economy talent pool are drawbacks that decision-makers should carefully consider. Overall, the city's mediocre economic character suggests that businesses should weigh these factors carefully before making a location decision.

Indianapolis

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood

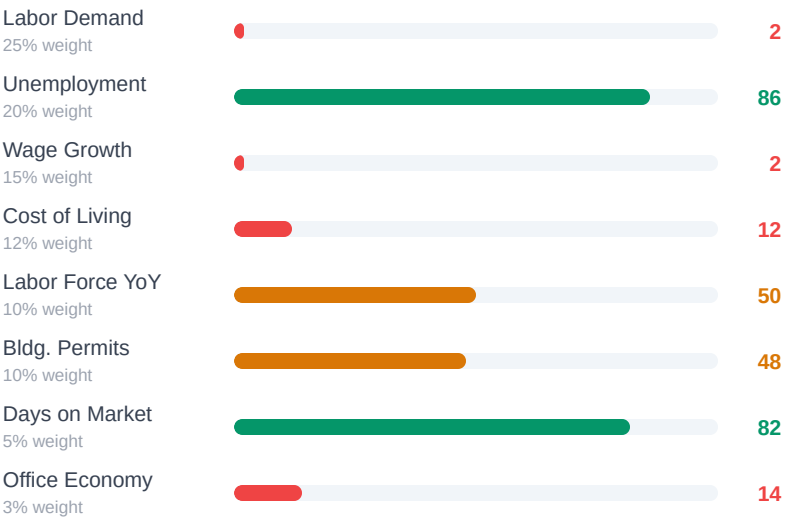
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VERY POOR

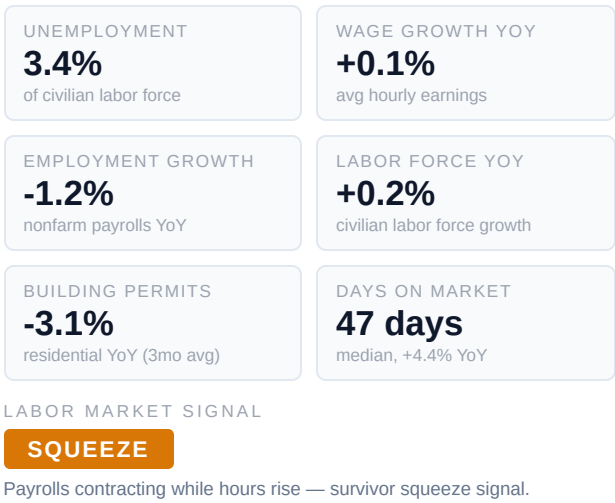
33.8th percentile

Rank 43 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 33.8th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score largely defined by its low labor demand and stagnant wage growth, at 2.22 and +0.09% respectively. The labor demand composite score of 2.22, combining a -1.17% employment growth rate and a +0.446% weekly hours deviation, signals a contraction in labor demand. This, coupled with the low wage growth, characterizes the city's current economic challenges.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is -1.17% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating +0.446% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a labor market contraction rather than genuine demand expansion, as hours are slightly above trend during a period of job losses, indicating a survivor squeeze. This scenario suggests that remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is 3.40%, ranking in the top tier at the 86th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with low unemployment. This tight market implies that it may be harder for businesses to hire, with more wage pressure, as the low supply of available workers gives them greater bargaining power. For a business trying to hire in this market, attracting and retaining talent may require offering competitive wages and benefits.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is +0.09%, placing it in the bottom tier. This stagnant wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are not rising significantly, but it also means that worker purchasing power is not increasing substantially. The slow wage growth may attract businesses looking for a flat cost environment, but it could also indicate weak bargaining power for workers.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$166/sqft to \$33.45/hr, and a year-over-year increase of 4.4% in PSF, Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood ranks in the bottom tier at the 12th percentile for affordability. This means the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which could make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The rising PSF relative to wages is the key driver of its low affordability score.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is growing at a rate of +0.22% year-over-year, which is near the median. This slight expansion in labor force supply suggests that the hiring capacity is not significantly constrained by a shrinking workforce, offering a modest advantage for businesses looking to recruit new talent.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits is -3.15%, indicating a slight tightening in housing supply. Although this decrease is not sharp, it signals that the future affordability and workforce accommodation might face some challenges, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with potential demand.

Days on Market

The current median days on market for homes in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is 47 days, with a year-over-year increase of 4.4%. This increase in days on market, ranking in the top tier at the 82nd percentile, suggests a slower market where homes are sitting longer before being sold. For a worker relocating to this city, this could mean a more accessible and less competitive housing market.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is relatively low, ranking in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile. This indicates a less deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, or HQ decisions, making the city more suitable for industries that are less dependent on a professional and office-based workforce.

In conclusion, Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood offers a business environment with a tight labor market and relatively low wage growth, which could attract businesses seeking to minimize labor cost increases but may face challenges in hiring due to low unemployment. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the city's relatively expensive cost of living, which could necessitate wage premiums to attract and retain talent, potentially offsetting the benefits of low wage growth.

Jacksonville

Jacksonville

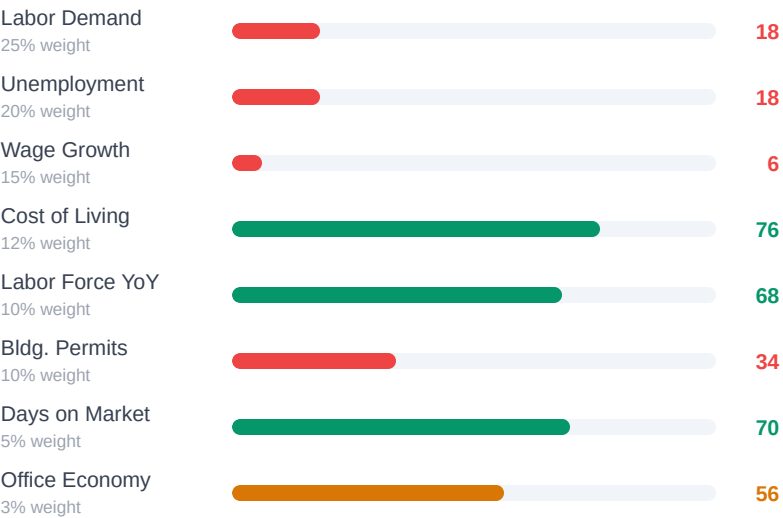
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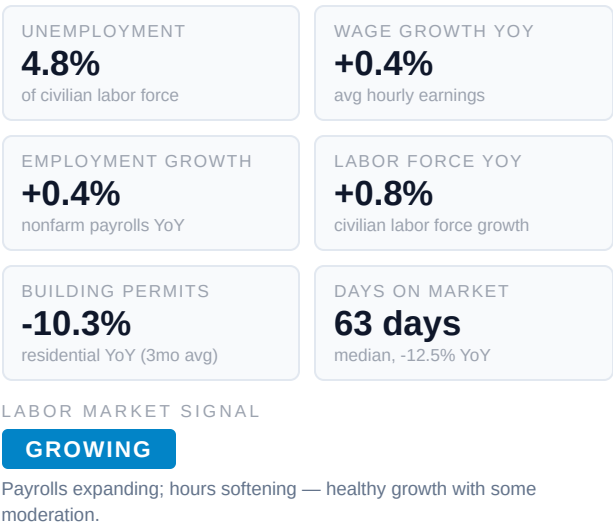
33.4th percentile

Rank 44 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Jacksonville has an overall grade of C, ranking 33.4th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 4.01, which is in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand and stagnant wage growth, with employment growth at +0.36% year-over-year and weekly hours deviating -0.794% from its own trend. These metrics signal a lack of genuine demand expansion in the labor market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.36% year-over-year, combined with weekly hours deviating -0.794% from its own trend, signals a contraction in labor demand. This indicates that the city is not experiencing genuine demand expansion, but rather a potential survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. The low labor demand composite score of 4.01 further reinforces this notion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Jacksonville is 4.80%, which is in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile, indicating a relatively high level of unemployment. This suggests that the market has some slack, making it easier for businesses to hire, but also potentially weakening local consumer demand. As a result, businesses may find it relatively easier to staff their operations, but may also face weaker demand for their products or services.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Jacksonville is +0.39%, which is in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth means that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also implies weak bargaining power for workers and potentially limited purchasing power. As a result, businesses may not face significant pressure to increase wages, but workers may not have the disposable income to drive local economic growth.

Cost of Living

Jacksonville has a cost of living percentile rank of 76th, with a PSF of \$216/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$36.85/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.86. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers. The fact that PSF is falling by -3.1% year-over-year further reinforces the city's affordability. This makes Jacksonville an attractive location for talent, as businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to compensate for a high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Jacksonville is growing at a rate of +0.78% year-over-year, which is above average at the 68th percentile. This indicates that the labor force supply is expanding, providing businesses with a growing pool of potential workers to hire from. As a result, businesses may find it easier to attract and retain talent in the city.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Jacksonville is decreasing by -10.28% year-over-year, which is below average at the 34th percentile. This suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for workforce accommodation in the future. As a result, businesses may need to consider the potential impact of a tightening housing market on their ability to attract and retain workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Jacksonville is 63 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -12.5%, resulting in an above-average percentile rank of 70th. This indicates that the housing market is relatively fast-paced, making it potentially competitive for workers relocating to the city. However, the decreasing days on market also suggests that the market is still relatively accessible, with homes selling relatively quickly.

Office Economy

Jacksonville has an office economy percentile rank of 56th, with a share of professional and office workers at 2.74 out of 5. This indicates that the city has a relatively deep talent pool in professional and office sectors, making it suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. However, the city may be less suited for businesses in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors.

In conclusion, Jacksonville offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and an expanding labor force, but also presents challenges such as low labor demand and stagnant wage growth. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering locating in Jacksonville is the potential for a tightening housing market, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for workforce accommodation.

Richmond

Richmond

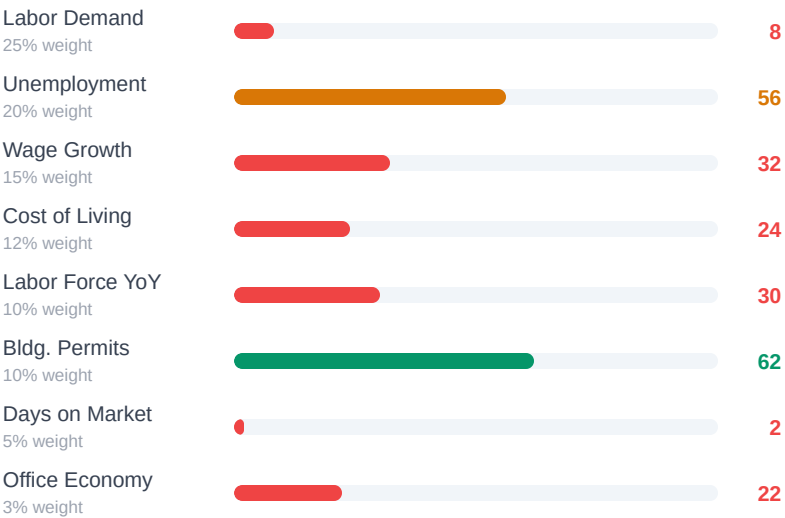
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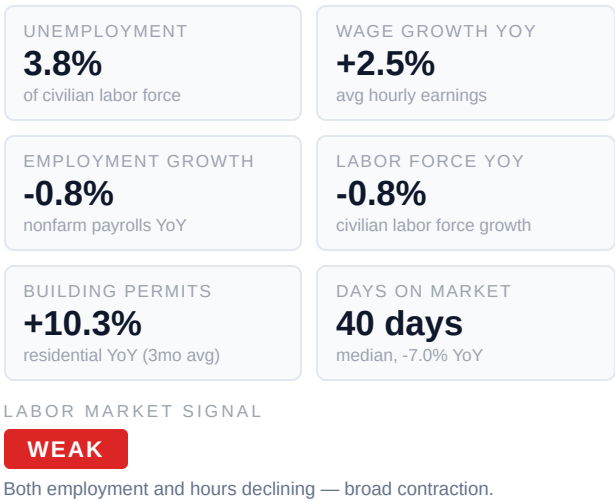
30.9th percentile

Rank 45 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Richmond metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 30.9th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score of 3.24 ranking in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile, and its below-average wage growth of +2.49% year-over-year. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Richmond is -0.76% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.415% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job creation and hours worked. This suggests a lack of genuine demand expansion, which could impact businesses' ability to find and retain talent.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Richmond is 3.80%, ranking near the median at the 56th percentile. This indicates a relatively balanced labor market with some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, this also means that local consumer demand may not be as strong as in areas with lower unemployment rates.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Richmond is +2.49%, ranking below average at the 32nd percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace than in many other cities. While this may be beneficial for workers' purchasing power, it also means that businesses may face increasing labor costs without corresponding productivity gains.

Cost of Living

Richmond has a cost of living score ranking in the 24th percentile, with a PSF of \$229/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$35.92/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.38. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which could make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The fact that PSF is rising 1.8% year-over-year further exacerbates the affordability issue.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Richmond is contracting at a rate of -0.80% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 30th percentile. This decline in labor force supply signals a structural headwind for hiring, making it more difficult for businesses to find and retain workers. This could lead to increased competition for talent and upward pressure on wages.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Richmond is increasing by 10.33% year-over-year, ranking above average at the 62nd percentile. This expansion in housing supply is a positive sign for future affordability and workforce accommodation, suggesting that the city may become more attractive to relocating workers and businesses in the long term.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Richmond is currently 40 days, with a year-over-year decline of -7.0%. This rapid pace of home sales indicates a competitive market, which could make it challenging for relocating workers to find affordable housing. The low percentile rank of 2nd percentile further emphasizes the fast-paced nature of the local real estate market.

Office Economy

Richmond's professional and office worker share ranks below average at the 22nd percentile, with a composite score of 1.74. This suggests that the city has a relatively shallow talent pool in professional and office sectors, making it less suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, or HQ decisions. However, it may be more suitable for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

In conclusion, Richmond offers a mixed bag for businesses, with some positive signs such as expanding housing supply, but also significant challenges like low labor demand and a contracting labor force. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's relatively expensive cost of living and competitive housing market, which could make it difficult to attract and retain talent without offering significant wage premiums.

Detroit

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn

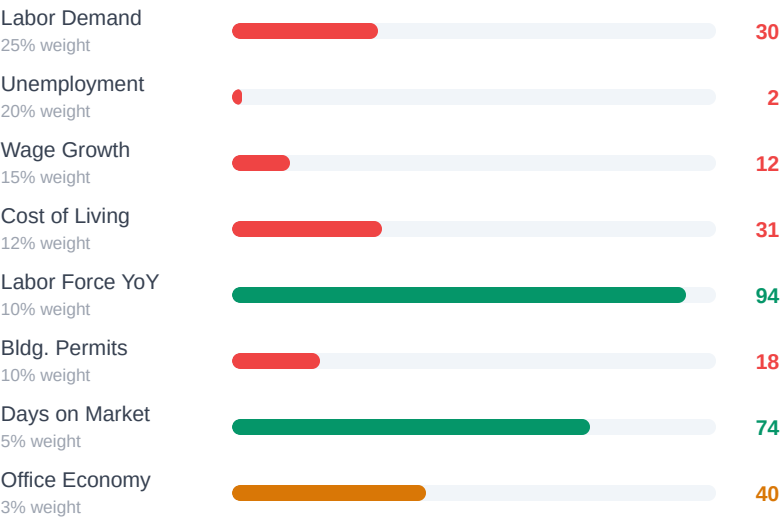
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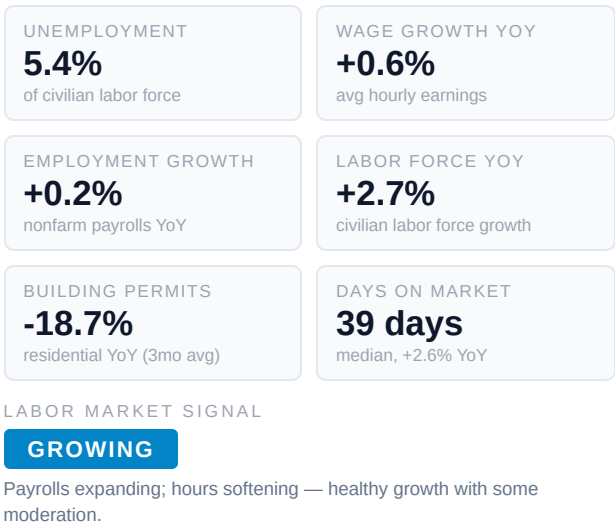
29.5th percentile

Rank 46 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Detroit-Warren-Dearborn metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 29.5th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 5.40% and its sluggish labor demand composite score of 4.43, which ranks in the 30th percentile. These metrics suggest a challenging hiring environment with limited job growth.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is a modest +0.16% year-over-year, while weekly hours are running -0.098% below trend. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion, as hours are not increasing despite some job growth, indicating a potential survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is 5.40%, ranking in the 2nd percentile, indicating a very tight labor market with significant slack. For a business trying to hire in this city, the low unemployment rate means it will be harder to find and recruit talent, and may lead to upward pressure on wages.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is +0.60%, ranking in the 12th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth means labor costs for employers will remain relatively flat, but workers will have weak bargaining power and limited purchasing power.

Cost of Living

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn has a cost of living score ranking it in the 31st percentile, with a PSF of \$186/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$36.68/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.07. This suggests the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The modest affordability means businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract talent, as the city's cost of living is not a significant draw.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is growing at a rate of +2.68% year-over-year, ranking in the 94th percentile. This rapid expansion of the labor force means the supply of workers is increasing, which should ease hiring capacity and provide a larger talent pool for businesses to draw from.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn has decreased by -18.71% year-over-year, ranking in the 18th percentile. This decline in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for

workforce accommodation in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is currently 39 days, with a year-over-year increase of +2.6%, ranking in the 74th percentile. This indicates a relatively slow market, which should make it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing, as homes are sitting on the market for a longer period.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn ranks in the 40th percentile, indicating a moderately deep talent pool. This city is best suited for businesses that can leverage its existing industrial and logistics expertise, but may not be the ideal location for tech, finance, or consulting firms that require a more specialized knowledge-economy talent pool.

The Detroit-Warren-Dearborn metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market and a rapidly expanding labor force, but the single biggest risk or constraint is the potential for decreased affordability and increased competition for workforce accommodation due to the decline in building permits. Decision-makers should carefully weigh these factors when considering a location decision in this city.

Sacramento

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom

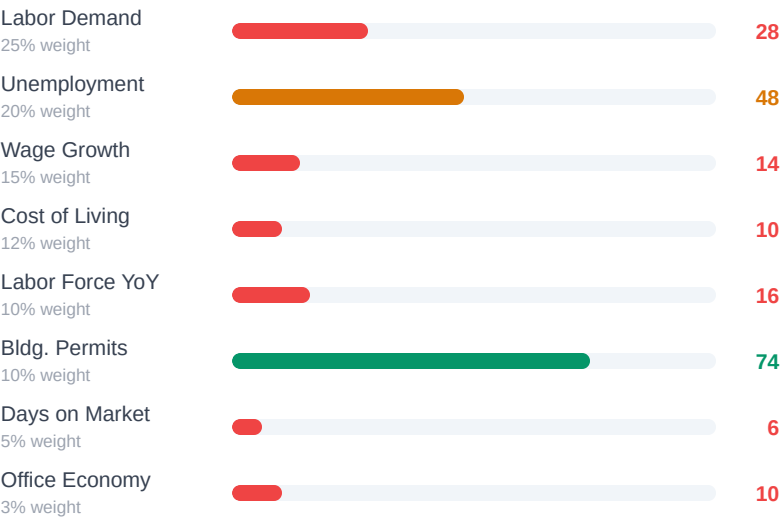
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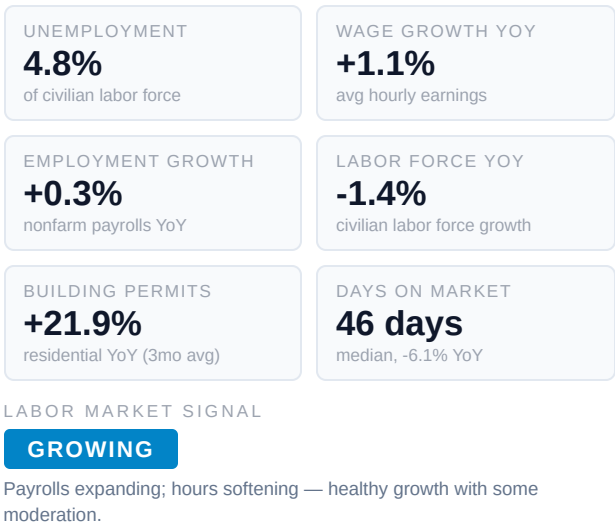
29.5th percentile

Rank 47 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it at the 29.5th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score of 4.32, and its high cost of living, with a ratio of \$344/sqft to \$38.15/hr, resulting in a bottom-tier percentile rank of 10th. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is +0.34% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.457% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not experiencing genuine demand expansion. The low labor demand composite score of 4.32 further reinforces this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is 4.80%, ranking near the median at the 48th percentile. This rate suggests that the market has some slack, making it slightly easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter labor markets. However, the relatively moderate unemployment rate may not provide a significant advantage in terms of hiring capacity.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is +1.05%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile. This slow wage growth signals a relatively flat cost environment for employers, but it also indicates weak bargaining power for workers. As a result, businesses may not face significant pressure to increase wages, but workers may not have strong purchasing power.

Cost of Living

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom has a cost of living ratio of \$344/sqft to \$38.15/hr, resulting in a bottom-tier percentile rank of 10th. This means that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, making it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The high cost of living may be a significant constraint for businesses looking to relocate or expand in the area.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is contracting at a rate of -1.39% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile. This decline in labor force supply signals a structural headwind for hiring, making it more challenging for businesses to find and recruit talent.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom has increased by +21.94% year-over-year, ranking above average at the 74th percentile. This expansion in housing supply signals improving affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce. However, the current cost of living and labor market conditions may still pose challenges.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is 46 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -6.1%. This relatively fast market, ranking in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile, may make it challenging for relocating workers to find and secure housing. The competitive market conditions may require businesses to offer relocation assistance or other incentives to attract talent.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is 0.72, ranking in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile. This indicates a relatively shallow talent pool, making the city less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy workforce, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. The city may be more suitable for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as logistics or manufacturing.

The Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area offers a mixed bag for businesses, with some advantages in terms of moderate unemployment and expanding housing supply. However, the city's high cost of living, slow wage growth, and contracting labor force supply pose significant risks and constraints for businesses looking to relocate or expand in the area. The single biggest risk is the challenging environment for attracting and retaining talent, which may require businesses to offer wage premiums or other incentives to remain competitive.

Grand Rapids

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood

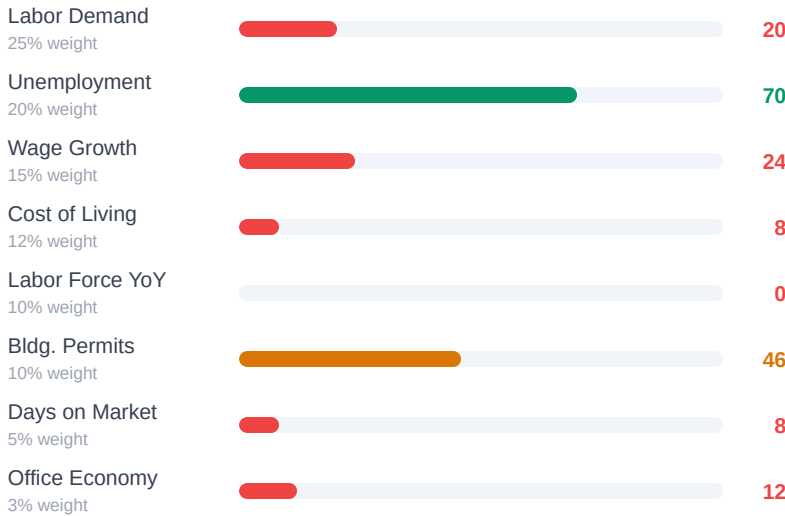
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CRITICAL

28.9th percentile

Rank 48 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.2%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+1.8%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.5%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-8.8%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-3.7%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

37 days

median, -5.1% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 28.9th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score of 4.11, and its high cost of living, with a PSF to wages ratio of 6.79. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to hire and retain talent.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is 0.47% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.851% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not experiencing genuine demand expansion. The low labor demand composite score of 4.11 further reinforces this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is 4.20%, which ranks in the 70th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer higher wages to attract talent. The tight market also implies that workers may have more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is 1.83%, which is below average. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace. Workers in the city may see some increase in their purchasing power, but it may not be sufficient to keep pace with the high cost of living.

Cost of Living

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood has a cost of living score that ranks in the 8th percentile, indicating that it is an expensive city relative to its peers. The PSF to wages ratio of 6.79, with a PSF of \$221/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$32.56, further reinforces this assessment. This means that the city may struggle to attract talent without offering wage premiums to offset the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is contracting at a rate of -8.76% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This decline in labor force growth poses a significant structural headwind for hiring, as businesses may struggle to find qualified workers to fill open positions.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is declining at a rate of -3.73% year-over-year. This decrease in building permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability challenges and make it

more difficult for workers to relocate to the city.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood is 37 days, with a year-over-year decline of -5.1%. This relatively fast pace of home sales may make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing, as the market is competitive.

Office Economy

The professional and office worker share in Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood ranks in the 12th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool. This suggests that the city may be less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies, and more suited for industries with fewer specialized roles.

The Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood metro area offers businesses a relatively tight labor market with moderate wage growth, but it also poses significant challenges, including a high cost of living and a shrinking labor force. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's limited ability to attract and retain talent due to its expensive cost of living and tightening housing supply.

Chicago

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin

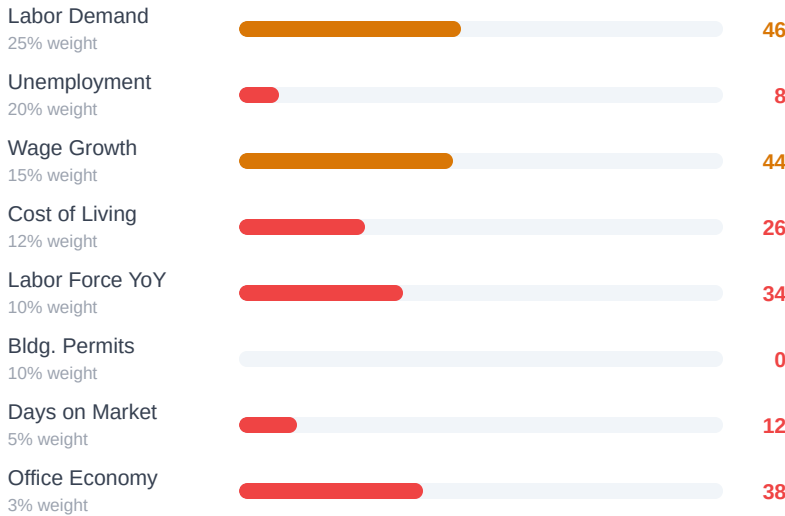
C-

CRITICAL

28.0th percentile

Rank 49 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

5.3%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+3.1%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.2%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-0.5%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-42.4%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

35 days

median, -2.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

STRONG

Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Chicago-Naperville-Elgin metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking at the 28.0th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 5.30% and its stagnant labor force growth rate of -0.53% YoY. The combination of these metrics suggests a tight labor market with limited supply of new workers.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is +0.17% YoY, and weekly hours are deviating +0.674% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. The labor demand composite score of 5.21 ranks near the median at the 46th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is 5.30%, ranking at the 8th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city will face significant competition for workers and may need to offer higher wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate also suggests that there is limited slack in the labor market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is +3.11%, ranking near the median at the 44th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so. At the same time, workers in this city are seeing their purchasing power increase, which can have positive effects on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin has a cost of living score ranking at the 26th percentile, with a PSF of \$221/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$37.34/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.92. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. However, the fact that the PSF is rising YoY at +2.8% suggests that the city's affordability is decreasing over time. This may make it more difficult to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is contracting at a rate of -0.53% YoY. This means that the supply of workers is shrinking, which can create a structural headwind for hiring in this city. Businesses may need to consider alternative locations or strategies to attract workers from other areas.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin has decreased by -42.35% YoY, ranking at the 0th percentile. This sharp decline suggests that housing supply is tightening, which can lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for housing in the future. This may make it more difficult for workers to relocate to this city and for businesses to attract talent.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is 35 days, with a YoY decrease of -2.8%. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, which can make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. The low days on market percentile rank of 12th suggests that the market is highly competitive, and workers may need to act quickly to secure housing.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is 2.22, ranking at the 38th percentile. This suggests that the city has a moderately deep talent pool in these sectors. The city is best suited for businesses that require a mix of professional and office workers, but may not be the best fit for businesses that require a highly specialized or technical workforce.

The Chicago-Naperville-Elgin metro area offers businesses a tight labor market with moderate wage growth, but also presents significant challenges in terms of labor force growth and housing affordability. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering this location is the limited supply of workers and the decreasing affordability of housing, which can make it difficult to attract and retain talent.

Louisville

Louisville-Jefferson County

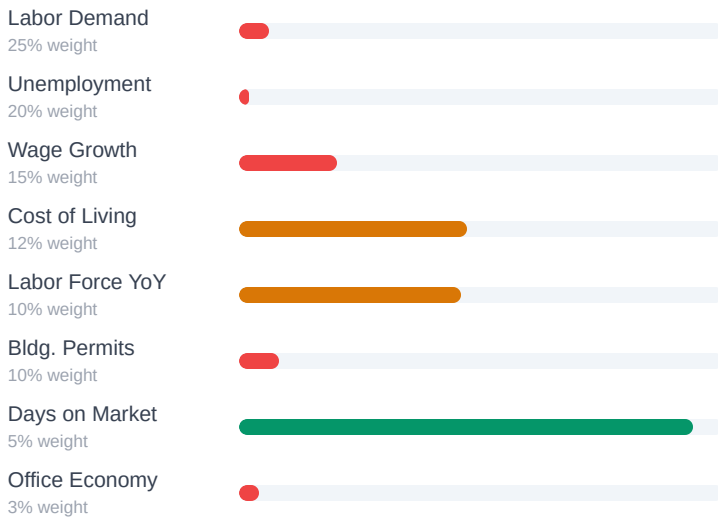
D

EMERGENCY

20.8th percentile

Rank 50 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

5.2%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+1.6%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.1%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

+0.1%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-31.7%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

43 days
median, +10.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Louisville-Jefferson County metro area has an overall grade of D, ranking 20.8th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 2.99. The city's economic character is most defined by its low employment growth rate of -0.07% and high unemployment rate of 5.20%, indicating a challenging labor market. These metrics suggest that the city is experiencing a contraction in labor demand.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of -0.07% and weekly hours deviation of +1.215% signal a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion. This combination indicates that the city is experiencing a decline in job creation, despite workers putting in slightly more hours. This is a concerning sign for businesses looking to expand or relocate to the area.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 5.20% is relatively high, indicating a labor market with some slack. This means that businesses may find it easier to hire workers, but may also face weaker local consumer demand. With an unemployment rate ranking in the 2nd percentile, the market is not tight, and businesses may have an advantage in terms of hiring and wage negotiations.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +1.61% is below average, ranking in the 20th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but worker purchasing power is also not increasing significantly. This may be a concern for businesses looking to attract and retain top talent.

Cost of Living

The city's cost of living, with a PSF of \$178/sqft and an earnings ratio of 5.69, ranks in the 47th percentile, indicating a near-median affordability score. This means that the city is neither extremely affordable nor expensive, and businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to attract talent. However, the stable YoY change in PSF suggests that affordability is not improving.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of +0.08% year-over-year, indicating a slowly expanding workforce supply. This modest growth rate suggests that hiring capacity is not severely constrained, but businesses may still face challenges in finding skilled workers.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -31.66%, indicating a sharp decline in housing supply expansion. This signals that future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 43 days, with a year-over-year increase of +10.3%, ranking in the 94th percentile. This suggests that the housing market is slowing down, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, this may also indicate a weakening demand for housing.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers is 0.38, ranking in the 4th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool. This suggests that the city is not well-suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies. Instead, the city may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Louisville-Jefferson County metro area offers businesses a labor market with some slack and moderate wage growth, but also faces challenges such as low employment growth and a declining housing supply. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's low labor demand and limited talent pool, which may make it difficult to attract and retain skilled workers.